Where it started...

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/34723426.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Melog (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Exes, Enemies to Friends to Lovers, Enemies to Lovers, Disability, Deaf, Hearing Loss, Trauma, Canon Lesbian Relationship, Useless Lesbians, Lesbian Catra (She-Ra), Lesbian Adora (She-Ra), Lesbian Disaster Adora (She-Ra), Lesbian Disaster Catra (She-Ra), Reconciliation, Adultery, Soft Butch Adora, Adora Has Issues (She-Ra), Human Catra (She-Ra), POV Catra (She-Ra), POV Adora (She-Ra), Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Alternate Universe - Human, She Ra - Freeform

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Iorek's Catradora Unputdownables

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Where it started...

by thedeafpomegranate

Summary

Catra's finally settled, six long years after she was abandoned at her lowest by the person she never expected to lose. But when a shadow from her past returns, her entire life uproots itself before she can even blink.

Bright Moon restaurant AU where hard of hearing advertising executive Catra becomes a thoroughly useless lesbian who can't cope for shit when Adora Gray suddenly appears back in town as a waiter at her local spot.

Chapter 1

Chapter Notes

> Here we go again!I thought it was time to get back on the writing horse, and find a new story to bring these wonderful characters to life again.
>
> I have an outline for the first few chapters and it likely won't be as long as the last fic was... I'd also say it's prob not going to be quite as trauma heavy , but hey ho, I say that now but who knows!?
>
> I would love to hear what you guys think - reading comments and getting feedback is genuinely always the highlight of writing :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra cleared her throat, doing her best to ignore the headache that she could tell was already starting to pulse behind her left eye socket. She fumbled in her pocket as discreetly as she could, searching for her emergency pills while pretending she was still listening. Her back straightened a little in panic as she fished for the plastic, only to feel that all the capsules were gone already, her fingertip tracing the edges of torn foil. She cursed herself internally, suppressing the groan that threatened to seep through her lips.

Oh, for fuck's sake…

"You alright, babe?"

Catra startled at the question, blinking as she refocused her attention on the woman in front of her. She slumped a little, nodding softly as she squeezed her girlfriend's hand on the tabletop. Even two years down the line, Catra was still working on being openly vulnerable and letting the blonde in when everything became too much.

"Mmm, I just. I forgot my back-up meds."

"Problem solved, Cat," her blue eyes sparkled as she dipped into her own pockets, withdrawing her hand for a quick moment to pull a bright pink and yellow box out of her jacket, "I got you."

Catra could feel a swell building in her chest, one she only ever used to feel when - *don't think about that, not now.* She took the pills, letting her fingers linger a little on the back of a smooth hand before she swallowed a bright pink pill dry, taking the glass of water held out kindly in front of her to ease its uncomfortable roughness as it slid down her throat.

"How do you even know which ones I buy?"

"You're welcome," Catra blushed as she realised she hadn't even thanked her partner, "And funnily enough, when you've lived with someone for eight months, you tend to pick these things up."

They both chuckled and Catra took the warm hand laid on the table back into her palm, raising it to press soft kisses to worn knuckles and thick silver rings. She didn't know why it made so little sense to her, that she'd be deserving of such attentive love. There were so many ways it played out on a daily basis that she struggled to understand - the way she'd be allowed to watch as long, blonde hair swept over bare muscled shoulders, how strong arms wrapped around her waist to help her rise up those extra few inches on her toes as they kissed, and why she never had to do the washing up after she'd cooked, even when they'd had people over for dinner and there was more to clean than there was space for on the drying rack.

"Thanks. Really."

"We can go somewhere else a bit quieter if you want, it's gotten pretty dark here now. Can you-"

"I'm fine, honestly. Let's just enjoy ourselves, hmm?"

Blue eyes met her own mismatched irises, searching for hidden discomfort. "Are you sure? W e can ask them to box dessert up to go?"

"No," Catra forced a smile onto her face, hoping she'd managed to convey enough warmth and satisfaction to put an end to the conversation, "I want to be here, it' s our anniversary. I can do it."

"Okay ," Catra hated the doubtful tone of the response, struggling to push painful memories of having to convince others - *well, a certain someone* - over and over again that she really could cope, and that she wasn't going to let the shitty inaccessibility of the world break her, "W e can leave if you change your mind."

Catra nodded, taking a long sip of her red wine. It drove her mad, the zig-zag of wanting so much for everything to be easier but watching herself refuse help. It should be simple - the logic of asking or demanding was clear as day. Nevertheless, she hadn't gotten a handle on it ever since she woke up that bewildering morning, suddenly stuck in a world so much less clear than it had been the night before.

She leaned back in her chair, twirling the stem of her near-empty glass between her fingers and surveying the view. There were few people in the world as beautiful as the woman in front of her, and she looked even prettier against the twinkling backdrop of the restaurant's indoor foliage and fairy lights. It almost made all the background noise, heightened through her hearing aid and burning into her brain, completely and utterly worth it. Catra could barely drag her eyes away from pink lips, irresistible and slightly parted, when the sudden presence of a waiter at their table surprised her. It had become second nature, almost, the alarm that swept through her body when she hadn't heard someone coming up behind her; when all of a sudden, there was someone right next to you, talking to you, who you were never expecting.

"Oops, sorry , didn't mean to make you jump there!"

Catra froze as the waiter's friendly voice seeped into her skin, ignoring the long-awaited chocolate fondant set down in front of her. She tipped her head backwards as she drained her glass, focused only on steadying her nerves, and praying that she hadn't been properly noticed.

"Enjoy! Is there anything else I can get for you?"

Catra stayed silent, lowering her glass to the table heavily as if any swift move taken would have catastrophic effect. She peered up at her girlfriend, hoping she'd notice her expression was different to her frequent request for a repeat, and that she'd realise all Catra actually wanted was to get out of the interaction, stat.

No such luck.

"Can you repeat that, please? You were facing me but my girlfriend needs to-"

"Lipread." Catra's lungs seized at the interruption, realising that the waiter very much recognised her and knew exactly what she needed. She kept her eyes downcast, determined not to deal with how it would feel to look at the newcomer again, for the first time in all these years. "Catra? Is that really you?"

It was no use. Catra raised her eyes slowly past her girlfriend's confused expression, straightening up. If she was going to go through with this, at least she'd make sure that no-one saw her falter. She hadn't worn her new corseted bustier top that evening with the intention of attracting any new attention, but maybe it had always been destined for revenge. Emerald green, perfect for inciting jealousy.

"Eve," Catra addressed her girlfriend, anticipating the sharpness of the dagger she was about to draw, "she's just an old friend."

Finally turning towards the woman she'd simultaneously hated and tried not to love for six long years, Catra miraculously managed to

stop her breath from hitching. She'd rehearsed what she wanted to say to her ex-girlfriend so many times in her head, always cutting her mirror soliloquies bitterly short once she'd convinced herself that she'd likely never see this woman ever again. They'd both made sure of that, and Catra's heart had been broken irrevocably, right when she was at her very lowest. She'd never forgive her ex for that - but now, she had a chance to have her say.

Catra picked up her fork, pressing it into the cake and letting molten chocolate ooze all over the metal sporks, knowing the action would trigger countless memories.

Let her remember what she walked away from. Who she gave up on.

She licked her lips, blowing softly before she took her first mouthful, soft and slow. It was time to speak, and there's only one way she'd ever greet this woman;she'd always loved how powerful it made her feel, to see the woman before her tremble - sometimes in awe and lust, other times in nervousness.

Catra spoke with long-lost confidence, ensuring her voice was just as silky smooth as the chocolate she'd licked from her lips.

"Hey , Adora."

Chapter End Notes

There we go... a short beginning but plenty more is to come. Let me know what you think!

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

The hours after that accidental reunion...

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Cold air from the AC pushed against the back of Adora's neck but it still didn't relieve the hot flush that had spread across her chest and up to her scalp. She'd spent the past two hours negotiating with her own body to no avail, begging her heart to stop beating so fast. Her mind was flooding with memories that she'd wilfully ignored for years, a dam of half-forgotten scenes bursting before Adora's eyes.

She should have known it would happen eventually, though she'd hoped it wouldn't come so quick. Deciding to return home was difficult enough even without the dread that history would hurt when it inevitably slammed into her - and slam it did.

Adora had almost done a double take when she'd taken over her section halfway through a shift, clocking in last minute when her colleague started feeling ill. She'd laughed at her own hypersensitivity when she noticed a familiar looking couple out of the corner of her eye. An athletic blonde with her hair swinging behind her in a high ponytail, red silk criss-crossing behind her neck and exposing her muscular shoulder blades, reminded Adora of another version of herself - an Adora she might have become if everything had worked out the way she once thought it would. It was almost as if this woman was an improved update of her, dressed in luxurious fabrics and with far better acumen for applying softened eyeliner, small flicks placed perfectly parallel on both sides, their clean precision visible even from afar. What's more, Adora had also spotted that the woman's date had thick brown hair, so eerily similar to the wild curls that Adora had woven around her fingers and

nestled her face into so many times;it felt like the universe was playing an unholy trick on her.

Adora could have brushed the whole thing off if the chef hadnt called her over to the pass to pick up dessert orders - despite the fact that Thaymor Bistro was renowned for its towering slices of lemon meringue pie, the blonde had ordered a single chocolate fondant to her table. It had occurred to Adora what a coincidence it was that this woman and her partner - who were practically a carbon copy of her and Catra - had ordered the same dessert that her ex had always gone crazy for . In the old days, thered been no fallout Adora couldnt fix with the of fer of that. Shed have gone to thirty restaurants looking for the kind of molten chocolate fondant that would appease Catra back then, even if it was training season and she wasnt allowed the slightest whif f of sugar herself.

Adora had never felt so close to heart failure than she had when she realised none of it was coincidence.

It had alarmed her in so many ways, seeing Catra living a different life with a different woman. She didnt look like life pained her so much anymore - there was no sadness looming behind those amber and blue eyes, and she didnt flinch the way she used to when the subject of lip-reading came up so bluntly . Adora had been pretty surprised Catra had allowed her girlfriend to disclose her access needs to anyone at all, let alone a random waiter. Yet most of all, Adora had been shocked by the electricity that had swept through her when shed seen Catra for the first time in six years, no dif ferent to the nervous energy that spiked in her veins with every stolen kiss theyd shared. It had been horribly dissatisfying to learn the truth too late: that no matter how many pretty girls Adora ran through, no-one ever made her feel the way Catra Weaver did.

It was almost as if she could still feel the ghost of Catra’s fingers stroking a line down her chest, the same lingering trail shed seen her ex’s eyes follow just hours before. Adora’ s lips prickled with want, her face inching towards an idea of love that no longer existed. Yet there was no trace of matte lipstick meeting her bare skin. Only

the wafting smell of antiseptic came to her when she inhaled, its soft tickle in her nostrils so different from the breathy sigh Adora had anticipated.

"Hey , Gray! You done over there yet?"

Adora jerked upright in surprise, bolted back to reality by her boss' question. She turned around to face Lonnie, dropping her cloth on the table. The whole restaurant was completely deserted now;she hadnt even realised she was the only waiter still cleaning her section.

"Oh, yeah," Adora gave the table one last wipe before finally walking away, "Sorry , I completely zoned out."

Lonnie raised an eyebrow, knocking Adora's elbow with her own lightheartedly.

"Hmm, I wonder why that was?"

The edges of Adora's lips curled up as she rolled her eyes, "No idea, Lon. None at all."

Lonnie chuckled, taking the cloth and spray bottle off her, "Get out of here, it's already past midnight. You've still got the early hours to work it out."

She nodded dumbly as Lonnie thanked her for coming into work at such short notice, though Adora didnt have the energy to explain that it felt better than confronting her grandmother's illness. If anything, seeing Catra was at least giving her something else to think about, even if it didn't make her feel particularly good either. Adora could feel her eyes glazing over through Lonnie's lazy goodbye chatter and while she pulled her worn leathers on;if the roads home werent so empty in the dead of night, Adora could have easily been knocked off her motorbike.

The whole journey felt like it took seconds - though that's what life was like when Catra was there. Entire weeks could just slip away from Adora, every second swallowed by the constellations of freckles scattered across Catra's skin, each one awaiting Adora's touch. She'd devoted entire weekends to them in the past.

When the roar of her Triumph Tiger died on the driveway, Adora stared at the front door. She wished she knew why it was so hard to do the simplest of things; just to take the keys in her hand and unlock the front door.

This was why you came home, remember? Just put the key in the lock and turn it. That's all.

Adora's hand trembled as she held the key out in front of her.

Just a couple more inches…

The door swung open before she'd worked up the nerve; she exhaled, the tension leaving her body as quickly as it came.

"Adora? What are you still doing out here?" She should have known that Perfuma would have stayed awake until she got home, even though she'd told her not to wait up, "I swear I heard Swifty turning in a whole five minutes ago!"

Adora stumbled over the threshold and kicked her boots off, shoving her helmet wearily onto the sideboard in the hallway. The other woman gathered it up straightaway, setting it in the basket by the staircase where it usually lived.

"Thanks for coming over to watch her tonight. I really needed to get out."

"Are you okay?" Perfuma's voice was full of concern, her face contorted into worry, "You don't seem like your normal self."

Adora forced a smile onto her face, though she assumed it looked more like a grimace. "Just a couple of road bumps."

"Do you want to talk about it? I'm not that tired."

Adora sighed and peeled off her leather jacket as she walked into the living room, dropping onto the sofa. Her trousers squeaked as she brought her knees up to her chest; Adora wished that she was already wearing her pyjamas and felt as cosy as Perfuma's soft green sleep shirt looked as she sat on the armchair opposite her.

"I saw her at work." Adora closed her eyes to shut Perfuma's attentive expression out, "Catra. She was on a date. She looked like she's doing a lot better. Happier."

"Adora-"

"I knew it must have happened by now, but I... I never imagined seeing her with anyone else."

I never imagined coming home.

"You met Eve?"

Adora startled a little, forgetting that her friends still knew Catra. They'd all stayed in Bright Moon, and Perfuma's girlfriend had been friends with Catra for nearly as long as Adora had.

"Is that her name?"

"Yeah, she's an old friend of mine. I- I actually introduced them, kind of."

"You did?" Adora could tell how hollow she sounded, "That's... that's great."

A weight settled down on the sofa next to Adora as Perfuma moved to place a hand on her shoulder.

"It' s been a long time, Adora. You moved on too, right?"

"Y eah," Adora' s chest tightened as the lie unfurled too easily from her tongue, "I guess I did."

Catra had watched as the colour seemed to drain from Adora's face, and she hadnt even tried to fight the instinctive snap of her eyebrow riding upwards.

Hook, line and sinker .

The problem was that Catra had never been sure whether it was her old girlfriend who'd get caught, or her .

It had been impossible to prevent the scene replaying in her mind the whole night, and now it was already morning. The thankless rush of life would catch up to her soon, but maybe, just for a few minutes, she could let herself pretend it wouldnt. Catra sunk into her memories yet again, a wave of Adora crashing over her. She imagined what her ex-girlfriend would be doing right that very moment, if she could watch her wake up the same way she always used to in Catra's bed, hidden under the sheets and cocooned in their own little secret. Adora had almost always woken before she did, but on the rare occasions that Catra got up first - usually only because Adora had driven herself to exhaustion despite multiple warnings - she loved to watch the way her eyelashes would flutter before giving way to bright blue irises. The edges of Adora's fingers always ghosted Catra's breast as her arms returned from their waking stretch, somehow more careful in the days before her period, as if Adora knew it would hurt if she was too heavy-handed. She had always been perceptible in that physical way of hers, even if she was maddeningly slow when it came to understanding Catra's emotions.

Sometimes, Catra wondered if they could have made it, if Adora could have understood her the way she was supposed to.

Catra could taste the bitterness building on her tongue as the consequences of Adora's actions returned her to the present. She turned in her bed with a huff, practically swallowed up by the rage that she'd thought she'd resolved when she'd decided that she wasn't going to wait anymore for that selfish, dumb blonde to get her shit together and come home; they'd only been twenty when their lives had fallen apart, but Catra had been mature enough to deal with the shitty hand she'd been dealt.

Why the fuck couldn't Adora deal with it too?

It was the question that had haunted her for years, yet it still hadn't hurt her the way the next one always did.

Wasn't I worth the effort to try?

It had never mattered how hard Catra tried to avoid thinking about it; once her self-doubt started to creep in, resentment always swallowed her up. The two of them had held the fragile relationship blossoming between them for so long, moving mountains to protect it as it changed from friendship into something different. But then, Adora had just stamped all over it - and for what? Swimming? Or was it to get away from Catra, because Adora hadn't wanted the new version of her who couldn't do the things she could before, whose life had dulled, and with it, the talent that was destined to shape her career.

Is she even sorry, for any of it?

There was little way of telling if Adora was guilty at all from their limited interactions in the restaurant. She'd seemed a little surprised, sure, but what else? Was there anything in the way her fingers scratched the back of her neck, or how she'd trembled a little handing over the card machine? Certainly, Catra couldn't deny that she could be reading into things either way - who was to say that

Adora's old tells were still the same, that every shake and scratch revealed the same insecurities they used to?

Enough about Adora *had* changed. A tiny scar at the centre of her right cheek, nicked into the carve of her cheekbone. Her old ponytail was gone, plaited and pulled into a topknot that revealed the sharp lines of an undercut. Her shoulders had been broader than Catra remembered too;she was unsure if it was due to some kind of training regime, or simply just that when Catra had let herself think about Adora over the years, she liked to remember herself as being bigger than she really was in Adora's arms, of feeling like she had more power. More control.

If Catra was really honest with herself, she had never felt in control around Adora. Her unwelcome fixation on that undercut was proof.

Stop falling back into this. Thinking about her doesn't have to screw everything up!

It was easier to pretend it was merely curiosity - Catra scrolled through her mental list of unanswered questions for the hundredth time.

What the fuck is Adora doing back home?

Where has she even been?

Why is she waiting tables?

Why did she have to pick my favourite place to work?

Is she staying for good?

Was she ever planning on reaching out to m-?

She shuddered as she cut the thought off, and the arms around her tightened. Catra's fingers twitched as they inched towards the golden strands that had fallen over her shoulder and spilled across her collarbone. She almost anticipated the smell of chlorine - *when was*

the last time she'd expected that? - but of course, there was only Eve's honey conditioner, sweet and fragrant.

Catra snuggled further into her girlfriend's arms. They'd been together for two years now, longer than she'd ever been Adora's girlfriend - at least publicly - and Eve had made her happier than she'd ever been. She'd accepted Catra's baggage and been so ridiculously patient with her for months before they'd finally made it official. Eve had made Catra into a map that her life depended on to know, and in return, Catra had granted her access to parts of her that no-one else had ever navigated.

This is what it's like, isn't it, to truly love and be loved?

Being with Eve had done so much to repair Catra's broken self-confidence. It had been exhilarating to begin with, not having to hide in someone else's closet and being able to love so openly without fear of consequence. Loving Adora hadn't been so freeing. Her ex had been petrified for months that their secret would come out, and Catra had convinced herself that giving Adora what she'd begged for would work out in the end. She scoffed at the memory of her own naivety;she realised too late she'd probably been louder than she realised - a rolling hum was already vibrating at the base of her neck.

"Mmmm, goo mor'ee, gorejus"

Catra turned round in Eve's arms and pressed a kiss to her jaw.

"Good morning to you too."

She didn't need the clarity of artificial sound to know what Eve would say;their little routine always started the same way, first with greetings and then with kisses. Catra burrowed further into her girlfriend, too tired to open her eyes yet.

"I cou te you bare-y slep aw nigh."

"Couldnt drift of f. Apparently you didnt tire me out enough, hot stuff."

Catra laughed as Eve nipped on her bottom lip, her fingernails fixing into Catra's bum.

"Oh, rea-y?"

"Mmm. I guess so."

She giggled at the firm palm turning her onto her back, the pleasant weight of Eve settling over her hips as her girlfriend straddled her. Catra opened her eyes then, keen to see the sight of her. She swept her eyes over long blonde hair settling on Eve's heavy breasts, the muscles of her stomach twitching as she sucked in a short breath.

"Maybe I can help with that, Cat."

Eve lowered herself down, the ends of her hair tickling Catra's stomach. She left rough kisses under her ribs, leaving small nips as she made her way to the inside of Catra's right thigh. Catra stretched out as she let her leg be lifted over Eve's shoulder, wrapping her palms around the cool metal bars of the headboard behind her. She tilted her hips, pushing the crease at the very top of her thigh to meet the warm mumble of moving lips. She couldnt be bothered to fill in the gaps of Eve's sentences now;those hazy words could settle on her skin instead.

Catra's skin tingled as Eve got closer to where she wanted her, the coil of muscles at the pit of her belly beginning to tighten and tighten until-

A harsh, flashing white tore into the dim light of their bedroom, rude vibrations slapping against the wood of Catra's bedside table and fighting the horribly unsubtle scream of Robert Plant drilling into the air.

"Y our phone goi- oh"

"I dont care. Just.let' s carry on, itll stop in a second."

Eve conceded;Catra tightened her grip on the headboard spokes, but her phone just kept on ringing.

"Will you ge tha? can'ea you ou to fucki- Immigra So-!"

"Why not? Led Zeppelin' s cool as fuck."

"Catra!"

Catra grunted as she reached out for her mobile, tilting her head towards Eve in confusion as she mouthed, "It' s Perfuma."

She answered the call hurriedly, twisting onto her side as Eve crawled out from between her legs and tumbled onto the pillows beside her.

"Hey , Fuma, just give me a second, I havent got my ears in."

Catra fished her hearing aids out of the ramekin by her phone charger, waiting for the telltale scale of rising musical notes and a sharp whistle of air before the world kicked in.

"Okaaaay ," Catra exhaled as the Bluetooth on her hearing aids diverted the loudspeaker directly into her ears, "I'm all synced up."

Perfuma's voice rang out loud and clear, though she spoke with a tinge of uncertainty that Catra hadnt heard from her before.

"Is Eve with you?"

Catra shrugged at her girlfriend's expectant expression, pushing herself out of bed and into the living room to curl up on the sofa with the cat. She held out her palm for Melog to nuze, her reply to Perfuma slow and measured.

"Not anymore. What' s going on?"

"I know you're not going to like this. But now you know she's home, I think you should reach out to her."

"Her?"

Catra knew that playing dumb was only going to steal her seconds before the bile began to rise in her throat;her false ignorance wouldnt fool Perfuma for the slightest moment.

"Catra, please. Will you drop her a line?"

She hung up the phone, staring at the calling history on the screen. Perfuma called her straight back;she declined without hesitation. Catra sat in silence for a while, pretending she couldnt hear Eve call out to her from their bedroom. It was just her and Melog, for the shortest, sweetest time.

Soon, she couldn't put it off any longer - she wasn't sure if five minutes had passed or forty - Catra opened her contacts list. It was a stupid thing to do;Catra had deleted Adora's number from her phone long ago.

That would make it too easy, huh? If you had no choice.

She laughed under her breath bitterly, switching over to the dial pad. However hard Catra had tried to forget Adora's phone number, her brain had somehow never managed it.

Eleven digits, practically typing themselves.

Her call was accepted on its second ring.

Chapter End Notes

> The biggest challenge for me in writing this is trying to reflect the experience of hearing loss on the page, in a way that feels accurate (at least to me) and not gimmicky. If there are elements that don't make sense, please let me know and I'll work on finding different ways of representing certain things, or

explaining them more. I don't have any memory of having my full hearing so working out what isn't obvious to others is proving trickier than expected!I can promise that there's nothing I'd find offensive in simple questions - I'd rather know so I can make things clearer... A vehicle for deaf/HoH access education, you wonder?What a wild thought!

Big love, and as always, love to hear what you're thinking.

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

TIA for all your patience... it has been a tough week (work, family health stuff, etc) ǎnd*for some reason, this chapter wasn't really coming to me naturally for a while!Got there in the end :)

This time, we've got Adora's POV solely, and going forward, it's likely each chapter will focus on a different character's perspective rather than flitting within, so mysteries will unravel piece by piece...

TW: abstract references to self harm, possible suicidal ideation.

Feedback of any kind (pos and/or neg) deeply appreciated as usual x

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Water streamed past Adora as she pushed towards the bottom of the pool, her belly closing in on concrete tiles as she propelled herself downwards. She twisted around, her hair flaring out around her, and let out a tiny amount of air from her lungs to stop herself from floating up to the surface. Shed done this since childhood, desperate to defy the laws of gravity amidst the mechanical hum of a pool;savouring the feeling of sinking deep, pretending there wasnt anywhere else to be - or anything else to feel.

Adora didnt know of anyone else who could hold her breath as long as she could - not that shed ever let anyone in on her secret. Shed managed a whole four minutes underwater once, grimacing while the burn in her lungs screamed at her. Adora had resisted it until it was almost too late, her mouth opening on instinct just as she drove her feet to the floor and pushed herself up. She could still remember the panic of realising a few seconds too late that maybe, she really had

taken the whole thing too far. The sensation of chlorine ramming against her windpipe repeated itself vividly in her sleep years later, a whole catalogue of concocted storylines ending in the very same way.

She stared at the surface of rippling water above her, monitoring the tightness in her chest to calculate how many more seconds she could give herself in limbo. It didnt matter how hard she tried to focus on the too-bright orbs of the overhead lights;all Adora could see was green fabric against tan skin and a gold pendant dipping between small, too familiar breasts.

Stop it - she isn't why you came home, and you can't risk fucking everything up again! You can't forget why you left.

Adora pushed a frustrated huff through her nose without even thinking;she'd ruined it now with her recklessness - she had no choice but to return to reality. Adora blew the rest of her breath out slowly and let herself drift to the surface, her heartbeat roaring in her ears. Holding herself still as she could, she bobbed in the water in a dissatisfying compromise, her eyes clamped shut as she threaded water through her fingers and toes.

"Grayskull!What the fuck are *you* doing in my pool?"

Adora swung round in surprise at the old nickname, hurriedly turning towards the person calling her. She laughed as she saw Mermista standing at the edge of the pool with her arms crossed and hip cocked just like she always had at their team practices, her sports jacket zipped halfway up over a blue swimming costume.

"Glimmer let me in,"Adora sliced through the water smoothly as she made her way towards her old teammate, hoisting herself out to sit on ridged ceramic, "I really needed to burn of f some steam, she's doing me a favour."

"Ugh, classic,"Mermista rolled her eyes, grabbing Adora's tattered red towel from the benches and throwing it at her, "Just because

she's, like, the head now, she thinks she can give the keys to anyone she wants."

"Cant she?"

"I guess, but it' s fucking annoying."Mermista fiddled with the whistle around her neck, watching Adora with a typically unimpressed expression, "Y ou know there are still public pools in Bright Moon? There's no reason to lurk around here like a creep or something."

Adora shivered, drawing the towel around herself as she got to her feet. She didnt want to admit that she hadnt only been here to swim laps;that she couldnt indulge in old habits with a lifeguard watching. It had taken more white lies than anticipated to get Glimmer to give her access to the pool she'd spent her formative years in.

"I tried to train at the leisure centre the other day , but it was so crowded. I couldn't even do a couple laps before I got stuck behind people, even in the fast lane!"

"A ww, babes," Glimmer had pouted at Adora in mock sympathy, *"A re all the plebs killing your vibe?"*

Glimmer had collapsed into giggles then, only pausing when Bow nudged her shoulder lightly. He'd looked over at Adora with genuine sympathy, a depth of kindness she'd forgotten could still exist.

"*C ome on, G lim, A dora' s barely been home in years and she's only trying to be honest with us about how she's settling in, right?"*

Adora had gulped, nodding with feigned gratitude, well aware that honesty hadnt been her most defining characteristic in recent years. She'd loaded her next words carefully , knowing that Glimmer's new interim headteacher position at their old high school could work out well if Adora could just play dumb in the right way ...

"Y eah, I just… I wish I could swim somewhere on my own without interruption and burn off some proper energy. I've really missed it

since leaving Salineas, what with everything going on."

It had done the trick, a little better than she'd thought it would.

"*You know,"* Bow had squeezed Glimmer's arm softly, and it had made Adora wonder whether things between her two best friends were still as platonic as they'd insisted when they were younger, "*You do have the keys to the school gym, Glimmer. Maybe Adora could train there a couple times a week?*

Adora's whole body had tensed as she'd watched Glimmer mull the idea over in her mind, praying that her friend would agree.

"I'll bite…" Adora's chest had swelled with excitement when Glimmer began, "*But only staff are supposed to have access. I'll let you in this week before team practices, but after that you're cut off. Unless..."*

"*Glimmer, for the last time, I can't coach the swimming team-"*

"Assistant coach. Just because you're some national hotshot now doesn't mean you get to walk in and be top dog. Hermista's still the head coach-"

"I'm not a coach! Besides, I have a job."

Glimmer's eyes had bore into hers as their conversation escalated, Bow's attention darting nervously between the two women.

"A shitty job. You're a professional athlete, for Christ's sake! It's clearly wearing you out somehow, you've basically been a zombie since you took on that extra shift the other night, and it's clear Lonnie's just taking advantage-"

Adora seethed at Glimmer's judgment. Still, she had known she couldn't let it slip that the demands of her waitressing job weren't what was making her so vacant; she couldn't bear bringing Catra up in front of the two people who had witnessed their relationship bloom and burn so closely.

"Working in a restaurant is not a shitty job, Glimmer , and Lonnie is helping me out. You're being a complete snob, and I can't be bothered with it, alright?"

"You're talented, Adora!" She'd been taken aback by Glimmer 's outburst, " *What are you punishing yourself for? Take the damn job! Or are you planning on running off again as soon as she's back?"*

Glimmer had cut herself off abruptly then, her eyes widening in shock and shame as she realised what she'd nearly said. Adora had stiffened. She'd thought meeting up with her closest friends for Sunday brunch would make her feel better, not worse. A fragile silence had fallen over the three of them, only permeated by the clatter of Bow's fork on his plate as he laid it down to reach out for Adora's hand.

"We just want what's best for you, Dora . It seems like you've been a little lost. Maybe coaching with Netmista would be a good thing?"

Adora hadn't wanted to admit that he'd hit the nail on the head - she'd felt lost for as long as she could remember , wandering through a desert with no manna to pull her out of her mental wilderness. She'd raised her eyes to Glimmer and Bow' s faces, a little taken aback by the depth of their sincerity.

"I'll think about it. Just… I'd really love to have that pool to myself, if that's on the cards?"

Glimmer had nodded, offering her humbled apologies, and they'd set up a plan for a week. She'd swim in the early mornings before anyone else would be at school each day, and then she'd have to make a decision on the job offer.

Adora knew she should count herself lucky to have evaded interruption until the third day of the school week. Nevertheless, she bristled at the knowledge that news of her return would spread to more of her old friends;it wouldn't be long until she'd be thrust completely into the world she'd shrunk from.

"Hello? Earth to Adora?" Adora zeroed in on Mermista's hand waving right in front of her face, "You gonna tell me what you're doing in Bright Moon this time, or what? Sticking around for a while?"

Adora nodded slowly. The jig was up.

"Yeah, I had to come back from Salineas to sort a few things out. It's not a big deal."

"I mean, you didn't come back for my wedding and barely anyone even knows you're here - it kinda seems like it is."

Adora cringed at the reminder of how she'd skipped out on Mermista and Sea Hawk's nuptials the previous year, secretly grateful she'd been tapped for crucial selection trials the same week. She'd been overwhelmingly relieved that the wedding hadn't been organised in Mermista's hometown, where she'd lived since transferring midway through her degree; the discomfort of seeing her two towns muddle was too much.

Adora chuckled, hoping she managed to make it seem breezy and lighthearted instead of unbearably nervous.

"Nah, I've just been busy since I got back. It's only been a few weeks so I haven't had the chance to reach out to many people."

Mermista watched her curiously; Adora could feel the prickle of anxious heat rising up her neck, defying the goosebumps that were starting to pucker on her arms and thighs, just like she used to when she was a fresher on the Bright Moon University swim team, and Mermista had stared her down at the start of every practice until she'd proven herself. How long could she pretend that she hadn't sworn Perfuma, Lonnie, Glimmer and Bow to secrecy, begging them to let her get settled in before she had to confront the rest of her past?

Extra kind of blew that out the water anyway.

"Did you quit Team Etheria? Not that I care or anything, but you're probably the best I trained."

"Trained?" Adora couldn't stop the snort from escaping her, sidestepping the question entirely, "Mermista, you do remember you were the team captain at uni, not the coach?"

"Ugh, whatever. As if I didn't do more to get your times down than fucking Micah ever did."

"Sure, Mermy, my entire career was definitely all due to you."

Nothing to do with all those punitive hours in the pool and the gym, chasing some kind of unattainable satisfaction.

Adora froze for a second when she'd realised she'd used the past tense; she hoped Mermista didn't pick up on it.

Did I just make a decision? Am I really walking away for good?

"Okaaay. Well, if you're looking for something to do, swim season's about to start and I guess it wouldn't be the worst thing to have a second pair of hands." Adora nodded, her lips pulled against her teeth in a tight, closed smile that didn't spread to her eyes. "The kids probably wouldn't mind it either."

Adora looked up at Mermista to see an old mischievous sparkle in her eyes; she followed the direction of her nod towards the changing room doors, where a slew of teenagers were making their way towards the pool, all gasping and giggling when they saw Adora by the pool. She could hear their surprise; not only had Adora made headlines with her times, but the school awards cabinet was practically a shrine to her teenage years.

Maybe it would be nice to feel wanted again, like I never did anything wrong...

"I'll think about it."

Adora smiled politely at the chattering teenagers as she made her way past them to the changing rooms, twisting her wet hair into a bun on top of her head. It had been so long since she had felt wanted, like she was in the right place.

Perhaps coming home wouldn't be quite as bad as she'd expected afterall.

A gentle breeze rustled Adora's hair as she waited outside the Fizone Group offices, leaning on Swift Wind as she drank in the building's industrial design. Yet another converted factory, it had been reinvented for productivity right in the middle of Bright Moon's dishevelled East End. The area looked so different to how Adora remembered its cobbled streets, much of the previous housing replaced by anonymous white apartment blocks and understated coffee shop fronts. It no longer seemed like the locals fit in quite how they did in the past, their neighbourly conversations crammed into side roads and under bus stops.

Adora rolled her shoulders back, hoping that her custom painted white and gold motorbike, cuffed jeans and Converse didn't make her seem like she was just another unwanted transplant from a different part of town;she had been native to the area once, back when she lived with Mara. She rubbed at Swift Wind's mirror with the edge of her jacket sleeve, unable to stand still. Adora didn't want to admit why she felt so nervous or that there was a looming feeling in the back of her mind that she could be left waiting forever. She'd already been standing in the street for ten minutes on her own, her helmet wedged in the crook of her elbow.

I guess that's what I deserve, right?

Out of nowhere, the sound of a door banging open jarred Adora's attention away from the bike.

She's actually here!

Catra was late, but she'd made good on her request for Adora to meet her;Adora was practically paralysed, watching how Catra moved with an air of efficiency in her casual workwear, gold necklaces layered atop an oversized maroon button-up, half-tucked into straight leg black jeans that cut off at just the right point above her ankle. Adora couldn't help but think - unlike herself - Catra had grown into the exact person she'd always said she would.

"Hey , Adora."

Adora shifted uncomfortably, tripping over her words too quickly .

"Hi, hey Catra. Your offices are, they look pretty cool-"

"You're mumbling."

Catra seemed irritated;she pushed open the office door behind her, beckoning for Adora to follow her back inside.

"So? Are you coming or not?"

Adora hurried after Catra, only just catching the edge of the heavy door after Catra let it go, not bothering to hold it open for her. Adora scratched at the base of her neck as she wandered behind Catra through the building, which seemed to be made entirely of steel, exposed brick and motivational platitudes in neon lights. When Catra finally stopped, showing Adora to a table in the far corner of the cafeteria, Adora felt like she'd been holding her breath just as carefully as she had hours earlier at the bottom of the pool.

Catra sniffed with impatience as she gestured for Adora to sit;she returned minutes later with a mug of coffee and a bottle of fresh orange juice, and slid onto the couch opposite her .

"I don't know if you're of f coffee these days or not, so…"

"Still sober in every sense of the word," Adora took the juice gratefully, smiling at Catra cautiously as she shook it and twisted the cap off, "Never developed the taste for it."

"W ell, if that's what a lifetime of elite training gets you, I can't say I regret my career choices much."

Adora nodded, sipping the juice in silence. They definitely weren't on friendly terms and Adora wasn't sure exactly what Catra expected to get out of the joke, especially given that her career certainly wasn't close to her original intended path - that had been cut off far too soon.

"I didn't expect to hear from you, Cat."

She tensed as Catra sucked in a sharp breath - Adora hadn't meant to let the old epithet slip out; it was too intimate for them after all this time.

"Y eah, well… here we are."

Adora cleared her throat - it gave her something to do as Catra blew on her coffee to cool it, her eyes drilling into Adora's own with a weariness that differed from her smouldering smirk at Thaymor Bistro.

"So, you work here, then?"

Catra raised a quizzical eyebrow; it summoned a million memories.

"No, dummy , I just hang out here with a load of ad execs for fun."

Adora snorted, almost like they were teenagers again.

"Okay , so you're one of those Mad Men advertising gurus now?"

"I wouldn't go that far ," Adora could tell Catra' s hardness was starting to fade a little, her mismatched irises no longer quite as cold, "But yeah, I'm a total private sector sellout these days."

"You've always gotten people to do whatever you want," Adora grinned, hopeful that the tease would help to recover their long-lost banter, "I bet you're better at it than you're letting on."

It was clear within seconds that her words didn't land as hoped.

"What the fuck is that supposed to mean?"

Adora's hand shook as she set her orange juice down on the coffee table, her palms held up in surrender.

"Wait, Catra, that came out wro-"

"You know, Adora, what did you expect me to do at the time, huh? You're clearly loud and proud enough now , so don't feed me this old bullshit that your whole life got ruined because you didn't get to do shit on your own terms."

"Catra! What the hell?"

Adora's eyes stung as she fought back the beginnings of long-forgotten tears, determined to stare Catra down without weakness. She stayed stoically silent, daring Catra to realise that she wasn't the same either; Adora was adamant that Catra would see that she'd gotten stronger too. She wouldn't just go along with this shit - it had been so much more complicated than Catra was making out.

Soon enough, Catra broke, her frustration palpable, "God, you're even more unbearable with that undercut."

Adora observed her ex as she crossed her arms, subconsciously flaring her nostrils.

She used to do that when we first got together and we couldn't touch in front of anyone, no matter how much we wanted to, and I always

knew we'd end up in my room...

Oh my God, does she…?

"You *like* it, don't you?"

Adora broke into a cocky smile, revelling in Catra's momentary panic. This was the kind of power that Catra always used to hold over her, and it felt good taking it for herself.

"What?"

"You like my undercut. It's doing something for you, isn't it?"

"Adora, you're being a complete arsehole," Catra spoke harshly, her voice dipping into a dark mutter, "Not that *that's* anything new."

Adora scoffed, running her hand through her hair and scratching at the bristles by her nape. She didn't know what she'd expected from her ex when she agreed to meet - her best case scenario had been some kind of rekindled friendship, ideally one that could help her feel better about the whole mess of how their relationship ended - but it certainly wasn't this slanging match.

"Why am I here, Catra?" Adora would have cringed at how exhausted she sounded, but she was too disappointed to be self-conscious, "If you just wanted to insult me, then mission accomplished. I'll happily fuck off and let you get on with your day."

Catra gaped at her, totally unresponsive.

"Alright then," Adora sighed, "Thanks for the juice, I guess."

She screwed the top back onto the bottle, hauling herself up roughly despite the burn in her muscles from her morning laps. She turned to leave, her helmet knocking on the side of the table as it swung in her hand.

“Adora,” Catra's urgency stopped her in her tracks, “Look, Perfuma told me to call you. I didn't think past that.”

Adora paused, intrigued by the confession.

“That doesn't sound like you.”

She heard Catra sigh behind her, weariness seeping through her words. Catra spoke with an exasperation only found in people burned out from having to remind others of simple instructions over and over again.

“I can't see you, Adora.”

She nodded apologetically, facing Catra again and inching back towards her seat. The Catra she had left six years ago would never have admitted she couldn't understand something - there was too much rage and pride in her at the time.

Maybe things really are different now ...

“Sorry . I said that it doesn't sound like you.”

“I don't know ,” Catra’ s eyes crinkled as she shook her head, “It’ s not like I had any clue what we were doing. I just thought…”

Adora slid back into her seat opposite Catra, still tentative in her actions.

“What?”

“I... “ Catra seemed more uncertain now than Adora ever recalled seeing her when speaking her mind, “It’ s stupid, probably, but I assumed we'd make it back then. Despite all of it.”

Adora wasn't sure what to say . She set her helmet on the table, looking anywhere but at Catra. She definitely couldn't say what was really on the tip of her tongue, not now that she'd heard about Eve - technically, she'd actually met Eve - and it was hard to imagine that

she could possibly be more *right* for Catra, if their love had left both of them in pieces and Eve had played a part in building the person that Catra had become since.

Ithought we'd make it too.

Chapter End Notes

> More angst coming up soon!W e got a whole host of bombshells to get to yet...

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

> Thanks so much for your patience, I know it has been a longer wait than usual for an update (can you believe I used to write 10-20k words a week before?)
>
> This chapter took a while but this slow burn is gonna heat up fast and soon...

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"I assumed we'd make it back then. Despite all of it."

For two months, Catra had felt like she was living on loop. She couldn't erase the memory of how Adora had tensed in reaction to her words, her stilted responses to Catra's efforts at conversation leading their meeting to a swift close. Maybe it had been a mistake to be so honest with her ex, but Catra was so tired of not voicing herself and of not understanding how their old life together had crumbled into nothing.

There was a nagging fear in Catra's mind that it was her own irritability that had sent the whole thing south - every indecipherable mumble and jumbled sentence was a jagged nail scraping its way down her spine, insisting that no matter how far she'd come, she was still undeniably dependent on others to get their communication right. Other people didn't usually grate on her quite as much, but that day, the dullness of Adora's voice had. It *always* had - and Catra didn't like to think too much about why.

It was easier to push her mental spiral far, far down; anything was better than thinking about how dejected Adora had looked while brushing off her confession, deflecting it with questions about their mutual friends, Eve and her job. Of course, the biggest elephant in the room had been left critically untouched - after Catra had

reminded Adora she needed to see her face to understand her, any mention of her disability and recovery had been painstakingly avoided. Catra didn't know why , given the past, that she'd ever expected otherwise.

That hadn't been what I wanted, was it, when I snapped at Adora all those years ago?

Catra had begun to let the true depth of her fears air out for the first time, her insecurities growing in the weeks since she'd last seen her ex.

Did I give her any choice? Was as it ever an option for her not to leave?

It was so much easier to believe that everything came down to Adora's failure, that Catra's part could be absolved by her painful adjustment to a new unexpected reality;yet since they'd clumsily reconnected, Catra had been trapped in echoing nightmares of her younger self lashing out over and over again - and Adora was always first in the firing line. Distinguishing between the version of events in her memories and in her nighttime subconscious was becoming increasingly difficult.

Catra was sure, however, about this: there was something going on with Adora, and it wasn't good news. She couldn't put her finger on what it could be, but it was only a matter of time before Catra figured it out;even though they hadn't spoken since that awkward meeting at her office, Catra was sure that she would get to the bottom of it. Somehow.

At least, that's what she'd managed to convince herself she was doing when she found herself complicating her commute by detouring to Thaymor Bistro for breakfast pastries and surprise take-away dinners for her and Eve. Catra had ignored Lonnie's jbes about her changing tastes - she'd never been one for Danish pastries and croissants before - and always tipped excessively when Adora was on shift, hoping that she'd noticed how generous Catra

had become. She hadnt always been in the position to tip properly when they were younger, and Adora had always made up the percentage, even if she was eqally as skint.

Catra wasnt sure why she craved her ex' s approval so much. Or she did - but it was easier to avoid thinking about why shed always struggled to see the best in herself, especially in comparison to the other woman. Adora had been the conscientious, well-behaved one - the golden girl - and Catra had found some kind of comforting safety in her bad girl reputation. Back in the old days, everyone pked that Catra and Adora were proof that opposites really did attract;even with Eve, anyone could see that their pairing was softness against steel.

The problem was, Catra had grown out of wanting to be the bad girl a long time ago.

She braced herself as she pushed through the glass bistro doors, hesitating before walking across to a table at the back of the restaurant. It was still early in the evening, and Catra knew that on a Tuesday night, there would be way fewer customers than usual. When picking up take-out on her way home over the previous weeks, shed also figured out that Adora always worked this shift, and she always waited on the table shed chosen. Catra wriggled her hands out of her thick gloves, teasing her woollen beanie off her head carefully to avoid ruffling her curls. She exhaled, a little with nervousness and a little with relief, when she saw Adora approaching - the last thing she wanted was to be caught off-guard by her ex's presence.

"Hi Catra,"Adora spoke with gentle professionalism, a cordiality that was curated for work rather than social friendliness, "What can I get for you"?

Catra cleared her throat, pushing her disappointment at Adora's lack of personal engagement away.

"Just a mocha, thanks."

The blonde nodded, a tight smile pulling at her lips, "Anything to eat?"

Catra shook her head, "No, Im cooking tonight. I just wanted to"…

She could feel Adora's curious gaze burn into her as her words died on her tongue. Catra didnt know what she even expected to say .

t' s not like you can tell her you came to watch her, to see if she's really happy. Not after how we left things last time...

"No worries, Ill be right back with that for you."

Catra jolted back into herself, reacting on instinct as Adora turned to leave, "W ait!Adora - do you maybe want to sit with me? Y ou know, if you have a break soon?"

Adora paused, and Catra wasnt sure if it had been a mistake to ask. She could feel her heart begin to beat a little faster as anticipation grew in her chest - *maybe we can actually talk properly this time, and Ill be better behaved, Ill work out what she' s doing in Bright Moon.*

"Sorry , Ive only just started my shift. Ill bring your drink over ."

"Sure, I- I thought you probably couldnt, I just-"

Her rambling was cut short as Adora backed away from the table, striding over to the tills with her head down. Catra could sense heat prickling at her neck and ears, the shame of rejection creeping up on her. She convinced herself it wasnt any big deal - *Adora is here to work after all, it's not like she's been hanging around waiting for me to come in and hash out all our old crap* - but when her mocha was delivered by another waiter, his head ducked and pupils avoidant, Catra's embarrassment nearly drove her out the restaurant without drinking the beverage at all. She forced herself through a million hurried sips, ignoring the numbing scald of boiling liquid on her tongue.

By the time she'd gotten home, her jaw sore from feigning neutrality as she requested the bill and paid, Catra felt completely deflated. It hadn't helped that she'd been playing a painfully angsty album on repeat, the sound synced via Bluetooth from her phone to her hearing aids to block out any noise of real life around her.

It was no wonder she didn't hear Eve come home while she finished cooking;Catra smiled as a text from her girlfriend popped up on her phone screen as she set the lid on the pan and paused the music, grateful that Eve always went out of her way to avoid shocking her. She leaned into a warm body as firm arms wove their way around her, a kiss pressed to the back of her head.

"What's this, babe?"

Catra bit her lip, wiggling her hips against Eve's palms, the heaviness in her chest beginning to dissipate, "Just your favourite"…

"Mmm, which one?"

It had been an inside joke between them forever. Eve could never decide which of Catra's dishes she liked the best.

"Set the table and find out."

Eve giggled - Catra never tired of hearing that sound, even when it was too sharp in her hearing aid - and begrudgingly broke away from her, the clanging of cutlery and crockery filling the kitchen.

"Forks, knives or spoons, babe?"

"Forks. And the microplane."

Catra smirked as Eve gasped in response, watching the blonde rush to the fridge to retrieve a hunk of parmesan.

"You didn't?"…

Catra hummed under her breath nonchalantly as she wrapped the pan handle in a dishtowel, transporting her handiwork to the dining table;she set it down on a trivet, surveying Eve' s reaction to the reveal of the creamy risotto, glints of pumpkin and sage sitting amongst the rice. It was a dish Catra didnt cook often - it took long enough to make - but it was worth it to see her girlfriend's delight as they began to eat, her efforts rewarded with the vision of Eve's forceful push of hard cheese through the grater to her bowl. Chatter was easy between them, conversation about their days at work flowing without effort. She had to remind herself that this life was what she'd always longed for: a love and simplicity with someone who understood her. Someone who made her feel good.

This is perfect, there' s no need for any concern about Adora. She' s not your problem anymore.

"Anyway , Fuma invited us round on Friday night for Scorpia' s birthday, they're having a get together ..."

I mean, you've been fine without her all these years - better than fine! Just forget about her , how hard can it be?

"... I think that waitress from Thaymore' s been invited, your old friend? Maybe you can catch up with her?"

Wait, what?

Catra choked on her forkful, spluttering as she rushed to gulp down water and recover.

"Shit, Cat, you okay?"

Catra peered up at Eve's concerned features, nodding weakly while her girlfriend patted her upper back.

"Y eah," she croaked, her throat sore, "I'm fine, I think I just misheard you."

I wish I misheard you.

"Oh," Eve smiled softly, "it's just that your old friend from Thaymor Bistro will probably be there. Fuma seemed to think you'd want to know, guess she reckons you can catch up."

Or like it's a warning...

"Hmm," Catra mused, hoping she sounded unfussed, "They've probably invited Bow and Glimmer then, they were always close with her. Remember those two from the last party?"

Eve grinned, running her foot up Catra's calf under the table - neither of them would forget that night. They'd heard of one another in passing before, but it hadn't been until one of Perfuma's own birthday parties that Eve and Catra saw each other in person. They'd each realised instantly that there could be more between them than the flimsy acquaintanceship of sharing mutual friends. Although she had never admitted it, Catra had been so startled by Eve's physical similarity to Adora that she'd been a bumbling mess when they met; it had taken everything to hold herself together when Eve's slender fingers had ghosted her forearm in the kitchen, a glass of prosecco attentively poured and held out for her.

"I'll probably recognise them," Eve's pupils glimmered with mischief, "Though I was a bit distracted that night."

It was true that they'd flirted shamelessly, soon curling into the corners of Perfuma and Scorpia's living room as if no-one else was there. Eve had gladly helped Catra ignore the presence of Adora's old friends and former teammates without even knowing it. One glass of prosecco had turned into two, then three, and before they'd known it, Catra had found herself in Eve's tiny bedsit. They'd only kissed before falling asleep fully clothed, but the next morning, Catra had unbuttoned Eve's shirt slowly, her fingers dipping into the hollows of her collarbones and down the smooth plane of her sternum. She'd waited for Eve to stop her, but all she had received in return was a hand paused at the waistband of her underwear

seeking permission to explore. They'd spent the entire weekend tangled up in one another, neither of them quite able to say goodbye until the Sunday night scaries kicked in.

For weeks after, Catra could feel the exhilaration of their tryst simmering under her skin. They started texting during work hours, sending goofy selfies from buses and trains or talking shit about their bosses, and it had surprised Catra when she realised Eve had quickly become the first person she thought about when she woke up. It had been so refreshing, to feel excited instead of exhausted. Yet without the drama that had characterised her previous relationships, Catra had begun to wonder if they were really only friends - maybe friends with benefits. The next time they'd met in person, Catra had scoured every twitch and wrinkle of the blonde's face as she approached, but it had only taken seconds to know that the energy between them was different. She'd moved closer to Eve, pressing her lips to the blonde's cheek as they greeted one another, only for the arms around her to loosen and for Eve to lean back and tease her.

"I was hoping for a little more than that, Catra."

Their kisses that night - and everything that followed - had given Catra much-needed clarity, clear as glass.

Eve squeezed Catra's hand a little just as the front door opened before them, a promise of solidarity before the challenges of a noisy party launched.

"Wildcat! Eve! It's so great to see you!"

Catra couldn't help but chuckle as she was swept up into Scorpia's arms, rubbing the muscular woman's back amicably as she turned to

embrace her girlfriend.

"Happy birthday , Grandma."

Catra smirked at Scorpia's incredulous gasp, revelling in the second sqeeze of Eve' s fingers around hers - now a reminder to behave herself.

"Gosh, Im only ten months older than you!"

"Y eah, yeah," Catra leant back into Eve' s side as the blonde handed over their present to her old friend, pleased at the delight the terraz plant pot evoked, "It' s more your mentality than the age gap."

"Simmer down, babe," the warmth of Eve' s voice tickled her ear, "W e havent even got you a drink yet."

"That' s a good point!" Catra grinned at the birthday girl, "Where' s the wine?"

"Y es! Let me show you..." Scorpia' s enthusiasm clearly wasnt waning with age, and she led Catra and Eve down the hallway towards the kitchen, "Perfuma got so many dif ferent drinks for tonight! She even asked Lonnie to sell her some of the good wines they have at the restaurant, but she couldnt come so Adora brought-"

Scorpia stopped abruptly in the doorframe, her shoulders tensing in front of them. She turned back to face Catra and Eve, her eyes widening with panic and worry. Catra jumped in hurriedly , desperate to smooth over Scorpia's hiccup - the last thing she needed was Eve thinking they had a problem on their hands.

"Did you forget something, Scorp?"

"Uhhh. Y. es! Y es, I..." Scorpia seemed to be catching on, her shoulders falling back into place by the second despite her obvious

struggle to come up with an excuse, "I need to find Perfuma... So she can decide what plant to put in this amazing pot you got me!"

Scorpia laughed nervously, jostling them out of the way to join everyone else in the living room and leaving Catra and Eve by the entrance to the kitchen.

"Okay ," Eve ran her hand through her long hair , her head tilted in confusion, "I guess we know she likes it?"

Catra glanced at Eve, shrugging her shoulders dismissively.

"Eh, you know she' s funny like that sometimes. Let's get ourselves some of this wine we've been promised."

Catra managed to still the quake in her hand before pouring their drinks, savouring the taste of Merlot staining Eve's lips as it layered over her own Sauvignon Blanc.

"Think this counts as rosé?"

Catra snorted at Eve's terrible attempt at humour, but it didn't stop her from kissing her girlfriend again;after all, they only had seconds before it would become rude not to join everyone else.

"Dork. Come on, we should go and say hello to people."

When they finally made their way into Scorpia and Perfuma's living room - they'd stolen a few more kisses from one another than planned - Catra was relieved to see that several of Perfuma and Eve's friends were huddled in the corner. Catra insisted Eve go over to the group, nudging her head in their direction affirmatively when Eve sought her eye contact.

"Go and chat with them, Ill be fine."

It gave Catra the perfect opportunity to seek out Scorpia. She slipped between the huddles of guests chatting amongst themselves

until she saw her friend at the back of the room clumsily rearranging ornaments on the shelves to make room for the gifted plant pot.

"Hey , birthday girl. What the hell was that about?"

Catra spoke softly despite the harshness of her words - she'd spent years sanding down the roughness of her old edges - but her frustration still bled through.

"I'm sorry!" Scorpia lunged towards Catra, a candlestick in her hand, "I didn't mean to make anything obvious, I just panicked because I realised I have no idea if Eve knows anything about Adora, and-"

"Breathe, Scorp."

"I haven't ruined anything have I?"

"No, no," Catra did her best to reassure her friend, annoyed at herself for making the slip into way more of an issue than it really was, "I just might not have. Oh, never mind."

"Not?" Catra cringed at Scorpia's encouraging face, a little ashamed of the truth, "Come on, you can tell me."

"Ugh, I never told her about Adora," She couldn't bring herself to meet Scorpia's gaze, knowing her eyes would be wide as saucers, "I mean, she knows the broad strokes of what happened, but not that Adora's the one who.. you know ..."

"*Catra!*"

From the tone of Scorpia's voice to the way she scratched the back of her neck uncomfortably with one curled forefinger, Catra was teleported right back into a long-gone interaction between the two of them.

"*Are you really sure this is a good idea, Wildcat?*"

"*What do you mean?*"

Catra hadnt liked the way her friend hesitated, scrambling to find the most delicate words she could. She was sure that Perfuma must have coached Scorpia for hours on how to have this chat;the broad-shouldered woman had looked like she was desperate to remember a critical phrase or qestion that couldnt be received the wrong way . It had made Catra sqirm in a perfect mirror image of the other woman.

"W ell, Iknow it' s been a while, and gosh, we're so proud of how far you've come..."

Catra had let her nostrils flare instinctively;that " *we"* had let it slip that her suspicions of being the hot topic of conversation between Scorpia and her girlfriend were correct.

"... B t have you thought about why you might like E e? B cause… Oh, wait, no, Im supposed to wait and see what you say before I start blabbering away again. t' s important that Igive you the opportunity to clear your mind so that we can have a loving and kind discussion-"

F r fuck' s sake, S orp."

Catra's irritation had been impossible to hide. It had enraged her that Scorpia was really trying to start this conversation, and that her friends couldn't just be happy for her . It had been forever since she'd dated anyone, and *what the fuck did it matter that E e-*

"W ell, we were just worried about the two of you, because you know , we love the both of you so much! A d P rfuma' s known E e since school just like we knew each other , they were in the same G ography class for all their e ams and stayed in touch all these years-"

S orpia! G t to the fucking point!"

Catra had practically shouted at her friend;they'd been lucky that Lonnie had let them stay after Sunday brunch hours were technically

over at the bistro, and they had been alone aside from the staff clearing up and preparing for dinner service.

She looks an awful lot like Adora! Are you sure you're not, well, not just replacing her?

Catra had sulked, crossing her arms defensively. She did the same now, staring Scorpia down as she hurriedly crammed the candlestick next to the gifted plant pot on the shelf. Catra had found herself fighting for Perfuma's approval when she and Eve got together - it had been the promise that Catra would tell Eve about Adora that had gotten Perfuma off Catra's back. She supposed she'd been lucky that Adora had never come up casually in conversation before. After all, why would she? Adora had been gone for years, and a part of Catra - simultaneously heartbroken and relieved - really had believed she'd never return.

"Catra, you *promised* Fuma!"

"I know, I know," Catra came closer to Scorpia, quieting her voice in desperation to avoid attracting attention, "I always meant to, it's just that bringing her up again always seemed so pointless, and I didn't know what good it would really do"…

A brief quiet settled between them, ripping off Catra's carefully constructed facade like a worn plaster to showcase the angry scab beneath. They had known each other since the start of secondary school; Scorpia had learned what Catra's silences meant long ago.

"Did it hurt? To think about her?"

Catra met Scorpia's eye contact, unable to stop a lump from forming in her throat.

"Yeah. It- it did, okay? But they've seen each other now, it's no big deal."

Scorpia sighed, her anxious displeasure seeping through.

"Please, just don't make a fuss out of it with Fuma. It's your birthday, you're supposed to be enjoying yourself, not worrying about my ex drama. Look at everyone here, they've all come to celebrate with you!"

Miraculously, it worked. Scorpia inhaled, took Catra's wine glass from her and emptied it swiftly.

"Alright, Wildcat, I trust you. Tonight is for having fun!"

"Yeah," Catra breathed out, a little in disbelief, "Go be the centre of attention!"

Catra watched as Scorpia grinned, following her friend as she sauntered across the room towards Perfuma, and hooked her fingers into the belt loops of Eve's jeans. The low hum of Scorpia's Spotify playlist was already starting to cloud her mind; it was easier to lean into physical pleasures than attempt to make out the blurry conversations drifting around the room. She let herself be tucked under Eve's arm, giving into her need for physical affection in a way that she never would have even dreamt of when she was younger, refusing to worry about what other people thought.

Catra didn't need the rest of her hearing back to figure out that she and her tall, blonde, blue-eyed, muscular girlfriend had caught the attention of the old gang.

She could see Glimmer and Mermista's eyes flick in her direction when they thought she wasn't looking, and the gentle, intuitive placement of Bow's hand on Adora's forearm when Eve pressed a kiss to her forehead. Catra knew that for all their faults, the lot of them were too well-meaning to make a scene in front of Scorpia and Perfuma's other friends, let alone on Scorpia's birthday.

As expected, their interest in her waned anyway. That had always been what annoyed Catra the most about the stupid Best Friend Squad and Adora's precious swim team - for all they pretended to care, they'd always change the subject before the last issue was

resolved. Every argument would be swept under the carpet in favour of keeping the peace, or winning whatever over-egged race was coming up next.

As far as Catra was concerned, not everything was worth smoothing over for the sake of friendship - *haven't we all learned that by now?*

The night wound on and on, unfurling around them. She could tell that Glimmer and Mermista were ɒvially ganging up on Adora about something - Catra could ɹst about lip-read some odd words at a distance from her vantage point - but she was soon distracted by more compelling conversation with Eve and their friends about theatre they'd seen, events coming up in the neighbourhood, and light-hearted gossip about those on the outskirts of their circle.

It took far longer than usual for the night to start weighing on her. A couple of hours in, Catra could feel herself getting heavier, her head beginning to pound. She started losing focus, her brain skipping over contextual words that she needed for the sentences to make sense. Nevertheless, Catra knew no-one else would notice;she'd gotten so good at mirroring other people, laughing when they laughed, making little pensive sounds when they seemed more serious. Camouflaging herself in the hearing world was its own form of illusion art, and Catra was close to perfecting it.

She fiddled with her left hearing aid, knowing full well that it wouldn't help at all, but doing it out of habit anyway. Catra could tell Eve heard the shrill whistle of air passing through her aid;her body twitched at the high-pitched, mechanical whine she'd learned to recognise.

"Y ou wanna go home? W e've definitely done our time."

"Nah," Catra kissed Eve chastely , "Y ou're having fun catching up with everyone. Ill ɹst get some fresh air ."

"Sure?

"Yeah."

Catra captured Eve's lips with her own again. In moments like this, she always remembered quite how much she'd struck gold.

"I'll take you over ."

"It's only the back garden, Eve."

Catra laughed genuinely when their friends began to tease Eve for being so pathetically whipped. It was much easier to overcome the sore fuzziness of lost concentration and fatigue when this kind of body language played a bigger part: extreme facial expressions; wide gesticulation;friendly pretend shoves. Swearing was effortless to read too - somehow, curses had been amongst the first words she'd learned to identify the shapes of.

They wandered over to the French doors, pushing halfway through while caught up in one another, as if they'd forgotten they weren't alone. There was something validating in it;Catra wasn't hiding any part of herself when cold air rushed through the narrow gap between window and wall. Eve almost didn't let her go out, pulling Catra flush against her body and leaning into the night frost despite her own feet still being firmly indoors.

Catra giggled, the crisp darkness already beginning to soothe the ache behind her brow. She teased Eve away from her, pushing her back into the party towards her friends, and shutting the door before her girlfriend could distract her any longer from her much-needed time out.

She hadn't expected to turn around to see Adora sitting at the top of the patio steps with a bottle of vodka in her hand, her feet sprawled across the grey paving stones.

Even against the inky sky, Catra could tell immediately that Adora was undeniably *pissed* - in every sense of the word possible.

Chapter End Notes

Well, folks, whadd'ya think?

Chapter 5

Chapter Notes

Wasn't planning on posting until tomorrow, but hey ho, it's a Chanukah miracle!
Happy first night / [illegible] to everyone who celebrates :)

Adora stood in front of her mirror, focusing on her reflection with such laser focus that she was almost surprised she didnt burn through the glass.

She shifted her stance, her fingers lingering on the buttons of her short-sleeved shirt. Slowly, she undid the top four, pushing the translucent white circles through their eyelets and watching the fabric as it fell away from her breastbone. Adora gazed at herself, interrogating how her broad shoulders filled out the boxy cut of the clothing, her pale collar bones popping against the bold grayscale print. Her breasts peeked out from behind painterly strokes of black, long silver necklaces dipping into the space between. Her chest rose and fell with her breaths as she steadied herself;she wasnt used to seeing her breasts so free - the compression of her swimming costumes and sports bras usually flattened them, though she spent more time out of the pool and gym than in them these days.

Adora sighed, wondering what it would be like if she ignored the discomfort clenching in her stomach and went to Scorpia's party just as she was, with her body on display.

Would she like what she saw if Idressed like this?

Adora shook her head, berating herself silently for the thought. Catra had barely left her alone for close to eight weeks - not that she was counting - and it had been all Adora could do to shake her off. It was too confusing to figure out what Catra wanted from her, but Adora was painfully aware of what she wanted from Catra. She'd wanted

the same thing for years, even if she'd tried to drown out her daydreams with half-hearted hookups and app date after app date. Adora had no choice now but to face up to it - getting what she wanted was impossible with Eve in the picture. If Adora thought she knew anything, it's that it was easier for her to retreat from Catra than to attempt to fight fire.

She hovered over her buttons, willing herself to do them back up. Instead, her hand wandered of its own accord to her belt buckle and up, pushing itself into her underwear , driven by desire over logic. She ran her fingers over coarse hair, closing her eyes as she imagined how Catra might look at her if she left her shirt buttons open, how her irises would rake over Adora's bare skin and drink in the unseen ink of the slim sword at the base of her sternum. It was all too easy to visualise their bodies colliding, Catra's skin pressing against her exposed decolletage, her mouth murmuring appreciation of Adora's soft butch style.

You're even hotter than you used to be, Dora , now you're more yourself.

Adora's breath trembled as she conjured Catra' s voice in her head, a low growl that raised goosebumps on her arms and breasts. She slipped the pads of her fingertips further down, suppressing a groan as she met her own wetness;Adora doubted she could make herself come without any help, but giving into the vibrator felt too intentional. She wasn't supposed to be doing this, using Catra, pining after her .

She tilted her hips backwards and forwards, leaning on the wall next to the mirror with her other hand. Adora caught sight of herself for a second, surveying how masc she looked in comparison to her uni days;she'd certainly succeeded in finding herself, at least in this way. She circled her clit, rocking against herself to build tension. The ache low inside her was only getting worse, every fibre in Adora's being crying out with want.

It was a pointless grasp towards satisfaction;Adora hadn't come hard in months, the stress of living in this house diminishing every

would-be orgasm. The whimpering skips of tightening muscle she'd been able to achieve in the past months had taken work, and they were nothing like the deep convulsions she'd much more easily incited before. She'd confided in Glimmer , grateful for the genuine sympathy her friend had expressed towards her, even though the pricey toy Adora had later received in the post was somehow yet to finish its job.

In truth, Glimmer was a better friend than any of the Salineas girls she'd hung around with while training with Team Etheria. The lesbian scene was far better in Salineas - Adora didn't know why she ever expected otherwise in a city famed for its watersports, progressive politics and women-only beaches - but Adora had never quite found her groove outside of Bright Moon. It was hard for Adora to accept that she was a homebody at the heart of things, despite her lengthy attempts to prove herself otherwise. No matter how much she loved having access to queer barbers, and how liberating it felt to see pink and orange stripes slapped across car bumpers and pinned to backpacks on a daily basis, Adora's uneasiness without the Best Friend Squad was profound.

Reticent to accept her orgasm was nowhere near close, Adora shivered as she pulled her hand out of her boyshorts, shimmying out of cotton and denim to dump her dampened underwear in the laundry. As she finished getting redressed, doing up her buttons and tucking the hem of her shirt back into her jeans, Adora heard her name being called.

"Mara, dearie!"

At least, the name she'd had to accept now referred to her .

She buckled her belt and jammed her feet into leather boots, the silver chain at her hip clinking against the doorframe as she left her bedroom. Adora made her way across the hallway, pausing before she entered the other bedroom to get Huntara's permission.

"You don't have to keep asking to come in, you know," the older woman spoke gruffly, "it's your house."

Adora shrugged, moving around the bed to squeeze her grandmother's hand. She was grateful for Huntara's presence, even if she'd initially resented Glimmer and her mum Angella's insistence that they pay for the nurse. Adora's protestations that working at Thaymore Bistro wasn't the reason she was always so tired had backfired to some extent - instead of leaving her be, Glimmer and Bow committed themselves to identifying the problem. Still, Adora was relieved that they'd thought Raz was the root of her issues; admitting to her situation with Catra would have been destructive to say the least. Besides, now that Huntara had been living with Adora and her grandmother for two weeks, she couldn't deny that having the woman around had lifted a huge weight off her shoulders - the reformed dealer had unrivalled pharmaceutical knowledge and the hardened muscle to physically support her patients regardless of how little faculties they had left.

"I'm going out tonight, Raz," Adora repeated her plans to her grandmother for the fifth time that day, "but I'll see you tomorrow."

"Oh, Mara," Raz's voice no longer had its characteristic airiness, her slackened mouth carving words with difficulty in contrast to the mischievous sparkle in her eyes, "You can leave little Adora with me. There'll be a pie for you when you get home, you know how much she loves to bake with her granny."

"Thanks," Adora mumbled, the interactions not getting any easier even though she was no longer so alone in it all, "I love you, Raz."

"Don't disappear again," the elderly woman suddenly snapped with bitterness, thrown into a replay of an argument that Adora had never witnessed or participated in the first time round, "You can't leave with that woman, not with my granddaughter! I won't have it, Mara, not again! I promise you, you'll regret it!"

Tears began to stream down Raz's face, loud wails pouring from the back of her throat. Huntara bustled Adora out of the way, nodding towards the door.

"Go on, kid. I've got her, go and enjoy your evening."

Adora grunted in acquiescence, not quite able to commit herself to any form of grace, and stumbled down the stairs. It was too early to leave for the party, but stepping away was more important. She needed it.

She dilly-dallied in the hallway for a minute, staring at her helmet and the crate of mixed wine bottles she'd been entrusted to take to the party on Lonnie's behalf. All she wanted was to grab her leather jacket and get on Swift Wind, speeding somewhere - *anywhere* - the wind would take her. Adora could see the motorway in her mind's eye, taunting her in its imagined emptiness, the yell of rubber against tarmac freeing the agony that screamed like neon light inside her.

Her fingers drummed on her keyring, her bus pass left lying cold on the sideboard. She texted Glimmer, pretending she was running late from an unexpected work shift and begging her to swing round to the house on her way to the party to pick up the wine. And before Adora knew it, the force of cool wind reddening her cheeks was almost as addictive as the feeling of gliding through water;propelling her body through the elements was her ultimate source of adrenaline.

You're so crazy for it, Princess. It's like your catnip or something.

Adora was too slow to stop her memories from resurfacing;how many times had Catra teased her with that joke at parties, using Adora's natural highs as an excuse to deny her even the tiniest drag on a shared spliff every time? She did manage, however, to stop herself from remembering the little puff of pride that had always swelled in her chest as she steeped in Catra's second-hand smoke, knowing that someone loved her enough to stop her from giving into peer pressure and transgressing her own boundaries;of

remembering the pride of having a person who knew her true desires better than she knew herself.

When Adora finally arrived at Scorpia's birthday party, there were already more people there than she'd expected to see. She let herself be pulled into hugs by the hosts, pushing down the urge to blurt out the one question that threatened to burst from her .

Is she here yet?

Adora counted herself lucky that Scorpia could talk for Etheria - she never had the opportunity to embarrass herself anyway.

She rounded the corner into the kitchen to pick up one of the non-alcoholic lagers left next to Lonnie's wines, grateful for Glimmer's thoughtfulness;it was the same brand that Adora had taken to bringing to their late night chats and TV marathons. These little acts were the reminder of kindness Adora needed when her pink-haired friend tested her with her outrageous inability to stop until she got exactly what she wanted.

Unsurprisingly, her time out with Swift Wind didn't excuse Adora from a grilling from Glimmer once they'd settled into conversation and her old Bright Moon gang had filtered into the living room one-by-one. She'd been a little dumbstruck by how pleased everyone had been to see her;apparently the brief welcome chats they'd all engineered by dropping into the bistro since Mermista spread the news of her homecoming hadn't sated their enthusiasm for a catch-up.

It was nice to begin with, settling back into her former life more smoothly than she'd imagined. Yet the second that Catra came into Adora's view, her ability to follow any thread of conversation plummeted. When she saw her whispering with Scorpia as she rearranged gifts on her and Perfuma's shelves, Adora's chest tightened in anticipation. There was clearly some kind of tension between the two of them, and Adora fantasised that they were talking about her. It felt guiltily wonderful, to pretend that every argument Catra had was the rest of the world shouting at her that

she'd made the wrong choice, that she should leave everyone else behind and go back to where she belonged, happily nestled in Adora's arms.

Her daydream inevitably fell apart when Catra and Scorpia's conversation swiftly resolved itself and Adora watched Catra cross the room to drape herself around Eve. She had no idea how she hadn't noticed the blonde's presence before - all the oxygen in Adora's lungs felt like it was being jerked out and pulled into a vortex. Her mental scaffolding collapsed in an instant;despite her ex's obvious soft spot for her undercut, Catra's type was clearly more femme than Adora now was, and she'd chosen someone who embraced all the lingering touches and PDA that Adora had repeatedly denied her when they were younger. The worst realisation of all hit Adora fast and hard: the love of her life had fallen for someone who hadn't played any part in the path that had led to Catra's hearing loss, who hadn't obliterated the longed for career that she had been previously destined for.

How could you ever compete with that blank slate?

The heartache cracked inside Adora as if her ribs were squeezing her organs together, a slow suffocation wrought by her own bone and cartilage. She'd felt it every time she'd played it cool around Catra, pressing in on her soul during every shamed interaction and cruel rebuff.

This is why you have to keep pushing her away.

It was no use pretending otherwise - Adora knew she'd never gotten over Catra, and if she didn't free her out, she'd never recover from the exile she'd imposed on herself over six long years of denial.

You have to draw a line under this. She'll never be yours, and you can't carry on as if you still belong to her either.

If it weren't for Glimmer and Mermista incessantly nagging her about her stupid training regime in Salineas and why she wouldn't talk to

anyone about walking away from Team Etheria, Adora wasn't sure she'd have ever been able to drag herself from falling into the horrifying black hole torn by Catra and Eve.

"Come on, Grayskull, give up those juicy training tips," Adora stopped the shiver that her old team nickname evoked when spoken by her former captain, "If you're, like, not gonna tell us what's going on with your swim stuff, at least help the team out."

Glimmer's slurring - she was already four drinks in, knowing Bow was her designated driver home - followed Mermista's question like a chaser.

"Yeaaaah, Dor! Why won't you tell us if you're going back to Salineas? We just wanna know if we get to keep you!"

Adora sniffed, not reassured much by Bow's small smile and his offer to replace Glimmer's wine glass with his own tumbler of water. All eyes were on her now - even Perfuma watched her with caution alongside Spinnerella, Netossa and Frosta - and Adora hadn't felt quite this uncomfortable with the group since she'd inadvertently crashed out the closet.

"I'll let you know when I do," Adora heard the words tumble out of her own mouth, completely detached from her brain, "It's complicated."

She didn't wait to see the sympathetic pity on her friends' faces as the final two words drifted towards them - they'd echoed in her brain and in the air around her far too many times in the short time she'd been home.

The real truth - that it wasn't complicated at all, that Adora had been fucking her times up for weeks prior to leaving Salineas, and that the panic attacks she'd evaded since leaving Bright Moon for the first time had come back with a vengeance - remained unspoken. She certainly hadn't told anyone that when the hospital had gotten in touch with her as Raz's next of kin, relief had washed over her before despair did.

Months spent doing squat jumps and tricep extensions until her body trembled, running until she threw up, cramps pinching the muscles in her feet and rashes splitting open in the reddened valleys between her dry fingers. It could all stop. She could just *not*, and let the smiling, hardworking, ambitious mask she'd clung to fall away. In the moment, it had felt like a dream had sprung from the stuff of nightmares.

Nevertheless, when Adora had asked her coach for a month off to sort out her and Raz's affairs in Bright Moon, her stomach had clenched in horror at his response.

"*One month isn't enough, Gray. We're signing you off for six.*"

She'd been flabbergasted to hear they'd noticed all her little tricks to hide how far she was pushing herself, that they had planned to intervene before Adora had requested the time off for herself.

"*I'll get my times back down, I promise! It's just a blip, I've got a lot going on and… I… I can make this work! Really.*"

"*This isn't about getting your times better, Adora. It's about getting you better.*"

Adora had never hated anyone as much as she'd hated the Team Etheria coach in his office that day. She seethed at how they dared to freeze her out, after she'd uprooted her entire life to join the Salineas University feeder team and dedicated years to representing Etheria nationally. Adora had no idea who she'd have become if she hadn't sacrificed everything to swim, and now what? They were going to leave her high and dry just because of one bad season, one tiny relapse in six medal-winning years? It made Adora sick every time she'd lingered on her Etheria teammates' concerned calls and messages for too long; after all this time, was she really still this pathetic, this obviously pitiful to everyone around her?

She did the thing she always did, trying to turn a curse into a blessing by convincing herself that staying with Raz for longer

would work out for the best. Afterall, hadn't she always wished she'd had more time with Mara? Yet Adora's flight back to Bright Moon hadn't felt like such a gift once the seatbelt lights had turned off and the enormity of what she was returning to properly hit her.

Adora shouldn't have been surprised that after a fairly positive few weeks keeping a low profile at Thaymore Bistro, Catra had sunk everything deeper in mere seconds. Witnessing her ex at the party now - her temple leaning in to the press of Eve's lips, her hip flush against the blonde's palm as they chatted to friends, the way Catra was clearly trying to ignore all their old university mates, her eyes flickering across the room in poisonous darts, daring anyone to disturb her - made Adora wonder whether seeing her might inexplicably be the hardest part of all.

Adora excused herself from the group and made her way towards the downstairs bathroom;but she hadn't even realised she'd charged right ahead of it and out of the front door before she was gulping down cool air, the winter frost nipping at her skin. She spotted a half-empty bottle of vodka on the porch - clearly set down during someone's cigarette break and forgotten - and swiped it quickly, as if it would be catastrophic for someone in their mid-twenties to be caught drinking. She turned round to face the front door, deciding to switch tact and duck through the garden gate to the rear of the house for a solitary breather. Miraculously, it was completely empty.

Adora settled herself on the cold patio steps, twisting the blue lid off the Grey Goose and staring the liquid within down - as if it were necessary to make it cower - and thrust the cool liquid to the back of her throat, once, twice, three times.

Reeling from the alcohol, Adora waited for the numbness she craved so badly to kick in, but of course, her impatience only served to remind her that the last time she'd had anything harder than half a glass of champagne after a championship, Catra had been the person who soothed her, who had made the pain ripping her apart halfway bearable.

Adora leaned forward, holding her head in her hands. There had to be *something* that could fix the burning misery that was swallowing her whole. She scrambled around the plant pots next to the patio steps, searching between terracotta urns and wild flowers. Adora knew that Perfuma always had some weed in the house - Lord knows she'd harped on enough about how much it could help Raz, if Adora would just let her bring a little over for her grandmother - and Perfuma had always prided herself on growing all her plants and produce herself. Adora barely knew anything about weed, but she couldn't imagine that it would be an exception.

Just as the soil had started to catch under her fingernails, a familiar giggle caught Adora off-guard. She twisted on the steps to face the house and clamped her fist around the Grey Goose bottle again;the sliding doors had been forced open at one end, two bodies pushing and pulling over the threshold as they flittered flirtatiously between the indoors and the outdoors. Undeterred by the turn in her stomach, Adora couldn't look away , trapped by the sight of someone else's arms around Catra's waist, stealing kisses from her lips, drawing out sounds that she used to draw out.

Adora couldn't believe that Catra and Eve had the audacity to be so affectionate in front of her all night - it was hard to believe it wasn't some sick show of possessiveness from this seemingly perfect smiling woman who Catra had learned to love in Adora's absence.

Her annoyance only grew when Catra finally parted from the blonde, and had the nerve to look surprised when she saw Adora on the steps, as if this hadn't been part of her plan to torture Adora for all the ways in which she'd fucked them up. But then Catra' s fingers twitched, and instead of reaching out for Adora like they always did in the past, she tucked them into the pockets of her jeans, her thumbs sliding into the belt loops that her girlfriend's fingers had been hooked into only seconds before to pull Catra closer and capture her lips.

It suddenly hit Adora in full force, even though she'd known the facts of it for weeks: Catra really was unavailable, and doing anything to

change that reality would only serve to make both their lives exponentially worse.

Adora had spent most of her teenage years pining after what she knew was horribly wrong to want. A lifetime later, it only took mere seconds for all of her work disentangling her hatred from herself to unravel as if it had never happened at all.

Chapter 6

Chapter Notes

> A regular weekly update? Scandalous.
>
> Even more shocking considering I went down a complete Arcane hole this week and exploded/ugly cried at my boss, oops. At least I've no excuse for dropping behind schedule after all that, haha.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It only took seconds for the air between them to crack.

"You can't look at me like that," Catra hissed, her breath battering the night sky with white fog, "Not when you've been..."

Adora curled into herself as Catra's voice trailed off, her bare arms hugging the tall bottle to her chest.

"What?" She watched as Catra blinked in confusion, her features failing to mask the hurt Adora recognised far too easily, "Just leave me alone, *for once*."

"I don't know what the fuck's happened, Dor, but whatever this thing is you're trying to do - it's pretty fucking shitty."

Catra sniffed, goosebumps rising all over her skin despite the thickness of her coat. Adora cursed herself for the thousandth time, wishing that she could just be *normal,* that the other woman didn't make her question every one of her words or actions, no matter how meaningless they really were. The effect Catra had on her even after all these years was sickening. Adora wasn't sure how long she could bear it.

"I'm not *doing* anything," Adora's teeth began to chatter, "I'm just"…

She exhaled forcefully instead of finishing her sentence, her eyes falling to the ground in resignation. She ran her fingers around the rim of the Grey Goose bottle cap, so hyper focused on the feel of metal against her quivering hands that she didn't notice Catra's growing proximity until the woman was standing right in front of her, her hand reaching out towards the vodka.

"At least tell me you've not had any of that stuff. I thought you were still sober?"

"I am, nincompoop," Adora couldn't hold back a derisive giggle at the lie, the haze of the alcohol she'd drunk starting to settle on her, "One hundo percent sober here."

"Nincompoop?" Catra raised an eyebrow; Adora wished she hadn't, her head spinning with visions of the countless times she'd been hit with the damning twitch of Catra's brow, "You're definitely clean as a whistle. Gimme."

Adora leaned away from Catra but it was no use. The brunette had always been able to make her do anything in the world - well, *almost* anything - and the feel of smooth glass cupped in her palm disappeared before she'd even noticed her fingers were loosening around its curves. She suddenly felt useless, weaker than she had in years; every cell in her body strained to leave this party, Bright Moon, her grandmother, *her…*

Every reminder of the lives Adora had walked away from, of the zig zag route she'd been following blindly, was taunting her, laughing in her face, and Adora had no idea how she'd possibly get through the rest of the night, let alone the week or the month; but then Catra tugged on her hand, holding her knuckles up towards the light of the house, and Adora had to accept that - at least in this moment - there was nowhere else she could possibly ever want to go.

"Why do you have dirt all over your hands?"

"It' s nothing," Adora scrambled to think of any answer that wouldn't make her seem so pathetic, but she could already tell the vagueness of her responses was furthering the brunette's irritation, the thumbs kneading her palm hesitating for a frustrated second, "I'm not"…

Im not your problem anymore.

Catra let go; impossibly , Adora's hand felt even colder than it had before, swinging limply back into her lap as if her bones had softened into gel.

"Stop bullshitting me. Jesus, Dor , you're freaking m-"

Catra stopped abruptly, halting before history could repeat itself. It was too dangerous to let a misstep risk their sanity - Adora knew that the wrong words would suck them back into a phantom pain that should have long faded into nothing. The wind whistled between them and held their silence.

Eventually Catra perched on the edge of the wall beside Perfuma's plants, her legs dangling over the edge near the steps Adora sat on. They sat stiffly, neither of them willing to step into zones of discomfort and danger. Yet Adora knew there was only so long she could hold out when it came to Catra. She fought to push her queasiness down to the very bottom of her stomach, hopeful that she could say something *right,* something that could make their stalemate bearable.

"It really is nothing. I was looking for"… Adora grimaced at the realisation she would have to tell the truth if she wanted to make any progress, and she was glad in the moment that the vodka was proving to have provided a little liquid strength, "I thought that 'cause Perfuma grows everything herself, she'd probably have some *you know* out here."

"Huh?" Catra narrowed her eyes quizzically before the realisation dawned on her, a grin spreading across her face as she tried not to laugh, "Are you…are you talking about *pot*?

Adora bit her lip, recoiling a little from the chuckle that Catra didn't hold back.

"You can't grow that stuff out here, idiot! Not if you care about keeping your record clean, anyway."

"If I'm clueless, it's your bloody fault. You never shared."

"You didn't really want it, Adora. Don't stick me with that."

The despondence in Catra's voice shamed her. Adora sighed, rubbing her jaw to ease the ache that had settled in her bones from the cold.

"You knew me too well."

Do you still know me, deep down?

Catra's expression was woefully unreadable. Adora wished she could believe that Catra was asking herself the same question, wondering whether they had ever really learned not to decipher every imperceptible action of the other. She tried to brush the thought away as quickly as she could. Adora had been teetering on the line between delusion and denial for so long that it was impossible to tell what was real. She was too slow to figure Catra's feelings out regardless; her features were already dissolving into something else entirely, a long-lost softness gleaming in her irises.

"You really want to try it now? It's not going to mess with your training?"

Adora could hear the curiosity in Catra's tone, but it didn't make her want to shut down the way everyone else's probing did.

"Training's not a problem anymore."

Catra nodded after a brief pause - Adora hoped the tremble of her bottom lip had passed as a simple shiver - and pushed past Adora towards the back of the garden.

“What are you doing?”

Adora failed to stop panic from bleeding into her voice;Catra turned back round to peep at her, mismatched eyes examining every inch of her face. She could feel a hot blush creeping up her neck despite the bitter cold, but then Catra seemed to flinch in distaste, her pupils flicking hurriedly over to the back of the garden. Adora tried to bury her concern that once again, she’d done something wrong, or failed to do something she didn’t even know was right. She decided it was better to focus on Catra as she crept up to the birdhouse by the far fence, her fingers fixing into its roof and easing it upwards.

“Lucky for you, I figured this out years ago,” Catra smirked as she retrieved a small silver tin, papers and a lighter from the wooden structure, “Flower girl and Scorp in there are a lot less subtle than they think.”

Adora could have sworn she saw Catra wink in the moonlight before she dipped her head and returned to the patio steps, sitting down right next to her, the closest they’d been in six years. Adora couldn’t concentrate on how Catra was rolling the joint;the rustling of filters and papers and ground herb between the pads of a thumb and a fingertip sank into an unimportant neverland. There was only the graze of nylon against Adora’ s icy elbow, and the tickle of a stray, curling hair sailing through the wind to rest on her forearm.

Adora took the thin cylinder from Catra when it was proffered to her and lifted it to her lips.

“Not yet, dummy ,” she looked into Catra’ s eyes, expecting to see amusement but only finding affection, “Let me light it for you first.”

Catra moved further into Adora’s space and guided her fingers around the spliff, encouraging her to rotate it slowly between her thumb and forefinger as a flame flickered at its end. Adora stared at it in her hand as the orange light began to glow and smoulder, closing her eyes in preparation of her first inhale. She spluttered as

hot ash grated against the pit of her throat, a burning wheeze pushing through her lips.

"Easy there," Catra's hand moved to her cheek, perhaps instinctively, but Adora wasn't sure, "Go slowly."

Adora leaned into Catra's palm as she mirrored her measured inhale, trying hard not to imagine that her guiding breaths were anything more than a simple teaching exercise. The heat didn't burn as hotly the second time, a thin, woody flavour coating her tongue through the exhale. Catra's hand still hadn't left Adora's cheek.

"You're so cold."

Catra spoke as if it weren't completely obvious, as if Adora hadn't been shivering in just her shirt the entire time they'd been in the garden. Adora's chest tightened as she passed the pint back to Catra, drinking in her ex's face as she repeated the words she'd been greeted with only a short while earlier.

"You can't look at me like that."

It hurts too much, knowing that I can't have you.

Catra swallowed thickly, waiting until Adora took the pint back again and inhaled a third time.

"I'm not trying to, I don't know how else."

Adora's hand covered Catra's, worryingly close to her lips. It took everything not to kiss the centre of Catra's palm, not to breathe in the earthy scent of her that had always been so grounding. Catra tore her hand away - Adora felt like she could break from the loss of her touch - but then padded fabric descended on her shoulders, draped awkwardly across her broad muscles. The hand she already missed suddenly doubled, her own fingers now sandwiched between two hot palms, friction sparking back and forth to warm them up.

It was simply too much. Adora felt her voice crack before she could taste her own tears on her tongue.

"I can't be here anymore."

Catra nodded like she always had, because when it came to Adora and her breaking points, she'd almost always understood.

"You don't have to be, Princess."

Catra had to stop justifying it to herself.

There's no way you could have let her go home on that bike, not in this state.

She could still feel the ghost of Eve's lips on her cheek when she'd explained her old schoolmate was in a state and despite her budding migraine, she'd rather drop her off on her way home than risk her getting hurt. As expected, Eve posed no objections, only checking to make sure that Catra genuinely was happy for her to stay at the party and get a cab later. She replayed the memory of their goodbye in her head, trying not to focus on her untruths.

I do still have a bit of a headache.

She sighed, hesitant to admit it was a bit of a stretch even if founded a little in truth. Catra would usually be keenly fixated on getting into bed when the heaviness of amplified artificial sound drilled into her, but all she could think of was the woman dozing in the passenger seat, her gentle snores filling the car.

You had to make sure she got home safe. There's nothing wrong with that, if anything, the opposite!

Catra wasn't sure how to interpret their earlier interactions. It had been torture stopping her fingers from reaching out for the swelling trap muscles nestling under her ex's collar;the printed men' s shirt she'd been wearing suited her so much more than Catra would have ever imagined when they were younger. Yet as much as it looked good on, Catra couldn't prevent her mind from wandering towards how much better it might look *off.*

Adora's mood, however - not to mention her attempts at conversation - was far more confusing than Catra's blossoming desire. She'd been deeply reluctant to accept Catra' s offer to drive her home, mumbling that she didn't even want to go back to her house, and that if she'd been smarter , she could have stretched the night out longer. Catra was grateful that Bow had finally talked some sense into Adora, practiced from appeasing Glimmer in her own oblivious and drunken state, and hadn't posed any obstacles to Catra doing the job. She wondered if she'd be in this position if anyone else had overheard her speak to Eve about it first.

Catra frowned as she pondered Adora's ramblings, her ears pricking up at every indecipherable murmur from the sleeping woman. She didn't get annoyed about not understanding everything that often anymore, but her failing determination to work out what Adora was saying was infuriating. Every half-slurred word and missed syllable felt like a personal shortcoming designed to thoroughly humiliate her.

Most of all, it made Catra feel like she was hopeless, completely unable to reach the blonde. Even when Mara had died and everything had burned around them, the truth spilling out like hot lava and scalding everything in its path, Catra hadn't felt that Adora was so far away, so closed off from everyone. Closed off from her.

What happened to you after me, to make you like this?

Catra paused at a red light, thinking back to the furtive moments she'd spent reading up on Adora' s races, pretending she wasn't searching for a glimpse of blue-grey eyes in official Etheria team

photos, her heart jumping every time she saw a teammate's hand resting on a sculpted shoulder or hip.

<u>Who</u> happened to you?

There wasn't much time to come to any conclusions - as they pulled up to the house that Catra had insisted multiple times she remembered the route to - Adora began to stir. When Catra saw Adora's disappointment that they'd reached their destination, she knew she couldn't just leave her there alone.

"Just because she left doesn't mean you should leave her. Besides, she needs you, doesn't she?

They stumbled into the house, kicking off their shoes and coats in the dim of Adora's hallway. Catra fumbled to find the light switch and marvelled at how nothing looked any different to how it had nearly a decade earlier.

"Fuck," Adora swore groggily as she leaned on the stair bannister, her head hanging, "Huntara will be pissed if we've woken her."

"Huntara?"

Adora flopped a little, barely holding herself up. Catra was sure she wouldn't get any answers from her in this state.

"Come on," Catra pulled her towards the kitchen, "Let's get you some water before you go to bed."

Unlike the entrance of the house, Catra hardly recognised the kitchen; although the cabinets and appliances hadn't changed, it was more orderly and organised than she'd ever seen, plates stacked neatly in their open cabinets and glasses arranged by height instead of by how frequently they were used. Clearly, Adora was in charge of the house now, her penchant for orderliness stamped all over the countertops - there was no way a kitchen governed by Razz would ever be this tidy.

Catra studied Adora with a beady eye as she sipped at the water she'd given her . She looked more tired than Catra remembered, wearier than she'd noticed in the short discourse they'd had since Adora returned to Bright Moon. They stood in silence for the second time that evening, Catra insisting that Adora finish her glass no matter how many times she claimed she didn't need it.

Catra didn't expect Adora to grab at her hand once she'd set her emptied glass clumsily into the sink, jerking her out of the kitchen and towards the stairs.

"A-Adora. What are you doing?"

The woozy woman peered back at Catra with confusion, as if she were doing the most obvious thing ever.

"Don't you want to see Razz before you leave?"

What's wrong with you? Why would anyone think she was trying it on when she's in this state? Of course it's only for her grandmother.

"Oh, sure," Catra surprised herself with how calm and collected she'd managed to sound, "That would be nice."

"Not that nice," Adora's tone had hardened, unexpected bitterness seeping through, "Perfuma says it's not so bad, but she never admits how shit things really are."

Catra stayed quiet, unsure of what to say and where the conversation could be going. They reached the top of the stairs, turning into the same bedroom Catra had tiptoed past a million times in their teenage years. The first thing she noticed was how small Razz looked, her slight frame seeming even tinier in the huge bed with its plastic railings. The IV stand and bag loomed over her, a box of disposable bedpans at the foot of the bed; this wasn't the life that Catra had ever imagined Razz leading, but it was unmistakably near its end. Razz groaned, her fingers twitching towards bedside tables stacked with short towers of pillboxes.

"Adora"…

Catra's whisper trailed off. There was nothing she could really say, knowing that Raz was the only family Adora had left.

"She doesn't remember me anymore. She thinks I'm Mara."

Adora almost sounded sober, as if the sight had shaken her back into the requirements of responsible caring.

"This is why you're home."

Catra didn't miss how Adora paused before responding, her answer sidestepping Catra's statement entirely.

"No-one knows apart from Perfuma, Bow and Glimmer . I don't want it to be like last time."

Catra didn't find her reasoning entirely unpredictable. Mara's death had been grossly public; that had almost been the hardest part of it.

"Catra?" Adora gasped in disbelief as Raz's question drifted over from the centre of the room, "is that you, dearie?"

They stared at each other for the briefest moment, their breathing suspended in surprise.

"She remembers you?"

Catra could feel Adora's eyes burning into her as she crossed the carpet towards the old woman, hoping that her decision to do so wasn't offensive.

"I'm so glad you're here. My Adora's been miserable without you."

"Raz," Catra could feel a lump building in her throat, but she was determined not to cry, not in front of Adora, "it's so good to see you again."

"Look after her for me, wont you? I always knew the two of you would end up together. Those boys she used to carry on with could never light a candle to you. Even when you were little I could tell you were made for each other."

"We're not." Adora was suddenly next to her, and Catra did everything she could to stifle her shock, "She's with someone else, Raz."

"Dont be silly, Adora, it's always been you and her. Dont tell me you've forgotten about her, now that you're studying?"

Adora leaned towards her grandmother, tears blinking down her face, "We're not at university anymore, Grandma. We havent been for a while."

Catra startled at Adora calling Raz anything other than her name; Adora had been so insistent on keeping that boundary in place since their teenage years.

"Pshht. Next youll be telling me we no longer bake together. That would never be true now, would it, Adora?"

"No"…

Catra wasn't sure if she should stay; the intimacy of the exchange between her ex and Raz was profound, and she had no idea whether Adora genuinely wanted her there. She readied herself to step away from the bed, willing her feet to move, when Raz's tone of voice completely switched.

"Mara, dearie, what on earth are you doing up at this time of night?"

Raz looked at Adora in bewilderment before blinking slowly, turning back to her pillow and towards sleep. A low whine left Adora; she dropped to her knees by the bed, her face buried in the edge of the mattress. Catra felt a wave of sad familiarity wash over her. She knew she'd been a witness of this scene twice before, although

she'd been told she was unconscious the second time it had happened.

Adora's shoulders shook, and the movement broke her out of her thoughts. Catra crouched down to the floor, laying a careful hand on her back.

"She hasn't called me Adora once the whole time I've been home. But you. She really recognised you."

Catra gulped nervously instead of answering, still apprehensive of becoming too close, of overstepping where she was no longer wanted.

"Don't think about everything she said before, please. She doesn't know what she's saying, it's all just the Al-Al-ei-"

Even if she hadn't still been wearing her hearing aids, Catra wouldn't have needed to hear what Adora was saying to tell that she was starting to break. She ignored her insecurities and jumped in quickly, keen to absolve Adora's struggle.

"Hey, Adora. It's okay. I know."

"She always thinks I'm Mara. But I'm not. I'm not her."

"I know you're not."

Catra was intimately aware of Adora's complex relationship with Mara, how resolute she used to be about never following in her mother's footsteps. She could only imagine how much it hurt Adora to be cast in Mara's shadow, even by illness or mistake.

She hoisted Adora to her feet, leading her to her own bedroom, the room she remembered most of all in the house. She noticed instantly that Adora's bedroom was the most changed of all;posters of TV shows and doodles on lined paper had been replaced by newspaper clippings and photos of Adora's swimming career at Bright Moon

University, Salineas University and then on Team Etheria - likely pinned up by Razin previous years, if Adora' s distaste for self-congratulation still applied.

Catra helped Adora over to her bed, taking a seat beside her. If what Adora had said about training no longer mattering was true, Catra didnt know how she could bear to be surrounded by all these reminders. Adora's caginess on the subject certainly didnt make it seem as if the circumstances were positive, or perhaps even if the situation had been of her own choosing.

"Y ou should be proud of yourself, Adora, for all of this," Catra fought her nervousness, hopeful that they had found a turning point, that they could speak as if they were friends again, "Y ou should be proud about choosing to come home too."

"Maybe. Everything' s a mess."

Catra's breath hitched. She was too affected by Adora's anguish, too far gone where she was never supposed to travel.

"Definitely . I know it hurts, but maybe it doesnt have to matter to Razwhether youre Mara or Adora - either way , she knows you love her."

When you loved me, it was impossible not to know.

Just as she began to regret saying anything, Adora squeezed her hand. Catra looked up, and then she saw it - the low grade keyboard that Adora had spent all her pocket money on buying so that Shadow Weaver never had any excuse to stop Catra from coming over;shed sat on her bed for hours while Catra practiced for her recitals and exams, both of them fully aware that Shadow Weaver would manage to find out if she hadnt.

The keyboard was still in Adora's room, even though so much else had gone. If Adora hadnt broken the silence then, Catra was sure shed never have been able to do it.

"You always knew what to say, Cat."

Something was thawing inside both of them;even the use of her nickname, only tolerated when spoken by her loved ones, didn't irk Catra at all.

Adora continued, her voice wavering, "I'm sorry that I didn't...that I wasn't strong enough after what happened in Dryl. I've never forgiven...I'll never forgive myself for it."

Has the past been hurting her so much, for all this time? Just like it's been hurting me?

"It's okay, Adora. Please, you need to look after yourself, I can't..."

I can't bear seeing you this way.

"It's too hard, missing you like this."

I know.

"I wish this were all different, I wish..."

Catra knew she was toeing a fine line. Adora was only so loose-lipped because of the alcohol and the pot, and Catra was sure that this conversation would never have happened without their influence. But Adora was still as addictive to Catra as she always had been;there was no other option. Catra *needed* to find out whether her suppressed fantasies of Adora's unresolved longing held any truth or if they were just a desperate manifestation of some other distorted issue she'd yet to properly identify.

"You wish...?"

"I wish I'd never let you go."

She couldn't bring herself to reciprocate Adora's words, but Catra could no longer quell what she'd denied for years. *She* was who had

happened to Adora, and Adora was who had happened to *her,* and apparently, their maddening cycle had yet to stop spinning.

Catra twisted her body and rested her forehead on the blonde's own, brushing stray hairs out of the way and cradling her jaw with a trembling hand. She could feel the tension inside her snap as Adora's face inched closer to hers and her arms reached out to encircle Catra's torso. Catra knew that this was how they were always supposed to be, where each of them belonged. Where they fit.

For the split second that their lips hovered close, Catra let herself pretend that the previous six years had never happened, that they'd never hurt each other, that neither of them had ever changed. Catra was held in Adora's arms again, and she realised she'd give anything to turn back the clock and rewrite history;for Adora' s wish to have never needed to be made.

Chapter End Notes

We're going time travelling next time... hang onto your hats :)

Comments/feedback bring a beaming smile to my face, would love to hear from you (I'll treasure them all)!

Chapter 7

Chapter Notes

> A brand new tattoo in the irritating itching stage and an even newer cough/cold (PCR result pending) set this publishing schedule back, so thanks for your patience.
>
> Next few chapters will all take place in the uni years, so the origins of Catra and Adora's original romance will be cracked wide open, not to mention how it all fell apart...!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

EIGHT YEARS AGO

The first time Adora Gray was kissed by Catra Weaver, it didn't mean anything at all. Or at least, that's what she'd been telling herself for nearly two years since.

They'd only been sixteen, and Catra had drunk three Smirnoff Ices by the time the last of December morphed into the first of January, and the fireworks weren't quite bright enough for anyone to see who kissed who in the inky darkness. Still, for something so fleeting, the memory of Catra's breathy giggle against Adora's lips had long overstayed its welcome.

A few times, Adora had managed to convince herself that it wasn't the kiss that had made that night so unforgettable. She could pretend that her heart hadn't started beating a little faster when she'd seen Catra's pupils momentarily drop to her lips, or that the excitable churn in her stomach hadn't turned when she'd come close enough to ghost the hollows of Adora's collarbone with her breath.

Ever since, Adora had spent enough time practicing her poker face to trick her body into believing that it practically didn't happen at all. Yet as she and Catra got further into their first term at Bright Moon

University, she often found herself ruminating on that night, the crack of sparklers and distant fireworks echoing in her ears. Her skin would tighten at every flash of curly hair she saw out of the corner of her eye, or any snippet of a gleeful cackle that even partly resembled Catra's own unmistakable laugh. And somehow, almost every time, she'd find a text, or message or meme from her friend appear on her phone right after, as if Catra's ears were burning.

If she didnt know better , Adora would qestion whether the whole thing was one giant game.

t' s kind of what Ideserve, isn't it?

Adora wondered whether Catra used to feel this way when Mara moved her to Central Bright Moon Academy, prising her away from Horde High.

Did she see reminders of me everywhere when Iwas gone, searching for me when Iseemed far away?

It was hard to come to terms with it, how she'd spent the final years of her school career living a completely different life to Catra, her friendship group completely reinvented. Adora still struggled to believe that her scholarship to the Academy hadnt just been the latest in a long string of Light Hope's messy schemes designed to keep Mara close. For as long as Light Hope had been in their lives, the constant push and pull of heartbreak had coloured Adora's childhood for the worse.

Until Glimmer and Bow befriended her at the Academy, Catra had been the only person who knew how much Adora hated Light Hope, how she wished that she could be part of a bog-standard, stereotypical family that never incited any taunts or teases. That was something they had in common;Catra had always wished for a normal mother too.

The difference between them was really in how they predicted what would come next. When Adora had broken the news that Mara was

moving her away from the East End again, it had been like Catra knew something she didn't.

"Maybe it won't be so bad? I was only gone for a couple of weeks last time."

"Yeah, maybe."

Of course, Catra's pessimism was proved right in the end; it had never been that simple to predict how long it took for the rollercoaster of Mara and Light Hope's love to reach its peak, only to plummet before the next slow climb began.

If Adora were completely honest, Catra had seemed distant ever since she left the East End, even despite the kiss. For months after she started at the Academy, she'd noticed that Catra always zoned out of their phone calls, often not replying to texts for days at a time. To begin with, it had been an easy excuse for Adora to fear that Shadow Weaver might be pushing Catra too hard; it wouldn't have been the first time that enforced hours-long piano practice resulted in numb or sore fingertips. But Adora had known that Catra had never let Shadow Weaver and her relentless push towards a narrow of definition success get between her and Adora before. Soon, she had had to face up to it: either Catra was done with her, or her infrequent contact was due to a whole other type of distraction.

For weeks, Adora had tried to ignore her concern, pushing it down through swim meets and training, long school days and even longer homework sessions, until eventually, Catra's silence got the best of her. She'd deleted and rewritten her question over and over again before Glimmer had torn the phone out of her hands in exasperation and pressed 'send' on Adora's behalf to get her out of the locker room and into the pool.

Catra's delayed response had been as out of the blue as Adora's question.

Y B

It had thrown Adora off completely. For years, Catra had refused to do anything but hole up in Adora's bedroom every New Year's Eve, waving away any party invite that had come either of their way. It had surprised her enough to make Adora beg Mara to drive her and her friends to the East End for the party, promising to play nice with Light Hope in return.

Adora remembered how Catra's face had twisted a little when she'd seen her Academy friends follow her into the party, her hand reaching for her first Smirnoff bottle, then a second, and barely speaking to Adora at all. It had taken the whole night to inch nearer and nearer to Catra, mitigating every jbe thrown in Glimmer and Bow's direction;but they'd ended up side by side in the end. Closer than they'd been in months.

She hadn't wanted to admit how much it hurt when Catra finally called her a couple of months later, only to ask Adora if she could speak with her mother.

"*You want to talk to Mara?*

Don't be weird about it, Adora, I just want to run something by her ."

"*Is something wrong?*

There had been a pause on the other end of the line, followed by a sharp sniff.

"I have this thing with someone, and I thought Mara might have some good advice."

Mara? Adora had been so confused by Catra's hesitation, not to mention the strangeness of her request, "*I know I'm not the most*

experienced but Ihave dated a few guys, and I-"

"She' s better placed for it, alright?"

The realisation had hit Adora like a ton of bricks. Perhaps their unmentioned New Year's kiss *had* stirred something in Catra's belly like she'd been pretending it hadn't in hers - but did Catra' s confession mean that Adora had wasted too much time trapped by her own denial? Had she let herself be overtaken by someone else before she'd even figured out where she stood on the map?

"*Oh, fuck."*

The swear had slipped through her lips before she had any chance of composing herself. Adora shouldn't have been surprised by Catra's immediate hiss, or the conclusion she'd quickly drawn.

"Wow . Are you serious?"

"Wait, that's not what I-"

"I didn't think you'd be… Y ou know what? Forget it."

"No, no, Catra. Please, Ididn't mean-"

The line had gone dead before Adora could finish her sentence, but not before the beast of panic in her chest began to howl. She had never been more decisive than when she'd chased down three buses on her way to Catra's doorstep that night, drenched to her bones in the mid-March downpour.

She should have known turning up unannounced on a school night would only drive a bigger wedge between Catra and Shadow Weaver, who ignored her daughter's requests to send Adora home.

"*Don't be so rude, Caterina. Didn't I raise you to behave properly in front of guests? It' s a wonder Adora even wanted to come all this way to see you."*

She'd stumbled into Catra' s room after Shadow Weaver finished reprimanding her, flushing with embarrassment and guilt. Yet Catra had barely reacted at all to her mother or Adora's arrival, drumming her painted black fingernails on her thigh as if Adora's presence was the biggest inconvenience she'd ever experienced.

"I'm so sorry , Catra," Adora had blurted out her apologies the second the bedroom door had closed behind her, "*I promise you, it came out completely wrong, I was thinking about…"*

Adora had been unable to finish her sentence once more, paralysed by how close she'd come to giving herself away .

"What?"

Catra's voice had been as acerbic as ever, her stony gaze looming over Adora's from the bed.

"I… I just want you to feel like you can talk to me about anything. Especially this. I mean, Mara' s gay, it's not like I'm not used to being around lesbians-"

"You hate Mara being with Light Hope."

Adora had been shell shocked by the statement for a second, even though it was true. She'd never taken the time to think much about whether her dislike of Light Hope stemmed from more than the disruption she always caused;but it was true that Adora resented every bullying taunt that was thrown at her in the corridors of every school or gym she'd ever attended, every accusation of wrongness her family garnered from others.

She had no idea what to say, other than what she thought could reassure her friend.

"I'd never hate you, Catra."

Adora had desperately willed her friend to remember the definite reasons she begrudged Light Hope and Mara: the fear that she'd be dragged from Raz's home; and the constant anxiety that her mother would disappear overnight, driving out to wherever her girlfriend called her regardless of how much Adora needed her. Maybe it hadn't been telepathic, but eventually Catra had pulled a towel off her bedpost and thrown it at Adora to dry herself off. It had been a tiny concession, but enough to make Adora think that Catra might have actually understood. She'd taken a risk then, tiptoeing forward a tiny step.

"You really can talk to me about what's going on. But if you want Mara, I'll ask her for you."

Catra had shifted on her pillows, making room for Adora to join her on the bedspread. She had spoken slowly, cautiously.

"*I think Scorpia has a crush on me.*"

Adora had blinked, swallowing her nervousness.

"*Do you like her back?*"

She'd braced herself for confirmation that never came.

"No. But I… I think I do like girls."

The nervous energy that had swept through Adora in response had been profound, challenging her shaking belief that she could never act on the wild tingling in her gut. For a split second, she had imagined having permission to look and touch, and to not have to keep her eyes trained firmly on the carpet every time they got changed into their pyjamas.

"Well… That sucks for Scorpia, but it's great news for all the other girls."

"Yeah? Catra had seemed more unsure than Adora remembered her being before, " *Ihave to figure out how to tell her . Ill have no-one if Idon't have her ."*

"You'll have me."

"You're not really here anymore, Dor ."

When Adora had found out Catra got accepted to Bright Moon University's music school, she'd turned down her Salineas University offer immediately. Her decision to reject the country' s most prestigious college swimming program hadn't made much sense to anyone else, but Bright Moon was the best for studying classical composition, and Adora couldn't bear to have Catra' s loneliness on her conscience again.

Despite the fact they still weren't as close as they used to be, the few instances that they had hung out on campus and binge watched cheesy movies in Catra's room confirmed to Adora that she'd made the right choice. Of course, Adora longed for more - but the fear of driving Catra away was bigger than her hope that their old bond could be recovered, or that it could grow into something new.

Adora's damp ponytail stuck to the back of her neck as she watched Catra from afar. It was easy to zone out of the conversation that was swirling around her, nodding at whatever her swim teammates were saying, as long as it meant she could keep one eye trained on the brunette standing at the bar. Adora played at guessing what Catra was ordering - it was pointless, she absolutely knew it would be pint of draught Stella - but her attention was diverted when Scorpia suddenly showed up, slinging her arm around Catra's shoulders. Even though Catra had never entertained the notion of romance with

the tall, muscular woman, Adora couldnt help but feel slighted somehow, as if Scorpia had replaced her as Catra's favourite.

What is she doing here? She doesn't even go to Bright Moon!

When Catra set her beer down at the table next to the one Adora was sitting at instead of the same one, it was like all her anxieties were confirmed.

It's just in your head. You and Catra are still OTP best friends, nothing could really get in the way of that, not after everything that's already happened!

The mantra didnt stop Adora from wishing the other woman would leave Scorpia behind, push her teammates out the way and sit beside her instead. It was a battle to stay grounded in the chatter at her own table;she could barely focus on anything else as the glint in Catra's eye gleamed when she cackled at some stupid joke someone else told, or the way amber liquid lapped at her bottom lip when she raised her pint glass to her mouth.

If it wasnt for the sharp nudge of Glimmer 's elbow in her ribs, jolting her attention to the emcee at the front of the room, Adora wasnt sure she'd have ever been able to stop staring at Catra' s mouth. She cleared her throat, grinning excitedly at the rest of her team in the hopes that it would conceal her prior distraction, pretending that she was just as ready for open mic night to kick of f as they were.

Like clockwork, Mermista threw herself into a chair opposite Adora the same way she did every week, seconds before her boyfriend took the stage. It was her fault that the open mic night had become an established hangout for the swim team, using her captain status to corral everyone into grabbing a drink after Friday night training. Yet despite the fact that they teased her mercilessly for it, Mermista would never concede the whole activity was just to make sure Sea Hawk's sea shanties had an audience - and it helped that she always bought their second round of drinks. Seeing Catra and her

music course mates there - not to mention Scorpia - was far less expected.

Halfway through the night, Adora couldnt believe her eyes when Catra was called up by the emcee, her hips swinging as she ascended the short stage steps.

At least I figured out why Scorpia's here.

Adora stared in shock as Catra flexed her fingers, taking her seat at the electric keyboard. She couldnt figure out what Catra might possibly play - it wasnt exactly the vibe for Chopin or Prokofiev , and Adora hadnt heard her turn her hand to anything non-classical since they were fourteen and Shadow Weaver had found out she wanted to try songwriting. She'd made it painfully clear since then that Catra was to focus on 'professional' music *or else* .

As Catra began to play, her hands moving across the keys, Adora's breath caught in her throat, the familiar chords altogether different in a softer, more delicate form. If this was Catra's pitch for a new career direction in a different genre, it was certainly convincing.

[illegible]

[illegible]

[illegible]

[illegible]

She could feel the lyrics on her tongue before Catra's voice rang out over the keyboard, even smoother than she remembered it.

[illegible]

[illegible]

[illegible]

Catra glanced up for just a second then, her closed eyes breaking open to find Adora's own blue-grey irises, and Adora knew she was powerless to stop the blush from erupting like fire all across her face. She shrank a little into her seat, hoping that no-one would notice the hairs standing up on the back of her neck, or how she tightened the cross of her right leg over her left.

"Damn, this girl's got pipes," Adora heard Mermista murmur from across the table, "You know her, Grayskull?"

"They went to school together," Adora had never been so grateful for Glimmer's impatience, resisting the urge to blurt out how much more they meant to each other than that, "You know, before she got scouted for our Academy team."

"The Academy should have scouted her," Adora heard herself say, rushing to get her words out before Catra reached the chorus, "She was way, *way* better than anyone in their music department. She'd have been the best in the whole school."

"Well, that's gay."

Adora's head whipped round to face Flutterina, her eyes narrowing on the shorter swimmer's face. No-one else seemed to have heard what she'd muttered under her breath; Flutterina raised her eyebrows, daring Adora to rise to her tease, and shrugged her shoulders with a smirk when it was clear that Adora had nothing to say back to her.

Frazzled, Adora turned her attention back to the stage, hoping that Catra hadn't looked back at her while she'd been distracted. But as Catra finally broke into the chorus, a wave of abject longing broke over Adora's body - and all at once, stuck in the noisy hubbub of almost everyone she knew, she had no choice but to fully acknowledge the desire she'd been wallpapering over for years.



Then

by

Then

Adora was stuck in a trance, every half-suppressed memory of Catra she'd ever pushed to the darkest depths her brain suddenly resurfacing;the tail end of Catra' s song was set to visions of her impish smiles, the twirl of a ringlet around her fingers, the curve of her waist as it sloped into her hip. Adora had to shake herself out of it when the song ended too soon, forcing her to return to the people all around her.

She recovered in time to see Catra grin with satisfaction at her enthusiastic reception from the audience, her chin jutting up a little with pride as she made her way back to her table. Except instead of returning to her seat, she stopped before the swim team's table, cocking her hip right in front of Adora.

"Hey , Adora. Didn't expect you to be here."

Adora's mouth was dry, her tongue stumbling to offer compliments at the same time that Glimmer spoke loudly over her.

"Did you really arrange that? It was incredible!"

"The swim team' s always here for open mic, Catra. It's kind of our thing."

Catra nodded at Adora, her eyes unmoving from the blonde's face even though her deadpan response was directed at Glimmer.

"Who knew a bunch of pool meatheads could be so supportive of the arts?"

Glimmer snickered, about to protest Catra's insult before Adora jumped in hastily , standing up so suddenly that the Diet Coke in her half-empty glass sloshed a little on the wobbling table.

"That was amazing, seriously, Cat. You should do it every week."

"Thanks," Adora could practically feel her serotonin spike when Catra's expression softened at her words, pleasure seeping through her shy smile, "I'll see you around, Dora."

She slunk back to her table next to Scorpia - who had somehow ended up deep in conversation with Mermista's willowy flatmate Perfuma - leaving Adora to clear her throat awkwardly, lowering herself back down to her seat.

"Well, Grayskull," Mermista crossed her arms as she leant back in her chair, a wry smile dancing across her lips, "Maybe we should have her stand at the end of the lane to make you swim faster."

Adora laughed it off nervously, countless memories of playground teases running wildly through her head.

This is why it won't work. You can't spend another three years staring into your locker while everyone gets changed after practice. You know how bad it can get.

She spent the rest of the night trying to ignore the flicker of Catra's pupils landing on her over and over, pretending she didnt have to stop every cell in her body from launching herself at the other girl and showering her with praise about how amazing she really was. There was only one feasible choice Adora could make, and she had to counter every pang in her chest pulling her to Catra with a reminder of what she had to lose.

It's not worth the risk. Not when you've settled into the team so well, and hardly anyone knows anything about Mara, or Light Hope, or anything else. Who's to say someone wouldn't make problems here too, if you give them reason for it?

Needless to say, the first time Adora Gray allowed herself to dream about Catra Weaver kissing her for real, the magnitude of what it meant scared her beyond belief.

Chapter End Notes

If you want to check out the arrangement of Cyndi Lauper's 'Time After Time' that inspired the idea for Catra's version, it's this gorge cover by Iron & Wine: https://open.spotify.com/track/5EM7lT9SyhUsKXGfSm?si=0a10ae0b3c44361

If there's not actually piano in this (it's prob all guitar), sorry kids, but you got a deaf writer and these are the receipts :)

Would love to know what you think of this chapter as i was very close to scrapping it instead of publishing! I have a much clearer idea of what the next few will look like, and the fluff (maybe the smut...) is finally on its way!

Chapter 8

Chapter Notes

> Will these two eggheads finally stop being such useless lesbians? Better read to find out...

See the end of the chapter for more notes

EIGHT YEARS AGO

Catra was used to waiting for Adora. She'd waited outside swimming pools and gyms, her music theory textbooks heavy in her lap and fingertips tapping while humming and sight-reading sheet music. She'd lingered at the bus stop for Adora to arrive from Central Bright Moon even when she knew the other girl was spending yet another weekend hanging out with her new Academy friends. She'd waited for hours for Adora to arrive at parties in the East End, only for bitter petulance to flood her body when Glimmer and Bow turned up too. Once, Catra had even waited for Adora to kiss her, but all she gained were drunken fantasies and the blurred memory of her third bottle of Smirnoff Ice on a completely empty stomach.

Sometimes if she imagined it hard enough, Catra could sense the tingle of Adora's lips on hers, how long, golden strands would thread through her fingers and the ripple of her breath would cloak sculpted collarbones. Other times, Catra knew the hope that her friend could be interested in her in that way was pure delusion. Adora's knee-jerk reaction to Catra simply alluding to her queerness had proved it. The blonde's subsequent back-pedalling and apology could never change the fact that her true feelings on the matter had been exposed.

Catra knew she had to accept it eventually; waiting for Adora was futile. It had gotten her nowhere but this very moment, imagining it was Adora's fingers filling her, Adora's teeth grazing her neck, Adora's mouth sucking too hard on a spot that would be too visible.

“So it’s the swimmer that does it for you.”

Catra wished that she could hate DT for figuring her out so quickly, but she didn't really feel anything. Not when they were so good at turning a probe into a proposition.

“Oh, kitten. It’s much better to get tangled with a clued-up pal than stay a virgin for your oblivious little straight friend.”

DT never felt *right* but they always felt *good* - and they gave Catra what she wanted whenever she asked for it, even though she never agreed to switch.

“It’s a shame you won’t put those talented fingers of yours to better use.”

Catra rolled her eyes every time, cursing DT for breaking the spell and ruining the illusion that they were someone else entirely.

“You enjoy my fingers enough when you’re performing.”

There was never any way for DT to argue with that. Since the campus celebrity had heard about Catra after her first open mic performance and scouted out her second, Catra had accompanied DT at all their auditions and gigs. It had been a simple agreement for a while - Catra lent her unrivalled musical proficiency to BMU’s rising theatrical starlet and they introduced her to every useful connection that they had along the way.

Catra couldn't deny that DT made life exciting and opened up opportunities - she was only in her second term at BMU, and she already had meetings lined up with multiple agents, all looking to weigh up the value of her pen, her ear and her voice. Catra had never been so close to reclaiming her talents from her mother, and to leaving the role of concert pianist to rot on its unwanted pedestal.

Despite DT’s attempts to convince Catra otherwise, she'd saved those weekly open mic nights for her own performances. She liked to

pretend that it had nothing to do with the swim team's presence;that she never thought about how Adora always seemed to be so fixated on her when she sang, like no-one else existed at all. Nevertheless, when DT had caught onto who Catra was really performing for, they'd startled her . It was embarrassing that she'd been so obvious to someone who knew nothing of her history with Adora, but could unravel years of unrequited longing from a short interaction. Most of all, Catra didn't need reminding that she should have known better than to pine after Adora. There was a reason you didn't find many romcoms about straight girls falling for their lesbian childhood besties.

At least with DT, Catra could have her cake and eat it. No strings attached sex with zero romance, any day of the week. And unlike a real relationship, Catra could hang onto her fantasy by keeping the door open for Adora to walk right through.

Just in case she thinks of me like that, one day…

It was the best of both worlds - and that was far more than an angsty East End girl with a single mum and a second hand keyboard was supposed to get.

Catra groaned as DT thrust their hand back and forth, the heel of their palm cupping her as she trembled around their fingers.

"You like that, kitten?"

"Ah..DT"…

"Yes?"

"Don't fucking call me that..Ahh!Can you..Mmm, I'm nearly there..."

"I bet if I stopped, you'd let me call you anything."

"Wh-What?"

Catra's eyes flew open as DT stilled, their cocky grin hovering above her face. The ache they'd worked up in her core was so intense she could cry, so close to release that it almost hurt.

"I love a little experiment."

"DT , if you don't-"

"What, darling?" DT laughed, their thumb ghosting over Catra' s clit teasingly, purposefully doing nothing to soothe its swollen throb, "Y ou won't let me have my turn?"

Her cheeks burned as frustration flooded her. Catra drove her hips down and pushed into DT's hand, whining when they refused to respond the way she needed.

"Use your words, Catra. Consent is *ever* so important."

"Fuck! Fine, whatever , just get on with it."

"Fine?"..

Catra growled, her fingernails digging into DT's shoulder. She hated when they got like this, when she'd ended up right where they wanted her.

"Y ou can call me kitten," Catra could have sobbed with relief when DT's thumb picked up pace again, their fingers curling inside of her, "But only now . Th-that's it."

"Whatever you say ..."

Catra ignored DT's teases as they resumed their previous rhythm, tuning everything out as she tensed her entire body, squeezing every muscle. Her head fell back as DT took her closer to the edge of her orgasm, not caring about the loud moans pouring from her throat when she finally climaxed. She was aware of DT watching her as she exhaled raggedly, their eyes roaming over her face as they withdrew from her slowly.

"Stop that, it's annoying."

"What?" DT smirked as they rolled from their side onto their back next to her, their head hitting the pillow, "Not even a thank you?"

Catra scoffed, about to respond when a sharp knock rapped on her bedroom door.

"Fuck, it's probably the dickhead next door, he's so pissy about any tiny noise-"

"Not exactly a tiny noise, kitten."

"Oh my God, shut up!"

Catra huffed as DT chuckled, climbing over them to get out of bed and pull her dressing gown around her. Another knock resounded on the door, louder and more urgent than the first time.

"Christ, I'm coming!" Catra grumbled as she reached the door, unlocking and yanking it open, "What?"

Her irritation was replaced by panic the minute she saw who was waiting in the hallway. With red-rimmed eyes and blotchy cheeks, Adora stood wringing her wrists.

"Adora? What's wrong?"

Catra was instantly put on edge by her friend's obvious distress, and she had no idea how to make everything better without making it worse first.

She's going to want to come in, she'll see them.

Adora seemed to hesitate upon hearing Catra's reedy voice, examining her flimsy dressing gown and dishevelled hair.

"Are you sick?"

"No, no, I'm fine."

"You're not dressed at 2pm. And you sound kind of hoarse."

Catra squirmed, instinctively grasping at her neck to cover any burgeoning bruises.

"This is normal for most students, Adora, I just didn't have any classes today," Catra reached out for the blonde with her other hand, "What's going on with you though? You're upset."

Adora's breath shuddered as Catra rubbed her arm soothingly; she racked her brain for how she could look after Adora without inviting her into her room and dealing with the awkwardness of her finding DT in bed.

"I- I didn't know who else to talk to"…

"It's okay, just let me get dressed and we'll go back to yours, yeah?"

"Can't I just come into your room?"

Fuck.

Catra stammered, scrambling for an excuse that would work.

"Don't worry, kitten, I've got places to be anyway."

Catra froze as DT's voice rang out behind her and they slapped her ass playfully as they slipped past her through the doorway. She couldn't bring herself to look at Adora, even though she knew that there was no reason she shouldn't fuck whoever she wanted.

It's not like she would care - at least, not for the reason you'd want her to.

"Oh God, C-Cat," Catra didn't need to see Adora to know that she'd be reeling with discomfort, "You and DT? You were"…

"Dont worry , blondie," DT called over their shoulder as they began to make their way out of Catra's halls, "I made sure she finished."

Catra cringed, pulling Adora into her bedroom and shutting the door behind them.

"Ignore them, they're being a twat."

Adora looked like she'd rather be anywhere else in the entire world, her body somehow shrinking in on itself as she caught sight of the dishevelled sheets on Catra's bed.

"Are you and DT together now? I thought it was just music-"

"No, no.. it' s just a sex thing."

"Right, right.. Not that I care, you know , you should do whatever you want, it's your body, it's not like it matters what I.. I.. I should go."

Of course, she doesn't care. Why should she?

"Adora, you dont have to leave. Y ou came here for a reason."

"Cat"…

Catra hated how Adora looked like she could burst into tears at any moment. She wished that she could hold her tight and soothe her without worrying she was forcing unwanted physical intimacy on her, especially after DT's exit.

"Come on, Dor . Talk to me."

"It' s just swimming stuf f, it doesnt matter ."

Adora wouldnt even look at Catra now , her eyes trained on the floor.

"Course it matters."

Catra waited as Adora stayed silent, her chest heaving up and down with the effort of stopping herself from crying. Catra rested her fingers tentatively on Adora's back and stepped closer to her, encouraging her to sit on her desk chair while Catra perched on the edge of her bed.

"I just thought this team would be different. But it..it follows me everywhere, it doesnt matter how hard I try to stop it."

"What follows you?"

She leaned forward, taking hold of Adora's hand. The blonde seemed to startle a little, but then she squeezed Catra's hand in return, gripping onto her fingers like she was scared Catra might suddenly disappear if she didnt.

"I'm always so careful, I get dressed as fast as I can and leave, I never look at anyone or anything like that."

"What are you talking about? No-one's thinking about anyone else when they're getting changed, Dor, there's no need to be so self conscious-"

"No, I..I'm sure of it, they think Im..that Im"…

Catra sighed. Of course, Adora could barely even say it.

"Dor, why would anyone think you were gay?" Adora seemed to ignore her, biting down impossibly hard on her lower lip, "What are you worrying about this for, anyway? It's not like it's true."

Adora looked at Catra incredulously, as if she were on an entirely different planet. Catra wasnt sure how to respond;what her behaviour meant.

"I shouldnt have come,"Adora jumped to her feet, jamming her hand into her hair so hurriedly that it completely messed up her ponytail, "I'm bothering you."

Before Catra had any chance to protest, Adora left in a flash, a flurry of movement propelling her out of the room. Catra fell backwards onto her bed, trying to process what had just happened.

Adora Gay, what the actual fuck is going on in your head?

Catra was almost surprised to see Adora sitting in her usual spot when Friday evening swung around.

She'd been unable to get through to Adora for days, even resorting to going to the university training pool after her swim practices to see if she could catch the blonde. But Adora had only rushed past her anxiously, leaving Catra to get caught up in unwanted small talk with her teammates about the stupid open mic nights.

Across the room, Mermista waved at her, beckoning Catra to come and join the team instead of sitting alone. She nodded, knowing it would look weirder to decline the request than it would to go over to the swim team and find a seat with them.

Well, at least you can make this a little easier…

Catra bounded over to the bar before joining the swim team, downing a double shot of tequila and biting into salted lime. She could still taste citrus at the corners of her lips as she dropped into a chair next to Glimmer, purposefully avoiding the free place next to Adora.

"Oh, hey Horde scum."

"Great to see you too, Sparkles."

Catra didn't miss how Adora's eyes widened a little at her presence. She wished she'd bought a beer to chase her tequila with. The best she could do was pick a little at the skin around her fingernails, hoping that she'd be called up to perform sooner rather than later. At least she'd feel better once she'd got this simmering tension in her chest out.

"You got a good song?" Catra leaned in towards Glimmer to hear her better, hoping that the conversation would get better than this, "Hate to feed your ego but you're kind of the best act every week."

Catra was taken aback by the warmth blooming inside her; she wasn't used to interacting with Glimmer much beyond their usual sarcastic volley. She'd been annoyed when she found out the pink-haired girl was coming to BMU too, but over the course of their first year, she'd come to accept that her and Adora's friendship was destined to change the minute Mara moved Adora to the Academy, regardless of whether Glimmer and Bow hung around or not.

"Eh, it's a little basic but I'm in the mood for it," Catra shrugged, determined not to look over at Adora, "You might even be able to sing along."

"Wow, you're feeling some kinda way then. No death eyes from you or anything."

Catra snorted, lifting Glimmer's beer from the table and stealing a sip.

"The night's young, don't get too comfortable."

Glimmer's retort was interrupted by the open mic emcee opening with the first set; Catra crossed her arms over her chest when she felt Adora's gaze resting on her. It was one thing to ignore Catra all week, but to openly try and stare her down in front of everyone…

She's got some fucking nerve.

Catra’s turn on stage couldnt come soon enough. Finally , she took her place at the keyboard, her fingers itching to play. It was Catra’s only opportunity to tell Adora what she really wanted, even though no-one would know that was what she was doing;after this, she promised herself she’d close the door for good.

No more imagining Adora’s lips under the fireworks, the feel of her embrace or the flutter of her breath on Catra’s skin.

No more waiting or hoping or wishing. Catra had to believe she deserved more than this;that there was some other girl with golden retriever vibes who was wonderfully, perfectly gay. Someone who would want her as much as she wanted them.

Catra fantasised a whole other life as she sang, her eyes blissfully clamped shut as she dove into an alternate reality far away from BMU's student union bar. These were her final minutes of indulging in the idea of her and Adora together, and she didnt want to spend them in reality at all.

She finished somewhat in a daze, tears prickling at the back of eyes as she let her final notes ring out.

That's it. No more stereotypical yearning. You're done.

Catra took a deep breath as she made her way down the stage steps. The crowd was applauding as loudly as they always did, but she couldnt bring herself to smile. This moment was supposed to be a big liberating moment, the start of a new chapter. Yet all Catra wanted to do was go home and break down.

She halted as she approached the swim team, eyes fixated on her empty seat.

There's no way you can do this.

Catra turned on her heel sharply, swiping her coat off the back of the chair as Glimmer called out after her in confusion, and pushing her way out of the bar.

The minute she hit the cool night air, she couldnt stop the tears from falling. She gulped down air desperately, scrambling to find a positive emotion inside of her.

This is supposed to be good! Why does it feel so shit?

"Cat! Wait up!"

Catra stiffened as she heard the familiar voice behind her;she carried on walking, hugging herself as she picked up pace.

"Hey! Catra!"

She was too slow. She should have known the athlete would easily catch up.

"What do you want, Adora?"

"Are you sure you're not with DT?"

Catra spun round, pushing the other woman away, her hand landing right in the centre of her chest.

"Fuck of f, Adora! Why do you care?"

Adora stammered; it pissed Catra of f even more, her voice rising in the middle of the empty street, beating against the inky sky.

"What do you want me to say? I'm sorry I'm gay? That I'm clearly unearthing some kind of weird, twisted trauma you've been burdened with from Mara? Does that make you feel better?" Catra laughed bitterly, unable to stop the rush of adrenaline unleashing her words, "My God, someone please tell me how I ended up staying friends with an actual fucking homophobe!"

Catra couldn't deny it felt a little good to see the pain in Adora's expression. It was only a splinter of what Catra felt, of the hurt that loving Adora had inflicted on her.

"I'm not a homophobe."

Adora's fists were clenched.

"Well," Catra scof fed, "If it looks like one, and it sounds like one"…

"I can't be."

Adora's hand shot out to grab Catra's, more forceful than she'd ever been before.

"Adora, what are you-?"

"Y our song," Adora tugged Catra towards her gently , "W as it for me?"

"What? Adora." Catra' s voice faltered, her heartbeat racing and stopping all at once, "I dont understand."

Catra stumbled as Adora pulled her into a side street away from the main road, crashing them together against the brick wall of the student union building.

"I cant be homophobic, Catra, because I'v e been waiting over two years for you to kiss me again like you did at Rogelio's party. And I can't wait anymore. I'm done with it."

Kiss you again? W ere the fireworks… were they not just a drunken hallucination?

Adora inched closer, and Catra was sure it was some kind of joke.

"Adora, if this is some stupid bet from your teammates"…

"It' s not a joke, Cat," Catra watched as Adora gulped nervously , her eyes full of sincerity, "I'm kind of scared, but I..I want this. Y ou. More than anything."

Adora leaned forward, her face suspended mere millimetres above Catra's own. She raised her hand to Catra's jaw , her thumb stroking her cheek softly. Catra tilted her head up a little, sure that she could feel every single drop of blood rushing through her veins; Adora was right in front of her, her lips almost close enough to touch. She inched forward the tiniest distance, and before she knew it, Adora was kissing her.

Instantly, Catra could tell it was too familiar. There was no joke involved, no hidden agenda. This *wasn't* the first time they'd kissed, but they no longer needed fireworks to encourage the spark of dynamite exploding between them.

They melded together, gold bleeding into silver as if they were always meant to unite;every touch felt like it was making up for a lifetime of loneliness, of craving the unattainable. Catra had never dared to fully entertain the possibility that she could actually be reading Adora’s skittishness wrong, that her friend's maddening awkwardness wasn't guided by resentment or misplaced bigotry. It had always hurt too much to believe that her deepest desire could genuinely come true. Yet as Catra tasted Adora on her lips and explored Adora’s nape with her fingertips, all the dreams she'd held at arm's length flooded back. There was so much want inside of her, so much desperation for this love to be real. After all these years, Catra had finally stopped waiting.

Adora Gray was truly, undeniably, *hers.*

Chapter End Notes

Let me know what you think of this chapter!Always love to hear your thoughts :)

Chapter 9

Chapter Notes

Well, this started out as fluff...

See the end of the chapter for more notes

EIGHT YEARS AGO

The weight of Catra's hand in hers was the greatest thrill Adora had ever felt. It seemed stupid to think it, that something so simple could easily outdo every hard-fought championship and A*essay . Yet all Adora could do was relish the fact that it was absolutely and undeniably true.

It had been three months since she'd stared dumbly at Catra on-stage, waiting for a teasing smirk that never came.

[illegible]

As the uncharacteristic melancholy of Catra's song had ripped through the room, Adora had willed the lyrics to connect somehow to the kiss they'd shared under the fireworks. She didn't want to consider that Catra could possibly feel more for someone else, or that she'd had moments that rivalled the one they'd shared.

What if I'm not the person she's been singing to?

Suddenly, the reason she'd lost control of her emotions and ignored Catra for days had clarified in front of Adora. She'd been mad because she had no idea who Catra had dated or kissed or fucked aside from DT, and there was nothing more she'd ever wanted than to become the full stop that ended the list.

What if I am?

She'd known Catra was breaking long before she ran out of the bar , way before she'd followed her out.

She'd known it was a risk to even think about asking the question.

She'd known if she didn't find out the truth right then that she might never work up the courage again.

When she learned that the song really had been for her, it had almost been as sweet as the taste of Catra's lips, as soft as Catra's cheek against her own. Every second they spent together energised Adora in an unprecedented way - more than any of the dates or hesitant kisses she'd accepted for years in high school - even if the desire she had for Catra almost made her nauseous. There was nothing more exhilarating than the crashing turn of her gut and the heady race of blood through her veins when Catra was close;than when she grazed the outer seam of Catra' s jeans with the edge of her fingernail as they sat next to one another in the dim light of the student union bar;or when she waited for the telltale moment Catra' s shining irises would find Adora during one of her performances, knowing they'd find themselves somewhere dark and hidden afterwards. If it weren't for the prickle of discomfort every time one of her teammates glanced at them or seemed like they caught her cheeks blushing, Adora could never have let Catra leave her seat for the stage at all.

Mermista's party was turning out to be no exception. Both the women's and men's swim teams had crammed into Mermista and Perfuma's apartment for the captain's birthday, and Scorpia had insisted on bringing Catra along with her at the last minute. Adora knew the entire night would be torture from the second she unexpectedly caught sight of her.

She watched from across the living room as Catra downed shots with Scorpia and finished the end of Perfuma's pint, blowing smoke out of the window casually like she'd been doing it her whole life. Adora couldn't pinpoint when Catra grew from an unwieldy kid with a pushy parent into this worldly, intoxicatingly independent woman, but

she wished that the invisible strings restraining her from launching herself at the brunette could be more easily cut.

"You're not gonna say hello?"

Adora startled at Glimmer's question, though not as much as she did at Flutterina's retort.

"She'd have to stop staring at her to do that."

"What?" Adora spluttered, panic rising in her chest, "I'm not staring. I just haven't had a chance to say hi yet."

"Why , you got your eye on someone else, Adora?" Flutterina cackled, clearly trying to get a rise out of her, "Like who? Sea Hawk? Bow?"

"What is your problem?" Glimmer chimed in, somehow even more irritated than Adora, "She' s not into Bow and you can shut up about Catra. It's weird. Not everyone's obsessed with getting laid, shortcake."

Adora would have laughed at Glimmer teasing someone else for their height if she hadn't been wishing so hard for the ground to swallow her up. Nevertheless, the jibe had apparently floated right over Flutterina's head.

"Come on, like you've never heard of besties yearning until they finally get over themselves and fuck?" Flutterina dropped her voice as she leaned closer to Glimmer's ear, though she still made sure Adora could hear, "As if you don't see Grayskull drooling every time Open Mic turns up. Or are you too busy lusting after-"

"Whatever! I need some air ."

Adora was dragged along with Glimmer as she stormed away from Flutterina angrily. She was too mortified to figure out why her friend had been so upset, or what she'd cut off their teammate from saying.

"Guess I hit a nerve?" Flutterina called after them before downing the rest of her beer, "Should have known Coach's daughter can't take a joke."

"Jesus Christ, there's a lot of asshole stuffed into that girl," Glimmer muttered in Adora's ear as they rounded the corner into the kitchen, "What's her problem anyway?"

Adora shrugged passively, desperate to convey that Flutterina's teasing hadn't affected her.

"I dunno, she's always like that."

Glimmer softened her voice then, enough to make sure the people chatting in the hallway couldn't hear them speak.

"Are you okay, Dor? Does she wind you up like that all the time?"

"It's not a big deal," Adora forced herself to make eye contact with Glimmer, aware that avoiding it had been her tell the whole way through her time at the Academy, "She just likes pissing people off."

"Okay," Glimmer paused, but not for long enough for Adora to change the subject, "Adora, you know that there's nothing you can't tell me, right? I mean, Catra's kind of difficult and she's always been all over the place, so obviously *that's* a bad idea! But if there was someone, I'd have your back. Whoever they are."

"Thanks," Adora shoved down the urge to object to her friend's judgment of Catra as best she could, "But there's nothing to tell."

Glimmer nodded unsurely, though a brusque clearing of a throat interrupted them from the doorway. Almost like her ears had been ringing, Catra pushed past them towards the sink.

"Know where the cups are? Weed always makes me thirsty as fuck."

Adora reached up behind her to fetch a glass, careful not to let their fingers touch and linger as she passed it over. She watched silently

as Catra ran the tap and gulped down cold water, following the bob of her throat as she swallowed.

"Arrow Boy's looking for you," Catra turned to Glimmer, nudging her head towards the door, "You should find him."

When Glimmer had left the kitchen, Catra slotted herself between Adora and the corner of the kitchen counter, her hand resting on the edge of the sink.

"Hey, Adora."

"Hi," Adora twisted around to block Catra's body from anyone else's view, "Is Bow actually looking for her?"

"No," Catra dropped her gaze to Adora's hands, her stance shifting as she got to the point she'd come to make, "Scorp wanted a wingwoman, it's the first time she's been to Perfuma's place."

Adora didn't miss the insecurity in Catra's voice, though there was no chance she'd ask for the reassurance she needed. Adora gave it to her anyway.

"It's good to see you."

She raked her eyes over Catra's thinning tights and baggy t-shirt slowly, grateful that no-one could see her grazing the waistband of the other girl's denim mini-skirt as she reached out to the small of her back. Adora leaned in a little, desperate to chase Catra's scent; they stood with their faces too close for any plausible deniability before Adora broke away. Catra stifled a sigh, but Adora could still tell that a whining exhale was trapped in her chest.

"I'm gonna head home, I think Scorp's fine now."

Adora's pulse spiked at the idea of Catra leaving.

"Can I come with you?"

"I dont know , Dor . Can you?"

Adora grimaced as Catra slipped past her towards the exit, her shoulders a little more hunched than before. She tried to imagine what it would be like to not care about anyone else, how it would feel to pull Catra into her arms and defy everything. The vision fell hollow in the emptiness of her palms.

Ill make it up to you someday , promise.

She chased Catra out of the flat without bothering to tell anyone she was leaving.

Adora kept her eyes shut tight as she woke, stifling a groan as the last dregs of sleep drained from her. She nuzzled a little further into Catra's torso, gently loosening the pads of her fingertips from the back of the other girl's ribcage as she tried to convince herself to get out of bed. It was all too tempting to pretend the morning hadnt come around;Adora never wanted to move when the rise and fall of Catra's chest ebbed underneath her cheek.

"Dont go," Catra' s fingers twitched in Adora's hair, her other hand sliding up Adora's back, "it' s still dark."

"That' s because you have blackout blinds," Adora pressed a kiss to the top of Catra's breast, inhaling the familiar smell of fading detergent mixed with Catra's own scent, "it' s 6am."

Catra groaned, her nails scratching against Adora's skin.

"Y ou could stay."

"I need to get ready for the gym."

"Shower here, you can borrow my clothes," the hope in Catra's voice made Adora wince enough to be grateful that the brunette couldn't see her face, "No-one else will be up."

No-one will see you.

"Glimmer's on your floor, Cat."

Adora hated how Catra deflated a little under her weight, and how the fingertips massaging her roots withdrew. The cycle was always like this: warmth morphing into anxiety and guilt. Catra shifted, arching away from the palm Adora rested on her side. It was a reversal of the hours they'd spent together after the party, of the way Catra's body had melted into Adora's and sought urgent contact with every inch of skin that could be found. She already grieved the loss of Catra's touch and they hadn't even parted.

Adora pushed herself onto her elbow and eased herself off Catra, pausing as she saw her moving her face away, her neck rolling in the opposite direction of the tear track that Adora could see coursing towards her ear.

"I love you," Adora smoothed her thumb over the trail of salt water, leaning down to press a kiss to the side of Catra's temple, "Really."

More than anything, even if you don't believe me.

"I just…"

Catra faltered. Adora's heart sank, realising it was the first time Catra hadn't immediately professed her love in return.

"What is it?"

Catra clammed up again, her jaw wired shut. Adora lowered herself onto the pillows next to her, winding her arm around her waist.

"You can tell me."

Adora could feel the tension contracting in Catra's muscles as she geared up to speak, the minuscule shuffle of her hips closing the distance between them.

"I heard you talking to Glimmer last night. What she said about me."

"She barely knows you, she doesn't know what she's talking abou-"

"Are you ashamed of me?" Catra sounded more uncomfortably nervous than Adora ever meant for her to feel, "is that the real reason we're still sneaking around?"

"What? No!"

Catra bristled in Adora's arms, pushing against her objection, "Then what is it?"

Adora sighed, offering no explanations. She didn't have the right words to describe the discomfort that overtook her when she thought about how people might compare her to Mara, or use her as an excuse to prove any weaponised theories she was desperate not to indulge. Some prophecies were more complicated when they followed through.

"Please, Dor, just talk to me. I went through this too, and it was"…

Even though Catra cut herself off, it was obvious how her sentence was supposed to end: *'t was harder for me.*

Adora didn't respond, at least not how she guessed Catra wanted her to. Everything had been stacked against Catra in a way Adora knew she'd never have to worry about (*if* she was ever able to stop worrying).Neither of them could forget how Shadow Weaver had fumed when Catra had come out to her mother in their final school year, spitting in disdain that she never should have let Mara anywhere near her daughter. Even now, Adora knew that Catra had barely spoken to her mother over the winter break, staying in her BMU halls alone while everyone else left for the holidays.

"Come home with me for reading week. We can stay with Raz."

"You're changing the subject."

Catra sniffed sharply and pulled away from Adora, swinging her legs over the side of the bed. Adora nearly reached out for her but the whole conversation felt too inevitable, like she'd been climbing slowly to the peak of a steep mountain, willfully ignoring the haggard trail down to ground level while kidding herself that there was still a safe way home. She'd gone too far, and had dragged Catra with her. Adora couldn't suppress the memory of what Catra had said when she'd first asked her to keep their relationship a secret.

I'm not asking - I wouldn't ask - you to come out. That's something you have to decide for yourself. But I promised myself a long time ago that I wouldn't hide who I am, Adora. Not even for you."

"I'm sorry," Adora whispered, unable to risk piercing the air too harshly.

"You should go," Catra reached for her sleep shirt on the floor, pulling it over her head and starving Adora of the sight of her nakedness, "You have to train."

She curled up under the covers again, burrowing under her duvet so that Adora couldn't see her face. Adora was sure she was trying not to cry; Catra had always hated being vulnerable in front of others - she wasn't so different herself.

By the time Adora had wriggled into her jeans and trainers, she could tell Catra was feigning being asleep. She didn't know what to do other than slip out silently and go along with the pretence, even though it sat heavily in her stomach. Adora felt incomparably lost; the bridge between them had widened, and she had no idea how to see past its slats to the other end.

The workout did nothing to calm the storm thrashing in Adora's mind. When her afternoon swim training rolled around, the band that had been tightening around Adora ever since she first realised her feelings for Catra had carved deep welts into her skin, finally too sore and red to ignore. She held her head in her hands as the rest of the team filtered into the changing room, well aware of what was coming.

"What the fuck is up with you today , Grayskull?" Mermista stood in front of her, hands on her hips, "First you barely talk to anyone, and now you're, like, storming out the pool because your flip turn was a little weak? What are you? T welve?"

"Mermista!" Spinerella tried to interject, but it was useless - Adora was shutting down anyway, "That' s not helpful."

The captain crossed her arms, glaring at Adora as she reminded the team about their upcoming meet.

"God forbid I have a single of f day."

Adora didnt recognise her own tone of voice;she could feel the hardness in her speech, resentment coating her tongue.

"That' s one hell of an overreaction to an off day," Mermista quipped back at her in front of everyone, "Seriously , you're behaving like a toddler."

"Back of f, Mermista," Glimmer cut in, standing between the two of them, "Coach said to let her cool of f."

"Here we go," Mermista rolled her eyes, and it reminded Adora so much of Catra that anger bloomed in her chest all over again, "It' s the chip off the old block reminding everyone else who's boss."

"What?" Glimmer gasped incredulously, "I'm *not,* I'm just standing up for Adora."

"Hilarious," Flutterina quipped, seemingly out of nowhere, "You're as bad at that as you are at backstroke. You sure Daddy didn't let you in easy?"

"Whoa," Mermista shot back at the smallest swimmer but Adora didn't hang around to hear it, pulling up her tracksuit bottoms over her damp Speedos and ripping off her swim cap, "Red card."

"Wait, Adora!"

She ignored Glimmer and shoved her towel into her sports bag sloppily instead of rolling it up precisely like she usually did, swiping her trainers from her locker instead of stepping out of her flip flops.

"Where are you going?" Glimmer's worry rang out across the changing room as Adora pushed her way out, "Oh, fuck."

The slam of the door behind her never came - Glimmer had blocked its swing, hurrying after her. Adora paused to turn, ready to tell her friend to fuck off, but it was hard to say it, seeing the pink-haired girl shiver in the middle of the sports centre corridor in a wet swimsuit, water still beading on her shoulders.

"What's wrong, Adora?"

"I just want to go home. Don't stress about it."

Glimmer stepped forward regardless. She'd never done what anyone asked of her anyway, and Adora couldn't work out if she was grateful for it or not.

"Who's upset you? Is it Flutterina? She was a total dick last night."

Adora could feel the flames of fury within her being stoked by the second, the memory of what Catra had said that morning replaying

in her mind, reminding her what had sparked the entire conversation.

"Glimmer-" Adora spoke warningly, determined to get away before she blew up.

"I'll talk to her, or Dad. She shouldn't get away with it!"

"It's not Flutterina. Just leave me be."

"Who is it? Adora, no-one should make you feel like this-"

"No, I don't want you to-"

"I'll speak to them, make them understand how upset you are-"

"For God's sake, it's *you*! Happy now?"

Adora couldn't stop her shout from bouncing off the white, sterile walls of the empty hallway. She flinched at how shocked Glimmer's expression was, her friend's confusion quickly giving way to hurt.

"Me?" Glimmer searched Adora's face, looking for some kind of explanation, "What have *I* done?"

"You insulted Catra. She heard you."

"Okay." Glimmer still looked puzzled, and Adora realised she'd done it again - she'd taken her canoe too far down a raging river to return, "Is she upset? I'll apologise but honestly, I can't believe Catra cares about anything I have to say."

"You're doing it again - just stop!"

"Stop *what*?"

"You're behaving like she doesn't have any feelings, like she doesn't get hurt."

"What? Adora, what are you-"

"Will you shut up? She's important to me, Glimmer."

Glimmer sighed, stepping forward again, "I know you've been friends since forever, Adora, but-"

"She's not my friend anymore."

Glimmer looked at Adora quizzically, "Dont tell me she's started a fight with you over this, it's nothing! I mean, why would she even give a shit? It's not like you'd ever-"

Adora bit her lip, letting her head fall forwards. She was too tired to carry on any longer and her friend saw it. Glimmer's eyes widened; the penny had dropped.

"Adora"…

Please don't make me say it.

"How long?"

Adora didn't reply, instantly regretting the snap decision to open up this can of worms - she'd never felt so bitterly reckless, even if her confession was borne from exhaustion. Out of everyone, Glimmer was surely the last person to be supportive, she'd always been a little jealous of her and Catra's bond; but then, she felt Glimmer's hand on her bicep, squeezing gently. After a beat, Adora replied in a fraught whisper, hoping that her trust wasn't misplaced.

"Three months."

"I'm sorry, Dor. I shouldn't have said that last night, I never meant to hurt you."

Adora shook her head, failing to prevent a short, snuffling sob from escaping.

"She' s mad at me. I dont know if.I might have ruined us."

"Dont worry ," Glimmer 's hand moved to her back, as close as they could get without worsening the damp patches seeping through Adora's shirt, "Go home and shower , Ill come over once Im dressed. Well fix it. Okay?"

"Okay ."

Adora finally nodded, letting herself look at Glimmer properly. She was almost ashamed at how surprised she was to see her friend's acceptance and reassurance.

"Do you want me to call Bow too?"

Adora took a deep breath and clutched at Glimmer's hand, nodding as the other girl clasped her palm in return.

"Alright. W ell see you soon, yeah?"

"Y eah."

Adora watched Glimmer return to the women's changing room, wiping at her eyes hurriedly in case anyone caught sight of her through the door. She still felt terrible, granted - and the idea of setting foot in her next team practice was too overwhelming to comprehend - but the slight easing of her breath after letting Glimmer in had been a little gratifying. Maybe Catra had been right.

Perhaps Ireally could do this. For myself.

Seeing that Catra actually turned up was the sweetest relief - it certainly hadnt been a given.

Adora held her breath as the navy satin of Catra's slip shimmered against her body, smoothing the skirt of her own dress with her hands. She had clearly made an effort despite her hesitant agreement to meet Adora after their argument that morning.

"You look amazing," Adora grinned at the blush rising on Catra's cheeks, secretly delighted that she was still capable of sparking the other girl's reaction, "I didn't think you'd come."

"Neither did I."

Adora reached out cautiously to pull the brunette into her room, taking Catra's right palm in hers.

"I missed you."

"It's barely been a day," Catra rolled her eyes, though it didn't stop Adora from pressing a kiss to her knuckles, "You whipped or something?"

"Completely."

Catra dipped her head, shifting nervously as she stepped further into Adora's room and shut the door behind her. She gasped softly when she saw the table set up in the middle of the small space, her eyes taking in the cut roses and tea light candles arranged across the tablecloth. Adora thought it was even better seeing her excitement at the greasy burgers and fries plated up as artfully as she could manage; Catra had whined at Adora to indulge in her favourite fast food so many times over the years, never able to convince her to stray from her athletic diet for anything other than one of Razz's pies.

"You did all this?"

"Kinda. Glimmer and Bow helped me."

Catra turned back to look at Adora instead of taking the seat she'd held out for her, totally dumbstruck. She spoke shyly with thinly-

veiled trepidation, as if she was avoiding jnxing the whole night.

"They helped you?"

She could feel Catra studying her face intently, searching for more information.

"They know , Cat,"Adora smiled unsurely back at her , "I told them."

"Adora,"Catra fidgeted with her fingers;Adora took hold of her hands again, willing both their anxiety to ebb away, "Y ou didnt have to do that, I wasn't trying to guilt you into it."

"Y ou didnt. I guess I just wanted to see what it was like to not be so scared of someone figuring it out."

"How is it?"

"Honestly , I dont know yet. This."Adora leaned down to capture Catra's mouth with her own, "This is better ."

"But you're okay?"Catra murmured against Adora' s lips, her eyelashes fluttering against the arch of Adora's cheek, "Really?"

"Y eah. I might not be after this junk food of yours though."

"I'll help you with it. One way or another ."

Adora giggled, pressing her lips to Catra's once more. Her heart raced when Catra deepened the kiss, their desire blossoming as Adora held her closer. They melded together, lips and teeth and slippery tongue, skin pebbling at one another's touch;their bodies became stone-studded beaches in desperate need of exploration, the moon reflecting silver off rounded sea-smoothed rocks. Waves of relief crashed over Adora, finally confident that she hadnt screwed everything up, that Catra could still be here even if her demons threatened to seep into every pore of her soul.

She let herself be pushed down into the chair she'd ushered Catra towards only minutes prior, relishing the feel of the brunette's thighs settling atop hers as she was straddled. Adora brought her hands to the Catra's spine;she got lost in the silky material there, its ripples mimicking the roll of Catra's hips and the throbbing that prickled in skips and hops within her.

"We should eat the food,"Adora felt like she was slurring, her lips swollen from Catra's touch, "it'll get cold."

Catra only responded with a moan, nipping further at Adora's jaw. It was instruction enough;Adora stood slowly with Catra held against her body, nudging the chair out of the way to lay her down on the bed. She took a second to cast her eyes over the woman, unable to hold back a slow gulp. This was a beauty that had seemed impossible to find in the past, a sight she hadn't even known she'd craved. Catra cringed a little at the depth of her attention, turning her head towards the nightstand.

"Adora, your phone looks like it's been going crazy."

Adora settled on her knees, half sitting in Catra's lap, "it doesn't matter. Tonight's for us. You."

"Seriously,"Catra sounded worried - *you don't normally worry like this* - and it scared Adora too much to ignore, "it looks like Razz has been trying to call you."

It only took a second to realise Catra was right;her mobile screen was littered with notifications. She'd missed call after call from her grandmother over the past hour, totally oblivious while she got ready for the date. Her hand shook as she dialled her voicemail number, barely registering the words as Razz's message spun in her ear.

Adora dropped her phone on the bedspread in shock, the world decelerating into slow-mo in front of her. Her brain was at battle with her body, a churn of emotions completely corrupting any coherent response she could form.

“What’ s happened?”Adora could feel Catra’ s palm on her cheek, sense the movement of her sliding back and sitting up, of how she made room for Adora to curl into her embrace, “Please, Dor , you're freaking me out.”

“It’ s Mara,”Adora felt like she was choking on air;even the sound of her own speech seemed foreign as it tore out her throat, “It’ s... It's my mum.”

Chapter End Notes

Happy 2022... Will aim to update soon!

Chapter 10

Chapter Notes

> For the first time in forever... An update!Thank you for your patience - I've had a lot on my mind and no headspace to write. But now, several life milestones later, my fingers are itching to get going again :)
>
> Please do leave comments and share feedback!After the break in practice, anything you have to say would be hugely appreciated for getting back into the swing of things <3

See the end of the chapter for more notes

SEVEN AND A HALF YEARS AGO

It had been hours, but Catra could still feel Adora's eyes on the back of her head from across the room. She couldn't decide whether the nervous prickle on the back of her neck was better than the alarm that washed over her when Adora insisted on going on yet another nighttime run in the dark. These days, it seemed like whatever Adora was doing, Catra always had cause for concern.

"I know you're staring at me," Catra twisted around to face Adora, smirking at the blonde's flustered reaction, "Get on with your work, dummy."

Adora sighed like a kid who'd been told they couldn't have candy, flopping onto her stomach and burying her head in the bedding; Catra could practically feel the pent up energy buzzing in her bones. She turned back to her keyboard, determined not to think too hard about whether they'd been right to stay in the East End so long. What was supposed to be a few days at Razz's house had turned

into weeks, their absence from school stretching beyond the Easter break through the whole exam revision period.

Catra wondered whether she should have insisted they return to their uni halls sooner, though she didnt mind having to watch Adora do her workouts on the bedroom floor every morning. She often pretended she was asleep when the sun began to ripple through the curtains and pour gold over Adora's muscles, her biceps and glutes flexing as she dipped to the floor and back. Catra was sure she'd never needed as much restraint as she did when Adora bathed in the dawn light, every sinewy muscle greeting the morning rays. Nevertheless, Catra knew there was really only one reason she'd indulged Adora's seclusion for so long. Leaving would send her straight back into the Central Bright Moon closet.

She frowned at the thought of it, sliding her pencil out of her curls and drilling it into a point on her manuscript paper. She'd been distracted from finishing her coursework compositions for far too long;a new song had circled her consciousness for days instead.

Catra's fingers skipped over the keyboard restlessly, the melody drifting through worn headphones. She could hear Adora calling to her through it, no doubt reminding her that she didnt need to keep qiet. Y et there was something about this song that Catra wanted to clutch close to her chest. She'd let Adora believe she was working on her coursework the entire time, grateful that the other girl had never read a single note of sheet music in her life.

Losing herself in music had always been the one thing Catra could count on. The piano had got her through her shitty schooldays, Adora fucking off to the Academy, the rocky weeks after she came out.Its black and white keys were a permanent buoy , the only constant that made life bearable. She wished music could do the same for Adora - being away from the pool wasnt doing her any favours, and it was exactly the time she needed the water most.

Adora's despair and anger echoed around her by the hour, turmoil broiling under her skin everyday since they'd huddled in that tiny hospital room next to RazGetting the blonde to actually verbalise her feelings had been futile;however much she tried to convince Catra that she was fine, Adora had almost entirely shut down. Between the moments of softness they shared - finally free to let every touch and gaze linger behind closed doors - she'd spend hours staring sullenly out the window, pretending the fond expression she saved for Catra had never given way to hardness. Nevertheless, Adora's volatile emotions didnt stop Catra from smiling when she heard the soft shuffle of Adora giving up on her revision and creeping up to her bench, the soles of her feet drawing out whining creaks from the floor. The anticipation of Adora's touch spun pinwheels in the pit of Catra's belly, copper coils twisting in her gut until the gentle pressure of tender lips blurred everything out.

"Let me hear it," Adora reached out towards the headphone jack, her fingers hovering over the black plastic, "it's my new favourite."

"You havent even heard it yet."

Adora shrugged, stroking the knobbly bone on the inside of Catra's wrist and nudging one headphone cup off Catra's ears. She looked down sheepishly, blush rushing to her cheeks.

"Yeah, but you wrote it, and you're kind of a musical genius."

Catra scoffed but the pleasure threatening to bloom in her chest was hard to contain. She knew the stupid grin forcing its way onto her face was probably slipping through more than she'd like.

"Pshht, you're just biased."

"It' s hard not to be."Adora paused, and Catra could tell she was about to go deep, further than she usually did these days, "Y ou're really special, you know that? Not just to me - though obviously you're probably , no, *definitely,* the most special person in my life-"

"Adora."

Catra didn't bother to roll her eyes, but her tone stopped the freight train of verbal sappiness in its tracks. Adora's gushing was quickly making her squirm awkwardly , unwanted embarrassment mixing with shy delight in her chest. The silence didn't last long - Adora charged ahead before Catra had any chance of changing the conversation.

"Sorry . It's just, I don't think you realise what it' s like when you perform, no-one can take their eyes off you! I know the open mics aren't as posh as your proper recitals, but you're so impressive in them. I wish I was talented like that."

"Come on, you're one of the best swimmers in Etheria. No-one could believe it when Salineas passed on you."

Catra couldn't decipher the curious expression that flitted briefly across Adora's face, almost like she'd remembered the course of history differently before Catra had reminded her. It didn't matter much anyhow;yet again, Adora moved on swiftly .

"Music touches people, though. *You* touch people."

"W ell. I definitely touch you plenty, Princess."

She waited for the inevitable clap-back that it was Adora who did most of the touching. After all, she was by far the more tactile of them both, in the bedroom and out. Catra could hear DT's voice ringing in her head as she anticipated Adora's response, her heart thrumming with sore expectation;but all Adora did was lower her voice and murmur even more softly in her ear.

"Is it really so hard to take the compliment?"

Catra looked away. Adora tucked a wayward curl behind her ear, removing the final veil of protection she was relying on.

"How many standing ovations do you need to believe it? Ten?" Adora's lips grazed the side of Catra's forehead, "Twenty?"

Catra kept a straight face, cracking the joints in her fingers and wrists as if she were gearing up to play again. Adora swung her leg over the bench, mounting it sideways so she faced Catra's profile, and shuffled closer, her hand drifting towards the waistband of Catra's leggings. Catra pushed gently on the black and white keys, letting the soft tinkling of her new song's opening bars fill her headphones - yet when she felt the pad of Adora's thumb slipping under lycra and stroking the fine, downy hairs trailing under her belly button, she knew the instant pebbling of her skin would betray her arousal even if she was seasoned enough to stop it from affecting how she played.

"I thought you wanted to hear this."

"I changed my mind."

Adora wrapped her arms firmly around Catra's middle and pulled her away from the keyboard, discordant notes ringing out as her fingers tore from the keys. Catra cringed at the sound, though it soon turned into a whimper when Adora tugged her round, guiding Catra's legs and bum over the top of her thighs so she straddled her lap.

"I need to get my coursework done."

"You will."

Adora dove to trail kisses all across her collarbone, her hands roaming up and down Catra's back.

"It'll be your fault if I fail."

"You won't," Adora paused, touching her forehead to Catra's, "But I'll make it worth your while just in case."

Catra gave in, finally letting her smile spread. She never would have imagined this version of Adora could exist in the past. The conscientious side of the blonde usually consumed all of her, and Catra wasn't sure if Adora's unprecedented irresponsibility gave her cause for concern or relief. There wasn't much time to think about it; the second she nodded her consent, Adora palmed her breast, her teeth nipping the silky plane where Catra's jaw met her earlobe. Adora's hips bucked underneath her, and Catra shifted her weight onto Adora's right thigh, tucking one leg under herself to place her knee teasingly close to Adora's core. Catra didn't have to move forwards for Adora took the bait - she wriggled towards Catra urgently, damp cotton meeting cool skin in search of gratification.

Catra watched Adora as her body rocked beneath her, driving down on the blonde's thigh in tandem. She could tell Adora was getting close, and she knew Adora *needed* her - more than she'd ever needed swimming, or Mara, or Razor, or anyone. There was no way she could pretend otherwise: being so important to someone, especially to *Adora*, was just about the best feeling Catra had ever experienced.

She brought her fingers to Adora's shoulders, slipping under the taut lycra of her sports bra. Adora's groan as Catra scraped down her muscles, digging harder into the balls and knots that never got fully worked out, made her feel more powerful than ever. She could feel herself getting wetter as Adora's breathing became more and more ragged, her pants reverberating in the dip of Catra's windpipe as she left sloppy bites and kisses on her neck. They moved faster and more desperately against each other;Catra thought she could cry when Adora shifted away, only for her headphones to be ripped entirely off her head and dropped softly to the floor, her whole body lifted with Adora as she rose from the bench. Catra clung to Adora as she stumbled towards the bed, just like she had in Adora's halls the night that everything had changed.

They stared at one another briefly before their lips reunited hungrily on the mattress, but Catra didn't need to see Adora to know exactly what shade of pink had coloured her skin, or how the golden baby hairs flying from her temple stood in a hazy halo, or how her pupils dilated so much that black almost consumed blue entirely.

"Do you want?"..

Butterflies fluttered in Catra's stomach as she trailed her hand down Adora's waist to under her shorts and underwear, fingers ghosting wiry hair.

"You don't have to," Adora squeezed her hip reassuringly, defying the quiver that Catra saw sweep through her, "Really."

Catra exhaled as she fixed her focus on blue irises, moving to cup Adora and coat her fingers with slickness. She glided upwards to circle Adora's clit, craning to catch the blonde's heavy groan.

"Cat," Adora mumbled against her lips, her words soft and quiet, "Are you sure?"..

"Yeah. Let me."

They flipped around, Adora parting her legs wider and wriggling out of her bottoms. Catra slipped a finger inside, waiting for anxiety to claim her and ruin the whole thing - but unlike every other time she'd tried to top, she didn't feel sickeningly nervous. Adora's warmth was empowering, and taking control didn't seem so intimidating.

"More?"

"Fuck," Adora was further gone than Catra had thought, "Yeah, I can do a-another."

Adora's voice became more strangled as Catra drove in and out of her, her hips pushing back and forth in response. Catra could tell her own wetness was growing fast too, a burning ache deepening inside

her that she had to squeeze her thighs together to halfway satisfy . She couldn't stop a whine escaping her throat, and Adora noticed - Catra couldn't believe it, she was sure she'd be completely oblivious if she was as close as Adora was - and she reached up for Catra's nipple, pinching it between her fingers and grasping at her breast.

"A-Adora, it' s s'posed to be your turn!"

"For someone who' s been at this - *ahhh* - a lot longer, I feel like you should.k-know"…

Adora groaned deeply;Catra could feel the pre-shocks of Adora' s orgasm building around her fingers.

"What"?

"... Y ou can have your cake *and* eat it."

Adora pulled Catra down beside her and shifted them so they faced each other, hardly inches apart. She ground down on Catra's hand while weaving her own between them, rolling Catra's swelling clit between her fingers.

"Y ou're so wet,"Adora sounded almost amazed, as if it hadn't happened every time they'd fucked, "Th-this feel good"?

"Y eah,"Catra moaned as she repositioned her hand at the exact same moment Adora entered her, "*Ah* , are you-"?

"I'm gonna c-"

Catra raced to swallow Adora's moan, riding on Adora's fingers when she went rigid to keep up momentum. She could feel the electricity building and building within her, her whole body chasing relief until Adora curled her fingers and bit down on Catra's lip, nipping it between her teeth;and suddenly , Catra snapped, fresh waves of pleasure breaking over her. For a moment, there was nothing but release unfurling from her toes to her scalp, nothing but white light in

the whole world, until she finally opened her eyes and found Adora peering down at her, flushed pink and searching her face.

Catra could feel a familiar stone plummeting in her stomach, telling her that she'd clearly pulled the wrong faces or made the wrong noises, or maybe Adora had been faking the strength of her orgasm the whole time;maybe she really was as bad at satisfying her lovers as she'd always feared.

"Did I..did I do something wr-?"

"I really love you, Catra."

Relief hit her like a ton of bricks, but it was too easy to give into Adora's gushing confessions of love - or rather, it was too hard, knowing they'd go back into hiding the second they returned to reality. Catra wasn't sure which was really true. She relaxed into the comfort of her usual snark, sidestepping the entire thing instead.

"God, is a hand job all it takes?"

Adora swatted at Catra playfully, though she held onto her wrist when they made contact, folding Catra's arm between her own and her chest.

"I'm being serious!It' s been a really tough couple of months, and you've.Y. ou've been here. Even though I still"…

You still haven't told everyone about us. Or you.

Catra shifted even closer, her feet twisting between Adora's ankles.

"I know . It's okay."

You needed me.

She used her free hand to push frazzled strands behind Adora' s ear, never breaking eye contact. Adora inhaled deeply, her chest rising at the top of her breath with a shudder. Catra waited for the pressure in

Adora's body to get pushed down far deeper than it should, just like it always was, without even a single tear allowed to shed. It was impossible to know how close Adora was to combusting, or whether she'd keep reining herself in over and over again until everything hurt less. All Catra did know was that the Adora she loved before was different to the Adora she was in love with now.

It was no wonder, really, after what happened to Mara.

Catra would never forget the dread that overtook Adora's face when news of the shooting began to bleed out of every phone, radio and TV billboard;how it looked like her heart had splintered every time she remembered that Mara's body had swallowed the bullets intended for Light Hope.

"She promised me she'd stop," Adora's voice had shaken almost as hard as her shoulders, *"She was supposed to stay away from Light Hope's shit."*

Catra hadn't been able to remember the last time she'd seen Mara out of uniform, but the patterned hospital gown and forced closure of her eyes made her look even less like herself. The golden tone of her skin had flattened into a putrid beige, her warm honeyed hair dulled to a mousey brown under the harsh ward lights. Even Adora's lily white skin looked bright in comparison, her hands grasping Mara's lifeless own as soon as they were shown into the room. They'd still been able to hear the hubbub from gathering reporters through the open hospital window;after all, it wasn't every day that the army vet partner of Etheria's Secretary of State for Defence got shot in the middle of their very own pre-election press conference.

Razz had gestured to Catra to shut the window and beckoned her out of Adora's earshot.

"Has she seen the video?"

"W-what?" Catra had stammered, unnerved by the unusual haste of Razz's question, *"I don't think it's the best idea for her to do that.*

Right?

Raz had nodded, patting Catra's hands as she held them in her palms, "*Okay, dearie. We'll cross that bridge when we come to it.*"

Catra's confusion had only festered for a couple of hours, ballooning until she'd slipped away to the toilets and ignored all the trigger warnings every news site had plastered over their articles. She must have watched the footage ten or twenty times, unable to believe it.

"*Why should anyone vote for you when you murdered your own child?*" Catra had winced when she saw the shock on Light Hope's face, however swiftly she managed regain her composure, "*April 9th, you were seen at Eight Mon Reproductive Choices-*"

"*I-*," Light Hope's had voice resounded clearly, "*I, like many others, support the right of any woman to make decisions about her own body-*"

"*How is anybody supposed to trust you, after lying to everyone for your entire political career, killing your own child, letting all of us believe you were a woman of your word, who 'wouldn't hide anything from the people', not even your ghastly relationship, if you can call it that-*"

"*I-. This is not an appropriate forum for-*"

Catra hadn't been able to make out what anyone said over the first burst of ammunition until Mara lept into view of the camera, running towards Light Hope and shouting desperately.

"*Stop! She never did it, I raised-Ah!*"

Catra had dropped her phone the first time she watched it. A hundred times later, she still couldn't work out if it was the sheer horror of realising what Mara had said or the rip of two bullets through her chest that had made her feel so sick. Catra was just grateful she hadn't been in the room when Raz finally sat Adora

down to tell her, though she'd tugged Adora' s laptop and phone out her hands dozens of times since to stop her from watching the recording on repeat.

Neither of them went to the funeral. Another day of nodding through the never ending rounds of official condolences would have driven Adora mad - not to mention that she'd refused to utter even the shortest word to Light Hope, let alone spend an entire morning in her presence. As far as Catra could tell, Adora had waited a lifetime for Mara to choose her over Light Hope and her constant cross-country campaigns;discovering she had two mothers who'd sacrificed her for political aspirations was simply too much to bear.

Catra reached over to Adora, pulling the sheets up around them to make a cocoon.

"I know we were supposed to go back this week, but I don't mind," Catra spoke softly, still naive enough to hope that if she tread carefully enough, Adora might just open up, "I totally get it if you need longer."

Adora blinked slowly, her ankles brushing Catra's toes.

"No. No, I promised Glimmer I'd go to team karaoke on Saturday night. It's a pre-exam tradition."

"I remember . You don't always have to keep your promises though. Not if they're too much."

Adora shook her head.

"It' s fine. You'll come with me, right?"

"You want me there?"

She watched as Adora scrunched up her face, pushing her brows together in a twisted frown.

"Yeah, I mean... Like, we always hang out with the team together."

Catra got the memo. She curled into Adora’s body, figuring it was easier to sidestep showing the disappointment she knew must have flooded her face.

Together but not together, in front of everyone, like always. What’s the worst that could happen?

Chapter End Notes

Thanks for reading, and yes, I'm sure you can guess that the karaoke isn't going to go as smoothly as our gals are hoping...! I'm off to the US for work next week, but you bet I'll be spending those 8hr flights thinking away on my notes app ;)

Hang onto that song as well (If You Think It's Love, by our wondrous King Princess)...

Chapter 11

Chapter Notes

> Hi all!I'm so excited to finally share this chapter with you, one mortgage and two rescue cats down the line (see, I have excuses for my dismal posting schedule these last few months!) Really hope you enjoy it and looking forward to reading all your feedback/comments :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

SEVERAL HALF YEARS AGO

Catra's hand was cold. It might not have been if Adora hadn't dropped it the minute they turned into Chinatown, her left palm joining her right on the steering wheel.

Well, that's kind of convenient...

Dismissing the fact that Adora often boasted about her ability to drive well one-handed (and was sometimes even stupid enough to try and show off without *any* hands on a straight, empty road), Catra reached up to pull down the sun visor and inspect her eyeliner in the vanity mirror. Under Chinatown's warm lanterns and the orange-rose sunset, it looked exactly how she remembered it had that morning, waterproof kohl swept across her lids in near symmetry, specks of fallen ink left under her lower lash line. There was no reason for her to expect anything otherwise - she always did her eye make-up the same way. It had become an armour of sorts, and armour was top of Catra's must-have list for the night ahead. She already needed it to survive the nervous glances Adora kept throwing her way.

Maybe she's changed her mind about me coming.

The thought saddened and infuriated Catra at the same time. The longer their relationship - *situationship?* - went on, the more Catra could feel herself being pulled behind her childhood bedroom door, her hopes for the future pinned solely on the piano that was both her captor and her key. She'd spent so many nights mourning the realisation that she was embarrassingly, stereotypically in love with her straight, borderline homophobic bestie in her teens. Yet after months of carving her life into halves, Catra was no longer sure that the secrecy Adora had bound her with was much of an improvement on her old unreqited crush.

Do I even want this anymore? Really?

Catra snapped the visor shut and closed her eyes, willing herself to think about something - anything - else. Yet all she could focus on was the memory of Adora's fingers slipping around her hip bones the night before, promises of a good time whispered into her ear and chased with urgent kisses that teased goosebumps out of her skin.

I want <u>her</u>.

She sat in silence as Adora crammed the car into an impossibly small space, waiting for the inevitable disappointment of seeing a platonic smile fixed on the blonde's face for the next few hours. Surprisingly, Catra felt Adora's hand wrap around hers again instead. Reassurance rushed through her veins with every stroke of Adora's thumb over her knuckles - she was sure it steadied Adora's nerves as much as it was intended to placate her.

"Are you sure you wanna go? We could make up some excuse. Or I," Catra gulped, pushing past the sore lump in her throat, "I can just get the bus home if that's better."

The silence hung between them again. One second turned into two, then three, four, five. Catra sucked her teeth sharply, half in disbelief and half in bitter dismay. She clutched at the door handle, instantly desperate to get as far away from the bed she and Adora had made for themselves as possible.

Fuck this shit.

She slammed the car door behind her, feeling for her phone and keys in her pocket. If she had to parachute herself out of this shittiness, then the least Adora could do is drive the rest of her shit over later.

God knows Ive done enough to deserve that.

Catra looked around, recalibrating her senses. Chinatown was always busy on a Saturday night;between the bustling crowds and how her body fizzed with bitter frustration, she had no chance of remembering where her bus stop was.

Crap. Ill figure it out eventually .

She set off down the street in a hurry, her platformed soles skimming the cobblestones. Catra didnt know what she really wanted out of her abrupt exit: whether she needed space or if that muted part of her - the part that roared for Adora to choose her unequivocally - was finally breaking out of the cage she'd been straining to contain it in.

"Wait!" Adora was jumping out of the car now;Catra could hear the panic in her voice from behind but kept on walking anyway, "Where are you going?"

She replied bluntly, hardly bothering to turn around to face Adora fully.

"Home."

"But I invited you, everyone' s expecting to see you!"

Great. All about appearances, then.

Adora seemed to realise as soon as she spoke that Catra didnt care about anyone's feelings apart from hers. Still, Catra didnt have the energy or the patience to go back and forth any longer. She just

wanted to reunite with her proper keyboard workstation (Lord knows the keyboard Adora had kept for her at Raż s was rudimentary at best), take her misery out on some poor unsuspecting melody, and try to forget about the mess they'd made until the morning.

"Just go and enjoy it, yeah? I'll message you later ."

"No, Catra-"

"*Adora* "…

Catra hated the tremble that was rippling through her words, threateningly close to tears. This wasn't who she was - a person who let her emotions overtake her, who let her weaknesses become so humiliatingly visible. She inhaled shakily, readying herself to leave.

"Hey , everything alright here, Wildcat"?

Adora's head jerked up;Catra followed her eyeline to see Scorpia approaching them hesitantly, Perfuma hand in hand. Adora's eyes darted between Scorpia and Catra, trying to interpret Scorpia's wary stance. Catra knew the two of them had never gotten on that well, that each was protective over her towards the other. Still, she could tell exactly what was running through Adora's mind: *does Scorpia already know?*

Catra's resolve to go home got even stronger.

"Yeah, I'm just not feeling this karaoke thing. I'm gonna head home."

Adora's face fell, crestfallen. It was obvious she was gutted by Catra's decision.

"You're not coming in"?Perfuma' s voice was soft and strong at the same time, questioning Catra without berating her , "Haven't you just come all the way from the East End"?

"Yeah, you're already here,"Scorpia chimed in, "it'd be great if you stuck around for a couple of songs!"

Catra knew she'd been backed into a corner. If she insisted on leaving to lick her wounds then Scorpia would only press her the next day to open up (her friend had gotten so bloody obsessed with open communication since dating Mermista's hippie flatmate). It was a choice between ripping off a small plaster now or a much bigger one later.

"Please," Adora managed to catch her eye, and her hope that Catra would give her yet another chance was palpable, "Stay."

If Catra had an achilles heel, it was hearing Adora beg.

By the time she'd been jammed into the booth next to Adora, the two of them squeezed into its musty corner and barely able to reach the drinks teetering in front of them, Catra couldn't help but feel sorry for herself. She hated everything about the dingy bar from its faded posters and mismatched signs to the soggy, barely-warmed spring rolls that were being served to them, so disappointingly inferior to the authentic dim sum sold at every other place on the street. Catra imagined how decades of patrons had warped the wallpaper with never-ending smoke; she could almost see circles of burning orange bobbing in the dark as ceramic ashtrays branded rings into the creaking wooden tabletops.

It was strange, quite how insecure this place and being around Adora's precious swim team was making her. She'd performed on stage for years and had revelled in the feel of eyes and ears focused solely on her. Still, something about singing along to a poorly produced backing track and a teleprompter gave Catra the ick. The feel of Adora's outer thigh stuck to hers didn't help either - her own misery was compounded by the thrumming anxiety of the other girl's jiggling leg.

She wanted so badly to be pissed off with Adora, to feel rightly justified in her anger; but all Catra felt was concern, her default worry consuming all of her other emotions. She leaned in close to Adora, careful not to murmur in her ear until the rest of the group was distracted by watching Flutterina take to the mic.

"Hey . You okay over there?"

Adora practically jumped out of her skin.

"Yeah," her surprise was striking, shock evident on her face as she examined Catra's own, "Thanks."

Catra shrugged and closed her eyes for a second, flexing her fingers in her lap.

I wish you would hold my hand and not care about anyone else.

She thought about it hard enough to wonder if it were possible to manifest her desires. She fixated on how Adora's fingers fit comfortably between hers, how her larger palm would close over the back of Catra's hand and wrap around it, her thumb resting on the edge of her pinky.

If only we could fast forward through all this.

Catra opened her eyes, preparing herself for the warmth she'd conjured in her mind to fade; instead, it persevered, the sensation of Adora's hand clamped firmly around her own revealing itself to be no figment of her imagination.

"Will you sing?" Catra looked up from their hands into Adora's irises, totally dumbfounded. Adora seemed to sense her hesitance, pressing again, "Maybe we could do a song together?"

Catra spluttered, taken even further aback by the suggestion - she'd never thought Adora would be willing to get up onstage, let alone sing. She was hardly able to stand on a medal podium without blushing to death.

"W -What would we even sing?"

Adora's sombreness broke and she tipped her forehead towards Catra's as she spoke, a brazen display of carelessness only made possible by the fortunate timing of Flutterina utterly failing to hit her

belter notes and capturing everyone’s attention in a room-wide grimace.

‘I dont know , Cat. Dealer’s choice?’

It was the right thing to do, however much she hated the attention - put Catra at ease by doing something she was sure to enjoy , and start making up for every stupid fuck up and nearly-happenstance she’d let pass between them.

Overwhelming guilt had consumed Adora ever since she’d gripped the steering wheel with both hands, her knuckles whitening against its black leather. She’d pretended not to notice that Catra’ s breath hitched before she snapped the sun visor down, or that she hadnt wiped at the edges of her liner, acting like the early summer heat might have softened its edges too much.

All Adora had wanted to do for weeks was scream.

She’d spent every night wide awake, stilling her breath as much as she could in the pin-drop quiet. Something was telling her - maybe it was noticing how Catra deflated a little whenever they talked about heading back to campus, or how tired she was of lying when anyone asked her what she’d been doing over the break - that she was fast reaching breaking point.

At first, she’d really thought that working out would fix it. The burn of her muscles had always been a good distraction from her thoughts, every intrusive notion blocked by the count of her breath drawing in and out, and the slow trickle of sweat beading in the valleys of her shoulder blades. When she’d realised that Catra watched her in the mornings, Adora couldnt help but congratulate herself on killing two birds with one stone;she made sure to stretch her core exercises

out as long as she could, a secret expression of love and apology. Besides, basking in Catra's blatant desire felt sweeter than winning any medal.

t' s not enough, though, is it?

The shame of hurting Catra, of being too scared to confront the situation she'd forced them into, was becoming all-encompassing. It was getting harder and harder for her to justify her anxieties: everyone already knew her mother - *mothers?* - had been gay; Glimmer and Bow were being nothing but supportive;even Catra herself was proof that life continued long after the sting of a negative response dulled. There shouldnt have been anything stopping her .

The longer Adora spent thinking about it, the more she realised that she was incapable of escaping one final miserable truth.

Inever got to tell herI love her. Now Inever will.

When Adora had driven them to Chinatown that evening, it had been a near miracle that she'd managed to focus on parallel parking at all. She'd taken Catra' s hand in hers instinctively once she'd turned the engine off, willing herself to come back to Earth. Yet Catra's voice still sounded like it was underwater, garbled and indistinct, and Adora hadnt felt like she was any more grounded than she'd been before. Worse, Catra's hand had then disappeared from under hers. The sound of the car door being wrenched open had hit her, and the outside hubbub from the evening crowds had pierced her bubble. Panic had risen in her chest as soon as she'd realised that she'd let life ripple around and pass her by *again* - she'd missed everything Catra had said. Moreover, Adora had failed miserably at keeping a level head when Scorpia and Perfuma bumped into them on their way to the bar, her paranoia soaring to an all time high.

What if she told them? Or maybe they've guessed how unhappy she is, because of me… Would they tell everyone, before Ieven get a chance to fixit?

Even though Adora had somehow convinced Catra to still come to karaoke, and she was about to sacrifice her own dignity on stage to cheer her up, Adora still felt like she had an impossible task ahead of her. She wracked her brain relentlessly for a way to heal the growing awkwardness between them, half-baked platitudes faltering with her every attempt to speak.

Just get through this song and then you can figure it all out.

Adora forced herself to stand up straighter as she took to the stage, watching Catra as she took hold of the mic stand and twisted the worn XLR cord in her hands, the pads of her fingertips skimming the PVC.

Imagine if I could let her handle me the way she's handling that right now…

Adora cleared her throat, wincing at the feedback that burst from her mic.

Fuck!

She stumbled a little, but knowing Catra was beside her reassured her instantly. There wasn't anyone else she trusted more to get on a stage with - and Adora forced herself to pretend she had all the grace and stage presence Catra had;regardless of whatever song was randomly chosen for them, she just had to keep calm and carry on. Performing together had been her idea, after all. She just hoped that leaving their song up to chance wouldn't backfire - all of a sudden, she couldn't help but worry how likely it was that one she'd never even heard of would come on.

You've never been any good at music - you're probably going to look like an idiot!

The first notes of the song began to play, and Adora could feel the tension in her shoulders draining as she realised the song was familiar.

Phew! That's one hurdle cleared.

Catra didn't seem so relieved though - she kept glancing at Adora worriedly, her eyes flitting between the tv screen and her. It wasn't until Catra began to sing that Adora drew her attention away from the brunette, turning towards the lyrics.

What's wrong?

I'm fine

Adora gulped, shaking her head at Catra dismissively. She was fine - totally fine. Catra didn't think she was melodramatic enough to take a random song too seriously, did she? Adora started to sing, her voice rough and pitchy alongside the silky smooth of Catra's vocals. Still, this was what she wanted, wasn't it? A chance to be with Catra, however indirectly, without hiding.

What's wrong?

I'm fine

She focused on reading and singing the lyrics, imagining Catra was physically closer than she really was, like they were back in her bedroom at Raz's. It was easier than acknowledging Catra's concern, or facing up to the unwanted gaze of the entire swim team.

This is fine. One hundred percent fine. It's just a song, like three minutes long, and then it'll all be done with and we can go home to Catra's room and…

Except, Adora realised, she didn't know for sure if Catra would agree to spend the evening with her. Not with the way things were going between them. It hit Adora that she didn't even know how to start a conversation with Catra anymore that wouldn't start and end with an apology.

Can I even talk to her anymore, for real? Or have I ruined everything, just like I ruined all my chances to reconnect with Mara?

She was convinced of it: without Catra in her bed, she'd be forced to toss and turn all night with the spectre of her mother, every hazy memory compromised by the revelations that had twisted her entire being into question.

How am I supposed to grieve someone who wasn't even who I thought they were?

Adora couldn't hold her flimsy emotional armour from splintering any longer. All her usual tools for staving off dangerous emotions had deserted her. On this stage, in the middle of this kitschy, greying bar, Adora couldn't run, or do push ups, or cocoon herself against the softness of Cara's body.

Th

Th

Th

H

B

The weight of Mara pressed on Adora incessantly as the song bust through every unconscious attempt at disassociation. The attention of the swim team seemed suddenly too oppressive, and the shitty spotlights focused on her too bright;even Catra' s brilliant voice scratched unbearably at her senses.

She dropped the mic to the floor with a clatter, her throat tightening. Adora brought her hands to her face - *am I crying?* - and coughed as her chest heaved, a wail bleeding out and betraying every single muscle that strained to keep her calm and composed. Everything seemed to be happening fast and slow all at once: the rush of salt

water down her cheeks;her quick descent to the floor of the stage, her hands gripping the mic stand as she sunk;the blanket comfort of Catra's arms folding around her, kisses pressed to her forehead and cheeks;a shaking hand tucking fallen hair behind her ear;her head being pulled to Catra's chest as she sobbed.

"I've got you, love," Catra's gentle murmur swallowed Adora whole, "Let it all out, it's okay."

For a short second, Adora thought that Catra's presence was all that mattered - she was sure that Catra was the only person capable of making the pain of everything stop. Yet slowly it dawned on her that Catra's affection was visible, plain as day, to everyone.

They're all gonna know.

Adora stiffened in Catra's arms, scrambling away from her to scan the audience. Her teammates were watching her with a whole cocktail of emotions that Adora didn't have the bandwidth to interpret. Catra seemed to realise what had happened at the same time, her fingers releasing Adora's bicep instinctively.

"Oh, fuck, Adora-"

"Oh my God," Adora wiped at her face harriedly, the air wheezing out of her chest, "You... I can't believe you did that."

Catra paled, her jaw dropping open. She didn't have much time to respond;the bar staff insisted on helping them off the stage, totally unaware of the grenade that was detonating between them. Adora stumbled away from Catra bewildered, her sight blurring under the dim bar lights. She grasped at the space around them, clambering to find the exit.

"Adora!"

She could barely hear Catra calling after her as she pushed her way out and launched herself into the cobbled streets.

“Adora! Please, stop!”

Adora dropped to the curb, her head in her hands. She had no choice but to abandon the denial that had governed her every move for months. Everything was out in the open and she had absolutely no control over it.

“I never meant to do that, I promise,” Catra hovered behind her in tears, her footsteps cautious and unsteady, “Dora, I’m so sorry.”

Adora felt totally numb. Catra waited for what seemed like an age, the sound of her sniffles cutting through the ruckus of the street. Adora had no idea what she wanted, or how to feel. Eventually, Catra lowered herself to the edge of the pavement next to her, a careful distance between them.

“Will you say something? You’re freaking me out.”

Adora looked at Catra, searching for blazing fury within herself. Yet however much she wanted there to be, there was simply blankness there. So she did what she wished she’d been able to do in every public place they’d spent time together: she closed the gap between them and kissed her.

A surprised squeak escaped Catra and she drew back in shock, staring at Adora quizzically.

“What are you doing?”

“What do you think I’m doing?”

Catra frowned, her pupils darting around Adora’s face in disbelief.

“I just outed you, Adora,” Catra sounded heartbroken in the way that Adora supposed she should feel, “You should be furious with me. *I’m* furious with me.”

Adora didn’t have the energy to process any of it. It was as if she were a tumbler glass, heavy with water at the bottom but weightless

at the top;keenly aware of how much she was holding, but utterly unable to connect her two halves.

She sighed, deciding that if honesty had already been forced upon her, she may as well participate by choice.

"I cant stop thinking about whether Mara would have been okay with us."

"Huh?"Catra startled a little in response, confused by Adora' s unexpected reaction to what she'd said, "What do you mean?"

"Mara,"Adora repeated herself, "Do you think she'd have been alright about us being a thing?"

"Of course,"Catra' s answer was tentative, as if she were scared of tiptoeing around Adora's unspoken fragility, "Why wouldnt she have been?"

"I dont know ,"Adora dropped her eyes to her feet, watching Catra' s platform boots shuffle a little closer to her worn red Converse, "There' s no way of knowing, not really. I dont actually know what she thought about anything."

"W ell,"Catra spoke slowly , "I think that Mara would have just wanted you to be happy. Whatever that looks like."

Adora nodded, clasping Catra's hand.

"Maybe."

Catra hummed, squeezing Adora' s fingers. Adora was versed well enough in her tells to know that Catra was beyond nervous.

"I really am sorry , you know."Catra finally broke the gap in conversation, "About everything."

"Me too, Cat."

Adora hoped that Catra understood what she was trying to say. There wasnt much she could do to erase the previous months, but if her brain point blank refused to process the night's events, then Adora would jump on the chance to be the girlfriend she thought Catra deserved all this time.

Maybe this is a good thing. Maybe now we'll really have a chance at forever.

Sidestepping the emotional fallout of Catra's mistake seemed to Adora to be a far better option than opening herself up to the consequences of betrayal.

This is okay . Im okay . It had to happen eventually , so it's for the best. There' s nothing to be upset about at all…

Adora was sure of it. She would salvage the remains of their relationship and prove that she could love Catra with all the unrestrained ferocity in the world - no matter how heavy the cost.

Chapter End Notes

> In case you didn't know the song that triggered Adora's grief, it's the classic 'Tears in Heaven' by Eric Clapton - perhaps expected, but since when has Adora not been kinda predictable?
>
> I would love to hear your thoughts on this chapter and predictions for what will happen to our beloved messy exes next!Seeing those notification emails with your kudos and comments genuinely makes my day ♥
>
> Next time, we'll see how their relationship progresses out in the open (dare I promise some fluff?) and we're going to Dryl to uncover how Catra lost her hearing...

Chapter 12

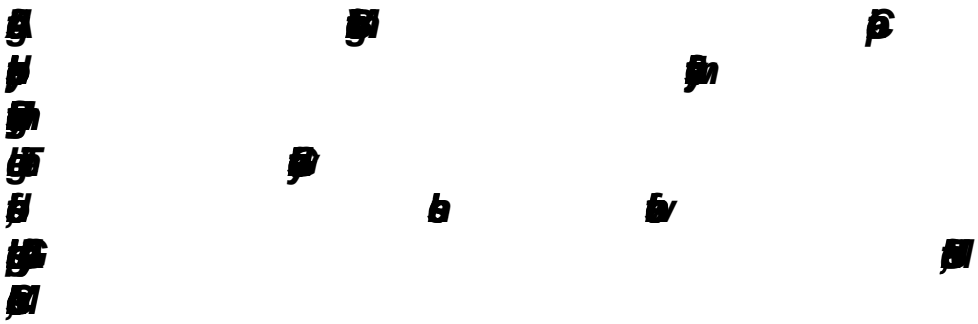
Chapter Notes

> Our penultimate flashback chapter, leading us right up to the big catalyst of the OG Catradora break up and the angst our current not-couple find themselves dealing with!How do you think it will all unfold?
>
> We're getting ever closer to the most sensitive part of this fic (at least for me to write it), so I really hope you like it - kudos and comments always massively appreciated x

See the end of the chapter for more notes

S[redacted]RS AGO

Adora hauled herself out the water, her head whipping round to the stalls as she tugged her goggles off. She couldnt stop the grin from breaking out across her face: Catra was exactly where shed hoped shed be, screaming with excitement even though Adora knew that Catra would probably have rather been anywhere else. At least, anywhere else if Adora didnt factor into it.



She caught Catra’s eye as the loudspeaker rang out, her chest heaving with the effort of completing her race. Her teammates were crowding around her, clapping her on the back and pulling her into a

group hug as the entire stadium roared. Still, Adora barely registered any of it;she was already slipping through the knot of swimmers and rushing towards the stands. Catra ran down the stadium stairs towards her, dropping her BMU placard on the steps and flinging her arms around Adora.

"Cat, Im wet!"

Catra smirked at her, leaning forwards to growl surreptitiously in Adora's ear.

"So am I," Catra cackled at Adora's blush, crossing her wrists behind the swimmer's neck, "You fucking did it!"

Catra pressed their lips together with a fervour and adrenaline rushed through Adora's veins all over again, her every nerve reacting to the feel of Catra's eyelashes grazing her skin. She forced herself to ignore the tiny nervous skip in her stomach that still sometimes twisted when Catra kissed her like this in public. Even though their relationship had been known for six whole months, Adora still sometimes worried about what people would think.

There are scouts here - should Ireally be doing this instead of being with the team?

Adora leaned forwards to kiss Catra again, determined to oust her thoughts with the addictive scent of Catra's hair products and body oil.

"I'm so proud of you, Dor," Catra teased her purple BMU swim cap off gently, "You totally smashed it."

Adora smiled, leaning into Catra's touch as her girlfriend detangled her damp hair lazily with her fingers. She knew she should get back to the team benches - there was still one more race to get through, and Adora didnt want to be accused of not caring about anyone else's events.

"Go on," Adora marvelled at how Catra seemed to be able to read her mind and how simple their communication had become, "Do your thing and I'll see you at the pub."

"Okay," Adora pecked Catra's lips once, twice for good measure, "I'll see you there."

"Counting on it, princess."

Begrudgingly, Adora made her way back to the poolside, nodding sheepishly in response to the congratulations from everyone she passed. She dropped into place on the bench next to Mermista, giving Glimmer a thumbs up while she warmed up for her relay before waving a final goodbye to Catra from across the room. Mermista watched Adora with an amused look in her face, chucking a granola bar at her.

"What?" Adora quipped as she tore open the wrapper and broke off the end of the bar, "No 'well done' for the tournament's top swimmer?"

Mermista snorted, clearly unwilling to take the bait of Adora's cockiness. She tipped her head towards Catra, pointedly overlooking Sea Hawk's frenzied attempts to grab her attention from the stalls.

"Not that I care or anything, but if Open Mic's the reason you're doing so well, you better not ruin it."

"Mermista," Adora squeaked, chewing through her response, "I'm not with Catra because it gets my times down."

"Yeah, yeah, it's 'cos she makes you happy or whatever. But that's like, literally, why you're swimming so well. You're not so super stressed all the time," Mermista nudged her shoulder fondly and Adora knew that Mermista was attempting to compliment her and Catra's relationship in her own strange way, "It'd be kinda cute if you weren't so, like, totally disgusting around each other."

Adora didnt have a chance to retort before the starting signal for Glimmer’s race ripped through the air - and all of a sudden, the building was charged with electricity again. They both jumped to their feet, shouting as Glimmer dove into the water and yelling encouragement at her fellow relay team members.



Adora held out Glimmer’s bottle for her, already teeing herself up for her friend’s inevitable sullenness - Glimmer had never been a good loser.

“Great job!” Adora tried to sound as enthusiastic as possible while Glimmer gulped down water, “That was so close, it really could have gone either way!”

“I knew we should have kept Spinny in the line-up instead of giving Flutterina a spot,” Glimmer sulked, “W e would have fucking had it!”

“It’ s no big deal, we’ve still got Dryl next month,” Adora tried to cheer her up, “It’ s not the end of the season yet!”

“Where is Adora and what the fuck have you done with her?” Glimmer rolled her eyes in feigned annoyance, tossing the water bottle back into Adora’s hands as she grabbed her towel off the bench, “Shtupping on the daily has made you soft, bitch.”

“Soft? Are you serious?”

“I told you,” Mermista smirked as she followed Glimmer to the changing rooms, wiggling her eyebrows in jest, “Disgusting.”

“What? Guys!” Adora grabbed her stuf f off the bench, “W e still have the medal ceremonies!”

“Y eah, yeah,” Glimmer winked over her shoulder , not slowing for a second, “Y ou’re only gonna spend it eyefucking Catra across the

room."

"Actually , she's going to the pub to grab our tables early - after those rugby blokes stole them last week, she said-"

Glimmer raised an eyebrow in Adora's direction to cut her off, and it reminded Adora so much of Catra that she knew immediately the jg was up.

"So, you're not gonna deny that if she were staying, you would?"

Adora couldn't help but chuckle in concession when Glimmer threw her head back and laughed with delight - she'd been well and truly clocked. It had taken long enough for her to get comfortable with the friendly banter that met any team member who'd been getting frisky with someone new;by now , Adora figured that she may as well make up for lost time.

When the team eventually ambled into the pub, metal discs clanging against her chest, Adora was practically sore with the need to find her girlfriend. She scanned the room as soon as they arrived, foregoing the chance to dump her stuff at their table;she'd already spotted Catra by the beer pumps, one boot resting on the brass foot rail. Adora didn't have eyes for anything other than the way Catra' s bum looked in faded black denim, her cropped band t-shirt rising to reveal the clasp of a dark red bra - *Adora' s favourite* - as she leaned over the bar's wooden surface. Adora made immediately to sneak up on Catra, fingers tingling in anticipation of her touch, only to see a Diet Coke pushed into view next to her. Catra turned round with her own drink in hand before Adora even reached her, a satisfied glint in her blue eye.

"You're a lot less subtle than you think, Dor ,"Catra moved closer to trace the edges of Adora's gold medals with her finger, "I could hear you barging over here as soon as you arrived."

Adora scoffed, swinging her gym bag off her shoulder onto the floor and taking a sip of the drink Catra had gotten her.

"Thanks for this," Adora reached out to Catra and rested her hand on the waistband of Catra's jeans, not quite confident enough to dig into her back pocket and pull Catra all the way to her, if really needed it."

"You're welcome," Catra smiled at her, eyes crinkling at the edges, "You deserve it."

"Christ, you've gone soft as well," Glimmer appeared out of nowhere next to them and swiped Adora's glass for a quick swig, eyeing Catra playfully, "This needs a double vod in it if I've got to spend the rest of the day with you two."

"Actually, that's mine." Adora trailed off as Glimmer walked away with her glass, her voice dropping to a mutter, "Not any more, I guess."

"Hey, Sparkles!" Catra yelled out across the busy pub, "Get your boyfriend to buy you a drink next time!"

Glimmer blushed furiously, sticking her middle finger up at Catra. Adora elbowed her gently, signalling to the barman that she wanted another Coke.

"What? She took your drink."

"Catra." Adora rolled her eyes, though she couldn't help but smile at Catra's staged innocent expression, "You know she's been super weird about this crush on Bow."

"I'm only helping them along," Catra smirked at her, intertwining their fingers, "It's obvious he's into her too. Besides, there's enough useless queers in this group already."

"So you admit it! You're part of the Best Friend Squad!"

"Yeah, yeah, whatever."

Adora grinned - it was a huge improvement on Catra's begrudging willingness to reference her growing friendship with Glimmer and

Bow at all, let alone for Adora to be mentioning the official BFS title. Catra eyed her mischievously, squeezing her hand.

"I gotta wipe that stupid grin of f your face, it's annoying."

"Oh yeah?"

Catra leaned in and Adora couldnt think about anything other than the dark cherry pink of her lips even if she tried.

"Y eah. Doesnt mean that I like you or anything."

"Course not," Adora captured Catra' s lips with her own, deepening the kiss before they broke apart, "How' s that going for you, anyway?"

She grinned even wider than before, staring right into Catra's eyes.

"Didnt work. Guess I better try again."

It wasnt until they were tangled up on the sofa that night, the cotton of Catra's pyjama shirt pressed flush against Adora' s side, that Adora worked up the courage to say what had been playing on her mind for weeks.

"I wish I hadnt waited so long."

"Hmmm?" Catra' s voice was muffled, a forkful of the risotto she'd made for them garbling her words, "What do you mean?"

"W e could have been together properly all this time, if it werent for me."

Adora knew Catra wouldnt like talking about the subject of their closeted relationship or Adora's coming out; just as expected, she'd tensed in Adora's arms, her body jolting against her chest and making Adora knock the bowl she'd been balancing on the sofa arm.

"Things are good now ," Adora could tell Catra was treading carefully , "That' s all that matters."

"You think?" Adora clinked her spoon against the side of the bowl, suddenly not so hungry despite Catra's effort to make her favourite meal.

"I know . Let's just focus on that, hmm?" Catra turned and pressed a kiss to Adora's arm, "Do you want more parm?"

Adora nodded, but she wasn't sure to what. Still, she waited for Catra to reach across her body to the coffee table and sit up from her position between Adora's thighs, twisting to face her better and grate the cheese into her bowl. It was another reminder of how much being together had changed them; of how Catra had insisted on buying the fanciest, most expensive parmesan in the supermarket to celebrate Adora's win even though Adora knew she'd been meticulously counting the pennies as her student loan began to run out. It made the love she had for Catra burst in her chest all over again, and the memories of how many times Catra had taken care of her in so many ways seeped into her veins like a potion. Adora knew then and there that she'd never fuck this up. She and Catra were endgame - there was no-one else she could possibly share this life with.

"Hey , Catra?"

"Yeah?"

Catra looked up at her, putting her own bowl down. She moved closer to Adora, pushing her hair behind her ear. Adora leaned into her touch, stopping herself from saying something ridiculous and stupidly premature, like asking Catra to marry her.

"Will you come to Dryl with me next month? For the qualifiers?"

"Is that what you're worked up about?" Catra raised her eyebrow , relief settling a little on her face, "You're in the strangest mood tonight."

"Mmmhmm," Adora said, rubbing Catra's foot with her own, "Will you?"

Catra grinned, snuggling into Adora's torso. Her hair tickled Adora's chin as she wriggled under her arm, picking a scrap of lost pumpkin off Adora's collarbone and sucking it off her thumb.

"I think I might have a gig that weekend, DT mentioned their agent was looking for an act for a fundraising thing."

"Oh," Adora tried to stifle her disappointment but failed to do so effectively, "You shouldn't miss that."

I don't want to be the person holding you back.

"It's just money, Dor, obviously I'll come with you. This is the meet that the Etheria scouts are coming to, right?"

I'll be whatever you need.

Adora nodded slowly, unsure why her heart was beating so fast. She almost felt like she was inviting Catra on some romantic holiday set to change their lives, where she'd make some gesture that would prove to Catra and everyone else how much she was in this; how much the past year of their lives - in secret and beyond - had meant to her.

"Are you sure?" Adora's voice had dropped down to a mere murmur, "We could make a trip of it, I guess. Maybe stay on in Dryl after the meet? I could get us a fancy room somewhere for a treat."

Catra made a noncommittal noise, stretching up to peck Adora's lips. They both knew that a splurge like that would require Adora to tap into her inheritance from Mara for the first time, and she hadn't even done that to pay down her share of the deposit on their rental studio.

"Up to you," Catra laid her head on Adora's chest, and Adora hoped the booming whoosh of her heartbeat wasn't too obvious - or at least

that Catra wouldn't mention it, "Just focus on your race - who knows what could happen with how well you've been doing. This is everything you've been working for, right?"

"Right."

Catra hummed against Adora's sternum, her fingers slipping under her vest to rest over her heart. She rubbed at the skin there tenderly, soothing Adora without any words, letting her know that everything was alright. The tension in her body began to loosen a little with every stroke. There were a million ways they'd learned to show their love to each other - showing up at every notable gig or swim meet, easing off when one of them had to study, getting more comfortable with each other's friends. Adora had even given Scorpia her phone number, though she secretly hoped she wouldn't end up talking to her too much.

It made Adora smile to think about how the two of them had settled into such simple domesticity. After she'd defended Catra from Glimmer's wrath and Bow's discomfort following their fateful night at karaoke, she'd convinced Catra to move into the studio she'd found right by campus;it had felt like a miracle when she'd finally agreed to it, questioning whether Adora had really processed everything that had happened between them. But Adora had been as certain then as she was now: she was only interested in looking forwards, and above all else, she really needed a win. Coming home to Catra after a long day of classes and training was a win rivalled by no other.

Adora liked watching Catra compose at her keyboard station from her favourite place on the sofa, seeing how the wrinkle between her eyebrows would deepen when she was trying to figure out a melody, and how she'd smile wryly, her incisor cutting into her bottom lip, when she'd had a eureka moment. She still wouldn't let Adora listen to any of her original compositions, but Adora often thought that getting to watch Catra make music was a far greater privilege than hearing the results - not that Catra took her seriously when she told her. Catra also didn't take Adora seriously when she insisted that it was down to her that she'd got the Vice Captain swim team spot.

Still, Adora knew that she'd have never put herself up for the role against older, more senior swimmers without Catra's positive encouragement, even if her times and commitment to training were completely unparalleled. It was undeniable: Catra was a good thing and Adora was sure she couldn't have too much of her.

"What are you smiling to yourself about?" Catra mumbled into Adora's breastbone, her breath tickling the plane of pale skin.

"Not much," Adora brought her fingers to Catra's jaw, stroking the curve from her chin to her ear, "just feeling good."

"Good," Catra craned her head back to reciprocate the lazy smile that had settled on Adora's face, "Me too."

Catra didn't usually sleep during long drives, but she'd been knocked out cold for the past couple of hours en route to Dryl. Adora didn't mind too much - she'd closed her own eyes and pretended she was asleep too, relishing the weight of Catra's head on her shoulder and the soothing inhale-exhale waves of her breath. It worked in Adora's favour to withdraw a little from her teammates' bus antics; she was never much in the mood for group singalongs or games before a meet. Cocooning herself with Catra at the back of the bus and thinking over her race strategy, multiple rows and decibels behind anyone else, suited her just fine.

She felt Catra rouse next to her, her face grimacing as she woke.

"Hey, sleepyhead, you hanging in there?"

Catra groaned and twisted in her seat to pull her knees up to her chest, "I'm never agreeing to a six AM start again."

"W ell get you used to swim life," Adora joked, "Y oull be getting up with me everyday at five before you know it."

"I've managed so far - don't bank on it." Catra peeked at Adora out of one eye, swallowing thickly and clearing her throat, "I feel like I've been hit by a brick wall."

Adora took Catra in, studying the slight flush of her cheeks and the grey bags under her eyes. She hadn't thought the trip would be so rough on her girlfriend; it made her gratitude towards Catra for coming to Dryl warp a little with guilt about their early start. Still, Adora reminded herself, unless they wanted to drive down on their own and cover a hefty petrol bill, taking the team coach was their only option.

"T ry this," she patted her lap, pulling on Catra' s arm to help her settle down, "See if you sleep better ."

Catra dozed off pretty quickly , and Adora was almost jealous - she ended up spending most of the eight hour drive wide awake, the winding roads up rugged mountain peaks and craggly boulder paths making the most steel-stomached of them a little nervous. The only saving grace was seeing the Salineas team stumble off their coach when they arrived at the hotel complex all the competition swimmers were staying at. They looked just as green-gilled as Adora' s team did.

"Y ou better go out without me," Catra sighed once they dumped their bags in their hotel room, making it immediately clear she had no intention of joining the team dinner , "I'm knackered."

"Y ou don't want anything? Y ou've barely eaten all day ."

Catra rested her hand on her stomach as if weighing it up; she coughed a little, and Adora wondered if asking Catra to come with her was a good idea after all.

"Maybe I could get some soup or something? My throat' s a bit sore."

Adora rummaged in her backpack, wrenching a small bag stuffed with painkillers and vitamin supplements out from underneath all her travel snacks, "This help?"

Catra nodded, taking the pills from her and swallowing a couple of capsules dry with difficulty. "Good thing I didn't stay home for that fundraiser - the last thing I wanna do right now is sing."

"Why don't we order in here and chill for the night?" Adora beamed, suddenly delighted she'd come up with a good idea, "I don't wanna get worn out before tomorrow anyway."

Catra smiled and let herself fall backwards onto the bed; Adora knew she'd said exactly what Catra hoped for but would never actually ask.

"That sounds nice, Dor."

Adora eased Catra's boots off her feet and crawled onto the bed beside her, leaning close to push Catra's hair off her face.

"*You're* nice."

"Oh my God," Catra giggled, her laughs morphing into coughs as they tailed off, "You're such an idiot."

"Your idiot, though."

"Yeah," Catra rolled onto her side, nuzzling into Adora's shoulder just like they were back on the bus, "Guess you are."

"Where's Catra?" Glimmer peered behind Adora as they gathered in the hotel lobby, a yawn stretching across her speech, "Is she not coming?"

"She's still sleeping. The bus really took it out of her."

"Oh," Glimmer shrugged, stretching her arms up above her head and twisting - her curious expression made Adora worry that maybe she should go back to her room and check on Catra again, though she was sure she was just being paranoid, "it's cool of her to come, anyway. Just don't make it too often - I'm not sharing with Mermista instead of you every time! She has *such* an annoying night routine!"

Adora chuckled. She couldn't imagine Mermista was *that* much of a princess, "Don't you have a seven-step skincare routine?"

"Not everyone has a magical chlorine-resistant, acne-deterring face, Adora!" Glimmer leaned in conspiratorially, "She played crashing wave sounds all night. I had to go to the loo like eight times!"

"Whatever," Mermista drawled as she walked past them, tallying up the number of swimmers who had made it to the lobby on time, "I know you're refreshed as fuck. You're, like, way more awake than normal this morning - thank me when you set a new PB."

Glimmer opened her mouth to respond, her lips stuck in an 'o' shape as she considered Mermista's observation. Adora couldn't stop a short burst of laughter escaping her, only making Glimmer purse her lips and cross her arms indignantly.

"You're gonna be pissed whether you lose or win now!"

"Dammit," Glimmer shook her head in pouting disbelief, "I really am."

They were halfway through the competition program and Catra still hadn't turned up at the pool. Adora chewed at the skin around her

fingernails, frowning at the section in the stadium seating that the Bright Moon supporters had been allocated.

She probably just overslept. We stayed up way too late last night watching those stupid movies. She'll get here any minute.

Adora tried not to let it get to her too much - her races had gone way better than she'd expected so far. Another personal best was set in her front stroke and several scouts had approached Micah for conversations during the breaks.

It has to be for me - no-one else has won anything outright for BM yet.

She wanted to stay humble but it was hard to stop the excitement fizzing in her veins. If she could get a professional contract, it would change everything. With a proper salary on top of their student loans - *a Team Eteria salary, even!* - they wouldn't have to scrimp and save at all. Adora could cover their rent for both of them easily, and Catra could focus on gigs that pushed her songwriting career forwards instead of getting booked up with weddings and birthday parties.

"Adora," Mermista's voice cut through her thoughts, "Have you, like, checked your phone or anything today?"

Adora tensed at the memory of how she'd left her phone alone back when Mara died, and how much she'd tried to minimise her use of it ever since. She failed to suppress the shiver that rippled through her body, puckering up goosebumps on her arms and shoulders.

"I turn it off at meets. Everything okay?"

"Perfuma's calling me - apparently Scorpia's been trying to get hold of you for ages? She said Catra's gone AWOL."

Adora held her hand out for Mermista's phone, her arm shaking a little.

"Hey , Perfuma. What's going on?"

"Hi Adora. Im sure you have everything in hand but Scorpia' s rather concerned that we couldnt get hold of either of you," Perfuma spoke slowly and sagely, and Adora wished she would just get to the point - it was putting her on edge, "Y ou know what she's like, so wonderfully vulnerable in that way, and she does have a slight tendency to worry about Catra-"

"Perfuma," Adora interrupted her urgently and repeated herself, "What' s going on?"

"W ell, she hasnt heard from Catra for quite a few hours now , and given that she mentioned how high her temperature was, I felt it was worth checking with you just in case-"

Dread built in the pit of her stomach;Mermista and Spinnerella noticed her change in mood and stepped closer, the latter reaching out to lay a reassuring hand on her upper back.

"What do you mean, she mentioned how high her temperature was?" Adora blurted it out in a panic, her tone a little more hysterical than intended in front of the other swimmers, "She didnt say anything before I left this morning!"

Adora glanced over at the large pool clock - Catra had been alone for over five hours now. She wracked her brain for memories of that morning: how Catra's speech had been a little hoarse and blurry, but not particularly alarming;that Catra insisted she should go ahead and warm up early instead of waiting for her to get out of bed;how stupid she'd been for not reading between the lines, of being so distracted by her hopes of impressing the Etheria scouts.

Ishould have known better . Ishould have gone back to check before Ileft.

She tossed Mermista's phone back to her without even hanging up.

I gotta get back to the hotel."

Adora didn't wait for Mermista to respond, though she'd started to catch the attention of her other teammates. She tugged her jacket on brusquely, jamming her feet into her flip flops.

"We've still got four races," someone called out after her - probably Flutterina, though she didn't care to check, "You can't go now, the relay's in half an hour!"

Adora turned to Micah, priming herself for an argument; she'd be dropping out of their new line-up for the relay, already a sore spot for several of her team members, none of whom were as strong as Adora in the butterfly stroke. She was practically handing the win to Salineas on a platter.

"Coach, I'm sorry but Catra's-"

Micah held his hand up, "Mermista, you're on butterfly for the relay," Adora could practically feel the unspent energy evaporating off her shoulders, "Call me once you get there, Grey."

The whole way back to the hotel was a blur after that. She'd managed to get a lift from someone's parents - one of the overzealous first years who had their sights set on team captaincy in the future - but Adora couldn't bring herself to call Catra. She stared at the mobile in her hands, petrified of tempting fate; she was sure that turning it on prematurely would evoke the wrath of the cruel mobile phone gods. The phone burned a hole in Adora's palm when she sprinted into the lobby, as she jumped from foot to foot waiting for the lifts, and while ripping her way down the seventh floor corridor. Her heart almost stopped when she stood outside the door of their room. It took four attempts to unlock it with the key card properly.

"Catra?

Adora slipped inside quietly, praying that behaving as if Catra was just asleep would make it more likely to be true. The room was still pretty dark and cold despite it being mid-afternoon;the lights were off and the blackout curtains drawn shut.

"You okay? Perfuma called me about your temperature."

Adora approached the bed, but she couldnt see her girlfriend there. The sheets were tangled halfway off the bed, drooping over the floor. She could see Catra's pyjama top had been shucked off even further away from the mattress - *that's not normal, she gets cold with the AC on* - but it wasnt until she saw a shaking foot peeking out the bathroom that she gripped her phone harder, finally turning it on. She rushed to turn the bathroom lights on, dropping to her knees when she saw that Catra was curled up on the tiles, a sweaty sheen covering her face as her head lolled on the ceramic.

"D-D-Dora?" Catra's teeth chattered but Adora couldnt believe how hot she was when she set the back of her palm against the brunette's forehead, "You s-s-swimming?"

"I'm not swimming right now, Cat," Adora fought to keep calm as she noticed a speckled red rash spreading from Catra's stomach to swollen glands, sandpapery to the touch, "Why arent you in bed?"

It was a pointless question - she realised as soon as she'd said it that Catra had been sick, probably multiple times. Adora grabbed at the toilet roll to help clean Catra up a little but she was already starting to lose consciousness, her breath petering into a shallow wheeze as her eyelids flickered.

"I d-dont feel g-g-good"…

"I know, babe," Adora dialled 999 as fast as she could despite the constant buzzing of her phone, a flood of message and call notifications from Scorpia and Perfuma finally unleashed. She turned Catra onto her side into the recovery position as she waited for an operator to pick up, determined to get something right;to not fuck

everything up the way she always seemed to, "I've got you, it's all gonna be alright."

This time it has to be.

Chapter End Notes

Did you catch that little pumpkin risotto link to a previous non-flashback chapter? The plot (or maybe the dish) thickens!

Coming up is our final flashback chapter - let me know what you think is going on with Catra's health and how you think it will affect Adora and their relationship... all will be revealed soon!

Thank you so much for reading and staying with this WIP - this one is particularly close to my heart ❤

Chapter 13

Chapter Notes

When I decided to write this fic, the idea of this chapter was the one that got me to do it. There is a lot here that speaks to my personal experience of living in a hearing (non-Deaf) environment with severe hearing loss, even though I remember very little from being diagnosed at primary school. I hope that - despite the angst - you see it just as one facet of the disabled experience and not an entirety. There are many rich, deeply valuable aspects to embracing disability that are central to my experience and my advocacy work in real life, and I often say that I wouldn't take my hearing back even someone paid me to do it. So - the positive part of Catra's journey with hearing loss will come, but it was really important to me that I didn't try to whitewash any of the frustration or grief that I've had in the past, or that someone in Catra's position would likely have.

A special and deeply grateful thanks to ResFlower and RaptorRed for beta-ing this chapter and helping me ensure that the emotions and dialogue did exactly what I wanted them to do. They both have written some exceptional works, so if you somehow haven't already checked out their SPOP fics, this is your PSA to do so!

I would love to learn how reading this was for you - so please remember that comments and kudos are much appreciated x

See the end of the chapter for more notes

SIXTEEN YEARS AGO

The first thing Catra had noticed was how the soreness in her throat had spread through her whole body, her own bones and flesh

weighing her down and pinning her to itchy sheets. She had felt a spot of damp on the back of her hand, the rake of something ember-light - eyelashes, maybe - against her forearm. She'd groaned, stirring as the air had shifted around her, the dull presence of someone nearby simmering above.

She knew now that Adora had sat with her for hours, refusing to leave her bedside despite her coach and teammates' concern that she hadn't been sleeping or eating properly;that Adora had come back from her meet to find her on the bathroom floor with a delirious fever;and that Adora had packed all their stuff up and sent it back to Bright Moon with the swim team while she recovered in hospital. It had been Adora, too, who had held her hand when the doctor explained what had happened to her - that a simple strep infection had blazed and morphed into scarlet fever to paint blistered red on her chest and throat.

"You could have died if they hadn't given you such powerful antibiotics," Adora's reedy, tear-stretched voice often echoed in her mind, *"or, we could have lost you."*

In her state of recovery disorientation, Catra had assumed for a while that the blurriness of the voices around her were purely symptomatic of post-viral exhaustion. She'd asked Adora to repeat what the doctor had said over and over again, her memory fuzzing halfway through sentences and hopping over consonants. Yet when she'd been discharged and had returned to their studio in Bright Moon, her tiredness had faded faster than the muffled sound around her.

Only hours beforehand, she'd focused all her attention and energy on listening to her doctor make sense of it.

"The treatment for life-threatening infections such as yours, Ms. Weaver, is a group of antibiotics called aminoglycosides. Due to their strength, it's not uncommon for them to cause hearing loss. Unfortunately, it seems that this may have been the case for you."

In her shock, Catra's first reaction was to joke.

"Better deaf than dead!" She'd paused abruptly then, steeped in the awkwardness forged between them, and held her tongue before asking the question that could open more wounds than heal them, *"Would it have made a difference if I'd have got to hospital sooner?"*

The doctor had hesitated before answering, though Catra had waited undeterred for an answer to her question.

"We can't say for sure. But it's possible that if you'd been treated sooner, you might not have needed such an aggressive treatment."

Catra had somehow managed to leave the appointment and sit in the audiology waiting room as if everything was still normal. But she'd been sure that the looming voice in the back of her head - the one telling her that her career was over, that the exhaustion muddying her brain after every half-caught conversation wouldn't magically disappear - would soon be proven right.

Now that she'd been ushered into a soundproof booth for her hearing test, Catra swept her eyes over its beige padding and viscose carpet. Although half the size, it didn't look that different to the small recording booth DT's manager had booked for her to record a demo only a few weeks ago. Just like then, her hair was flattened against her head with a pair of oversized headphones, and the familiarity of leather against her earlobes gave Catra the chance to pretend she'd returned to normalcy. Yet where microphones should have beckoned her voice, there was only a worn black button attached to a greying lead.

She imagined her mother watching her through the plastic window of the booth, standing behind the audio technician. Catra was well aware of how annoyed Shadow Weaver was at her for getting sick so far from home and dragging her away from work so inconveniently. She had cursed herself a million times for not updating her next of kin information since leaving home. Over a month on, her mother still insisted on getting a rundown of every

hospital appointment, if only to continually berate Catra for being foolish enough to accompany Adora to Dryl. There were no two ways about it: the whole thing was a perfect opportunity for Shadow Weaver to punish Catra for daring to stray from the path she'd chosen for her, and for putting her all-important orchestral potential at risk.

Catra cringed at the memory of how Shadow Weaver had sucked her teeth in distaste when she'd arrived at Dryl General to find Adora curled around Catra in her hospital bed. She could feel Adora tense at her mother's half-hidden insults, shame encroaching upon them and wrapping its dark tendrils around their ankles tighter with every visit and video call. Catra didn't know how to tell Adora that she'd noticed how the blonde always retreated a little from her when other people were around since then, never holding her hand quite as firmly.

She made so much progress, and you're purposefully undoing it stitch by stitch…

A mid-pitched beep jolted Catra out of her thoughts. Just as the technician had instructed her, she rushed to press the button to acknowledge the sound. It was a mindfuck, waiting with her thumb primed to hear what came through the headphones. Even though she'd been assured that there weren't any wrong answers, Catra felt that it was inevitable that she'd fuck the test up. Concentrating so hard on hearing (or not hearing) anything, she could easily get overzealous or confused, and then no-one would even be able to accurately tell her what was going on with her hearing at all.

How am I supposed to know if I'm hearing something or if I'm just imagining that I'm hearing something?

The test seemed to simultaneously last forever and no time at all, but the fact that Catra was directed straight to a third waiting room to get ear moulds fitted revealed enough for her to know that the dullness she was stuck in was set to stay. As a nurse pumped cold silicone putty into her ears with a syringe, Catra could see everything she'd

taken for granted slipping away. For the first time in her life, she felt that she couldn't depend on her most reliable sense - and she was sure that her lost confidence in it and herself would never fully return.

Adora had convinced her that getting an official diagnosis would only help. Now that Catra could stare at the paperwork sent from her consultant to the BMU disability services team, she wasn't quite so sure.

[illegible]

Catra had spent hours googling every single phrase in the report - always hidden from her girlfriend's concerned gaze (*boy, how the tables had turned*) - and she still had no clue how any of the reasonable adjustments Adora had meticulously researched would help her. A whole eight weeks since she got her hearing aids, every lecture seemed to go over Catra's head. Worse - what she could read in sheet music never seemed to translate out loud with the same dynamism as before.

How the hell am I supposed to finish a music degree like this?

She sighed, folding the papers along their worn creases and pressing them flat under her hands on the kitchen counter. Catra felt stupid for assuming that hearing aids would be a magic fix. She'd thought they'd be like glasses - put 'em on, and hey presto, *magic* . The fuzzy speech around her did clarify , steam condensing into water;but everything else got louder and sharper too. Alarms and

background chatter and shrill beeps stuck like unshakeable itchy pollen on her skin, drowning out whoever or whatever she actually wanted to hear.

Catra stood before the kettle and watched it boil, grateful to have given up on wearing her hearing aids for the evening. Adora was still at the pool training and Catra had barely cooked anything for them since she got sick;for nearly three months, they'd lived of f supermarket ready meals and batch-cooked leftovers that Scorpia and Perfuma had made.

Maybe if Istart cooking again, I'll feel a little more like Iused to.

The thought gave her resolve - and the challenge of figuring out what to make from the contents of their half-empty fridge was a welcome distraction. The kettle lever popped up just in time for Catra to decide - she forwent the tea she'd planned in favour of boiling spaghetti on the electric hob, mixing egg yolks, lemon juice, parmesan and olive oil in the biggest bowl she could find. Catra hummed to herself as she ground black pepper into the bowl, leaning into the familiarity of songs she'd always loved performing.

"Fu--!Ca--a!"

Catra gasped and jerked violently in shock when Adora appeared out of nowhere in the kitchen. All of a sudden, her girlfriend was right by her, lifting the pan of pasta off the starch-covered, waterlogged hob and turning the heat down. Catra gaped at Adora, trying to work out how long she'd been home.

"Shit, I didn't hear that happen!"

Adora placed a hand on the small of her back, tossing the dishcloth she'd used to wrap the pan handle on the counter .

"Y ou're all goo-,"Catra caught Adora looking in her ears out of the corner of her eye, and it made her twitch, "T aki-- a break fro- your heari-- ai--"?

"I have a headache," Catra pushed Adora away, grabbing the dishcloth and attempting to wipe up the excess water haphazardly, even though she knew it would be better to wait until it had cooled down, "When did you get home?"

"Oh. Li-era--y a minu-e ago, I rush-- in as soo- as I hear-"

"W ell, you should knock on the doorframe or something. You gave me the fright of my life!"

Catra could tell she was making Adora feel bad by interrupting her so roughly. Although it wouldn't help anything, it felt good for a moment to absolve herself of everything being her responsibility and loss. She busied herself draining the pasta, tossing it in the mixing bowl forcefully with spinach leaves.

"I know. I'm sorry, I didn'- mea- to shock you,"

Adora leaned into Catra's space to wrap her arms around her waist, and Catra could feel herself soften a little.

"I'll be more careful next time," Catra conceded. Making Adora feel as shit as she already did wasn't really helping to lift her mood, "Y ou hungry?"

"For your foo-? Alway-."

Adora spoke gently despite the sharpness of their exchange. Sometimes Catra wondered if 'water of f a duck's back' was Adora's new unspoken mantra; the number of times she'd managed not to rise to one of Catra's insults or barbed responses over the previous months was teetering in the hundreds by now. But Adora only pulled out Catra's chair for her as she carried their plates over to the table. Her eyes were as wide as saucers when she took her own seat, and she started gobbling down her dinner before Catra barely had a chance to pick up her cutlery.

"Thi- i- amaz-! Have you made thi- before?"

Catra smirked. Adora always knew how to cheer her up - and when it came from her girlfriend, praise was often an easy kink to satisfy.

"Nah, it' s an Adora special."

"Cau-- *Im* so specia-..."

Catra almost regretted saying anything thanks to the shit-eating grin on Adora's face.

"Sure, princess,"she reached out for Adora' s left hand, suddenly overcome with the need to touch her in apology for her earlier harshness, "Let' s go with that."

If Adora was surprised at all, she didnt show it. She just put her fork down and scooted her chair round the table, gripping Catra's hand harder and exhaling deeply. Adora looked at Catra with a reverence she hadnt remembered seeing for a while;a welcoming home of sorts.

Imissed you, Catra imagined Adora saying, the recent back and forth between them starting to thaw a little in the air, *Im so glad to have you back.*

There was only a week to go until Adora left for her next away meet and all Catra wanted was to take out her hearing aids, rip off her bra and cuddle up on the sofa. She tugged Adora down to the cushions when she walked past, smirking at Adora's half-hearted protestations.

"Hey ,"Adora laughed from her state of collapse on the sofa, "I've go- -a get a cardio workou- done tonigh-"

"I'm sure I can find a way to get your heart rate up," Catra wheedled, burrowing herself into Adora's side, "Plus, I know you wanna finish that film we started. I'll even let you put the subs on."

That made Adora pause - Catra had insisted countless times that she didn't need subtitles, only to get disgruntled when it was too much effort following anything without them. Catra knew it drove Adora up the wall. Still, admitting that she needed them made Catra feel like she'd never get her old life back; like there was no hope of picking up where she'd left off. When she played the piano, everything sounded generally as it should but somehow not *quite*. She always sought a richness that seemed just out of grasp, and pre-recorded music - which didn't have the immediacy of vibrations at her fingertips - was even flatter.

How could Adora, of all people, possibly understand what this feels like?

Catra looked away from her girlfriend, suddenly too timid to make eye contact.

"We don't have to put them on if you don't want them."

"It's fine. I've know I've been kind of stupid about it. It's just..."

Her voice trailed off but it didn't matter; for one reason or another, Adora didn't try to push her any further. She simply reached over Catra to fish the remote off the sofa arm and started up the TV, her eyes dutifully glued to the screen. Catra snorted as soon as the subtitles came on, rolling her eyes.

"Silence," she read the white text off the bottom of the screen flippantly, "Well, I can hear *that!*"

She turned to Adora incredulously, only to see her girlfriend catastrophically failing to keep a straight face.

"What?"

"S-sorry , Ca-," Adora was fast dissolving into laughter , straining to keep a lid on her giggles, "It' s jus-… *you ca-… hear tha-* !"..

Catra snorted at the sight of Adora - her laughter was infectious. It only took seconds to completely lose her own composure too.

"W e shou-wat-h the res- o- thi- pro-er-y ," Adora gasped through peals off laughter, "I actuay-do have to go to the gym tonigh-."

Catra sobered quickly . It seemed like they never spent that much quality time together anymore. At least, not the kind of quality time she missed, from before the big hearing loss elephant in the room moved in with them.

"Stay in with me. Please."

Adora's chuckles petered out and she scratched the back of her neck guiltily.

"I wish I cou-. Bu- I on-y ha-- a few day- before the compe-i-io-."

"Y oull be gone for ages, Dor!" Catra was being petulant but she didnt care, "And while youre having the fucking time of your life, Ill be stuck here on my own thinking about-"

Catra cut herself off sharply, standing up from the sofa and dusting off her bum and thighs as if there were dirt on her.

Ill be stuck here thinking about how everything' s changed for me and your life is still perfectly on track like it's supposed to be.

Catra waited for Adora to say something that would make it all better. She stared at her defiantly, goading the blonde into attempting to fix it.

"Caa." Adora spoke so hesitantly it was a wonder she made any sound at all, "Y ou could alway- come wi- me, if you reay-wan-."

They caught eye contact, both of them waiting for the other to say it before Catra finally cracked, her outburst splattering them sorely like the burst pellet of a paint gun.

"Yeah, that worked out *great* for me last time, Dor."

Adora shrank further into the cushions, though she started to gather her hair into a ponytail. Catra seethed, knowing what was coming.

She stood opposite Catra and wrung her wrists, "Maybe it's be~~er~~ if I go to the gym now and we fini~~sh~~ the film later."

"Yeah, whatever."

Catra left Adora to get ready for her workout, falling back onto their bed and turning away from the living space. She thought about getting up over and over again, wanting to stop Adora from going out before they resolved the discord between them. Nevertheless, when Adora called out to let Catra know she was leaving, she pretended not to hear a thing.

Catra stood at the door to the BMU pool stands, deciding whether it was a good idea to turn up unannounced at Adora's final training session before the Salineas meet. She rocked a little from left to right before pushing through the glass, stepping cautiously down the steps until she got to the front row of the spectator seating. Even though the pool was empty apart from the swim team, the shouts of the swimmers and the crash of water over racing bodies screamed in Catra's hearing aids, every echo ringing like feedback in her ears. She fiddled with her right aid, grimacing as the high-pitched whistle of air shooting through the ear mould pierced her ear drum.

"What's that noise?"

Catra looked up to find Glimmer hovering over her, her purple swim cap failing to keep wisps of lilac and pink hair from escaping. Catra smiled to herself, knowing that it probably drove Adora nuts to see Glimmer be so unfussed about maximising her aerodynamic form at such an important practice.

"Oh, sorry ," Glimmer winced at her own question, looking at Catra apologetically, "I dont know if you can hear that."

Catra tensed uncomfortably but she wasn't about to let anyone know it.

"It' s just the hearing aid," she muttered, wiggling it in her ear again in demonstration, "It does that when it' s not in properly."

Glimmer nodded, mulling over the information. She clearly wasn't sure what to say next, but Catra waited for her to sweat it out and change the topic.

"What are you doing here, anyway? Adora didn't say you were dropping by."

"I didn't tell her . I was hoping it would be a nice surprise. Things haven't been amazing recently ," Catra confessed after seeing Glimmer's face twist with confusion, her voice tightening with unspent emotion, "It' s kinda my fault, I've been sort of… *difficult*. And I haven't been to any of your meets since Dryl, so I don't want her to think that I'm not being supportive or anything," she dropped to a whisper, unable to speak truthfully at her usual volume, "Honestly , I'm worried that she might…"

Catra trailed off, biting her lip. She couldn't bring herself to admit it out loud.

"What? Dump you?" Glimmer snorted, waving her hand in the air dismissively, "As *if*, Catra. That girl's not going anywhere. For God's sake, she turned down Salineas University the second you got into BMU. You guys are gonna be fine."

Catra stared at Glimmer, not trusting that she'd heard her correctly.

"She turned down Salineas? Her first choice uni?"

"Come on, you remember this! I mean, it was nice thinking she wanted to stick with me and Bow at the time, but after the two of you got together and she stopped being so, like, uptight about the whole gay thing, it was pretty obvious. She literally had zero interest in picking BMU when we got in."

"I'm not sure she's stopped being that uptight about it." Catra muttered furtively under her breath.

Glimmer blinked a few times, suddenly a little self conscious.

"Wait, Catra. You *did* know that, right?"

"Course, Sparkles," Catra lied, the untruth slipping smoothly off her tongue, "Don't sweat it."

"Okay." Glimmer nodded unsurely, shivering for a second in her wet swimsuit, "Well, do you wanna come out for a drink after training? It's our last hurrah before the comp. I know Adora's not really into these things anymore but she'll probably come if you're up for it."

Catra leaned back in her seat, wondering how many times Adora had covered up that it was Catra who always turned down their invitations these days. Just thinking about sitting in a rowdy student bar was enough to give her a headache but she really wanted to do something nice for her girlfriend.

Maybe it's worth giving it a shot, it always used to be fun.

"Yeah, alright. I guess it's been a while."

Glimmer smiled - Catra never realised that she cared much for Glimmer, but they'd come far enough for a little warmth to spread in

her chest. It only grew when Adora joined them, her excitement at Catra's presence obvious.

"Hey , Adora," Catra drawled as her girlfriend shook the chlorine of f her shoulders, "Apparently , we're going out tonight."

Catra slammed the front door behind her, not waiting for Adora to follow her in. She felt stupid for accepting Glimmer's invitation that evening, for being naive enough to think she could enjoy herself for a night like old times.

"Catra!"

Adora's shout sounded dull through the wood, but she didnt turn around to open the door and let Adora in. That would be too easy.

She can use her fucking keys.

Catra listened out for the sound of Adora fumbling to unlock the door but it was hopeless. She didnt register a single thing until the door creaked open.

Ill add that one to the lost list then.

Catra dumped her keys and phone on the kitchen table, bracing herself for Adora to start questioning and consoling her . Like a rehearsed play, Adora behaved exactly how Catra expected, shucking her gym bag on the floor and looking at her with an expression that irritated Catra more than anything else: the one that said, '*How can I fix this?*

"What is going on, Catra? I promise you, no-one noticed!"

"Bullshit."

Catra barely looked up at the blonde. They both knew the truth - everyone had listened in when Catra started singing along to a song that was playing in the background, only for her to find out she'd completely mistaken the song for one that was entirely different.

"Cat. There's no need to be embarrassed. People do stuff like that all the time, honestly."

"I never do it!" Catra's shoulders tightened, her body winding tight like an electric coil, "I *do* it. Fuck!"

She could sense Adora's brain whirring, trying to figure out how to make her feel better. The problem was that Catra didn't want to feel better. She wanted to rage, to scream, to wrench her keyboard from its stand and bludgeon it into the ground.

"It'll get better," Adora had finally decided what she wanted to say, but every word scraped down Catra's skin sloppily like a blunt serrated knife, "It probably doesn't seem like it now, but it will, I know it! We could do one of those lip-reading classes together, or... like, maybe we save up and we buy you some better hearing aids than the basic ones the hospital gave you-"

"For God's sake, Adora! Don't you get it? I don't *want* to do the lip-reading class with you, or the BSL class, or read about whatever overpriced piece of tech you googled. I just want to go back to how it was before."

I want music to feel the way it used to.

"Catra-"

"And while we're at it," Catra growled, the fury in her chest barreling ahead of her brain, "Can you stop with the constant martyr shit?"

"Martyr shit?"

Adora sounded so confused and wounded, but Catra had lost all control over herself. Everything she'd been bottling up poured from her throat freely, finally granted the sweet relief she'd been denying herself.

"You have an unhealthy obsession with putting what you *think* I need first all the time, and it isn't fucking cute."

"What are you talking about?" Adora sounded small, her speech tinny, "I- I just want to be supportive, you've been going through so much."

"Come off it, this goes back way. You lied about getting into Salineas, Adora?"

She watched Adora's eyes widen in recognition, blue irises revealing her surprise that Catra knew about her decision to turn Etheria's best university swim team down.

"I- I wanted to be close to you. More than I wanted to go there."

"Adora," Catra groaned but Adora interrupted her before she could continue.

"I don't regret it! I've had all this time with you, and Bow and Glim - and Micah's a great coach, I'm better than I've ever been!"

Catra drank in the sight of her, palms stretched out in her direction in a complete contrast to how she'd folded her own arms across her chest.

"You're totally missing the point - you've been pissing everything away because you think *I* want you to! Do you have any idea what I'd give for another shot at my dream becoming a reality?"

"Catra, it still could, it'll just take time-"

"It *can't* . If you actually think that, then you really are an idiot."

Catra collapsed on the sofa, exhausted from it all. She expected Adora to join her, for them to smooth everything over now they'd got it off their chests and move on. But Adora didn't sit next to her, or even attempt to get any closer. Catra looked up to see Adora rooted in the same spot, her fingers kneading her forehead.

"You know, Catra, you've been dealt a really shitty hand and I'm sorry about that. Really. But I'm doing my best here, and I am *so fucking tired* of being your punching bag. It's like nothing is good enough for you to even try, and...and I can't keep playing happy families when you are so unwilling to help yourself, or cut me any fucking slack!" She sighed, her exhale enveloping Catra in regret, "This is new to me too - I need you to give *me* the benefit of the doubt this time."

The implication was clear: it was Catra's turn to bury her wounds for the sake of their relationship. Yet Adora's attempt to reason with the fallout of how Catra had accidentally outed them didn't strike the expected chord. Buoyed by defensiveness, Catra's blood boiled.

"I'm the first to admit that was a shitshow, Adora - you know how terrible I felt about it. But if you think that compares to this...I'm *really sorry* that you got to start being your full self around your friends and gain a whole new fucking lease of life!" Catra laughed bitterly, the sear of acid anger slick on her tongue, "And you know what else I'm sorry for? That when I was trying to be some kind of perfect, do-no-wrong girlfriend to you, *you* left me with a fever in a hotel room in a foreign city to fucking *swim*. And look at where that got me! If you'd never dragged me to Dryl, I'd probably be totally fine. Great, even!"

A heavy cloak of dread descended upon Catra the minute the words left her lips. She wanted to take it all back more than anything; she pleaded with Adora silently to see that, to know that she hadn't meant anything and it was all one big, adrenaline-fuelled mistake. But Adora didn't look at Catra at all. She ran her hand through her hair, messing up the fringe that she'd pinned back above her forehead and picking her bag back up from the floor.

f think I better crash at Bow' s tonight and give you some space."

A surge of panic swallowed Catra, f dont need space."

Not from you.

Adora stopped and glanced up at her, looking like it hurt to speak.

" *I* need it."

Despite everything in her body screaming at her to intervene, Catra didnt feel like she had any choice but to let Adora go.

Although Adora had come home the next day, her fingers didnt feel qite as confident as usual when they rested on Catra' s bicep, nor her embrace as tender. For two days, every conversation had existed in two halves: the casual intimacy that Catra had come to love and depend on;and the stilted awkwardness wrought from stepping around rugged cracks. Neither of them seemed to be willing or capable of addressing what they had said.

The morning that Adora left for Salineas, the pit of Catra's stomach twisted back and forth. She woke hours before Adora needed to get up, laying next to her in bed and examining every pore of Adora's face. She still didnt know how to bridge the divide that had grown between them but Catra was determined to make sure that Adora didnt go before shed had a chance to prove to her that things could still change for the better.

Icould still change for the better .

Catra waited until six to wiggle closer to Adora under the bedding, curling herself into the spot between Adora's arm and breast that she

hadn't slept in for days. She let out a breath of relief she hadn't even known she'd been holding when Adora tugged Catra closer , her chin slotting into place by the slope of her neck.

See? We can get past this.

She felt Adora stir a little and murmur in her shallow sleep, ripples of soft indecipherable vibrations skipping over Catra's collarbones.

"I was thinking we could go to Raz's when you're back from Salineas," Catra whispered, "I left most of my written compositions there, and I thought I might try writing again. Like you suggested."

Catra could imagine the wrinkle forming between Adora's eyebrows behind her.

"Hmmm. You do-' ha-to do tha- ju-ecau-l though- i- migh- be goo- for you."

"I want to."

They fell into silence for a while, their fingertips tracing lazy circles on each other's bodies. Catra could almost let herself believe they'd hit the rewind button;it was only her own tongue that tripped her back into the present, eager to erase the source of their tension.

"I really didn't mean it, Dor . I don't know why I said it."

A beat passed between them before Adora carded her fingers through Catra's hair.

"I know ."

"I'm sorry ."

Adora wrapped her arms around Catra fully, pressing them together. "I'm sorry too."

Catra sniffled in Adora's hold, hoping - *praying* - that it was enough to buy them a fresh start. She didn't know what Adora was really sorry for (knowing Adora, it was a combination of nothing and everything), but she convinced herself it didn't really matter . All Catra needed was a chance - and now she was far surer that they had one.

Catra tried not to think too much about the fact that Adora had gone incognito since she landed in Salineas, barely responsive on any channel of communication and always absent from the Snapchat and Instagram stories she saw Adora's teammates post. She carried on sending encouraging texts anyway, adamant that it was probably Adora's competition anxiety that was affecting her girlfriend's availability. When Adora finally FaceTimed the night before her flight home, Catra's heart soared, over a week's worth of concern eased in a second.

"Dor! I've been following everything online, I can't believe you swam so well!"

It was only then that she noticed the violet smudges splayed under Adora's lower eyelashes and the blotchy redness of her cheeks.

"Is everything okay?"

"Umm," Adora sniffled, "kind of."

"Are you sure? You seem really upset," Catra waited for Adora to elaborate, but she stayed quiet, chewing on her lip, "We can talk about it when you get home if you'd rather?"

Adora breathed in so deeply, Catra knew something terrible had happened. Her pulse began to pulse, worry creeping into her veins.

"I- I'm not coming home."

Catra nearly dropped the phone. She pressed her hearing aid deeper into her ear, sure she had misheard.

"What?"

"I had a few meetings with T eam Etheria and they want me. I'm transferring to Salineas at the end of term, and I start training here next week."

Catra was stunned, her mind flitting between the grenades Adora had thrown at her, "N-next week? But I've been waiting for you to come back this whole time. I- I really missed you."

"I've paid of f the studio for the rest of the year," it seemed like Adora was hellbent on ripping the bandaid off all in one go, "Y ou don't have to worry about rent until the lease is up, and Glimmer and Bow promised they'd come and pack my things."

The shock that had frozen Catra was starting to thaw , her confusion giving way to dismay as she watched Adora fumble through her speech.

"Why are you doing this?" Catra' s voice cracked with a sob, "I love you, Adora. What am I supposed to do without you here?"

She waited for Adora to reciprocate, but it didn't come. Catra could tell the words were on the tip of her tongue.

Why won't you say it back?

Finally Adora spoke, her voice trembling with every word.

"I don't think us being together is good for you, Cat. I forced you back into the closet, and to Dryl, and then everything else recently." Adora looked away from the camera, her pupils directed at anything but Catra, "I keep making things worse for you. This is for the best."

"No, Adora, you can't just decide-"

"I'm sorry ," Adora choked up, her throat raw , "I can't do this anymore. I have to go."

Catra stared at her phone after Adora hung up, waiting for the blonde's face to magically reappear on the screen and to make her feel better, as if their entire conversation hadn't even happened. She dialled Adora's number, then again - eight times total - and she was sent to voicemail every time with no chance of convincing Adora to change her mind, just like she would be for weeks after .

What the fuck just happened?

She howled, throwing her phone on the floor and bringing her knees to her chest on the sofa, desperate to block out the sight of the studio around her. Every inch of the place had Adora stamped all over it. Catra knew that for as long as she stayed there, she'd constantly relive how everything had broken like glass around her, carving into her soul and needling her piece by piece. Catra couldn't comprehend how they'd gotten from A to B, how Adora could take her love and reject her in the same instance, all under the guise of the greater good.

She pressed the heels of her hands into her eye sockets, scraping her fingernails over and over her hairline until she got so rough that a tell-tale whistle rang through her ears. She pulled the hearing aids out of her ears, turning them in her fingers as they screamed shrilly. Catra imagined her heartbreak wailed through their plastic tubing, crashing painfully into the air.

Maybe they really could be a part of me - working with me, not against.

Her breath shuddered and she blinked through the heavy ache that was quickly spreading from her scalp down to her jaw . Yet instead of putting her hearing aids away, Catra jammed them back in, her frenzied inhales magnified as artificial sound returned. Without

Adora, she only had herself to challenge;continuing to fight against her disability was as good as fighting herself.

Catra made a promise to herself then and there: she'd never let her hearing loss - or anyone else's perception of it - take life out of her control again.

Chapter End Notes

Writing this was really rewarding (if not at times a little mind-twisting), and I really hope it resonated with you!I know there were lots of guesses about how Catra's hearing loss occurred, and in the end I decided to stick with the cause I know best - my own!And on the subject of the other big reveal... Did Adora and Catra's break-up surprise you the way it happened?

From now on, we'll be back in the current day, with a much-needed deep dive into Adora's brain coming right up...

Thanks so much for reading x

Chapter 14

Chapter Notes

> Thanks so much for waiting for this update - the last chapter took it out of me a little so I needed a bit of brainspace!Given I had an unexpected day off work due to the Queen's funeral, this has at least been written sooner than I expected.
>
> I'm excited now that we are coming back to the 'present day' and we will start to see how these messy exes' lives unfold. Things are certainly about to get complicated!As always, hearing your thoughts in the comments is so deeply appreciated - knowing what you think makes me so happy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It'd been four days since Adora had woken with a pounding headache and a memory too muddled to trust, and she still couldn't shake the nerves sloshing in her gut. She groaned into her palm, unsure whether she wanted the ghost of Catra's forehead against her own to have been real or not. Adora was sure that something had happened - Catra had texted her too many times for there not to be - yet a part of her was adamant she'd rather not know;she almost wished she had zero recollection of the night at all.

Today, though, she'd have to confront it all. Catra was on her way over, and Adora was keenly aware that she did remember confessing her guiltiest secret of all:

"I wish I'd never let you go."

She told herself that it didn't matter - Catra had Eve, and she was only coming over to see Raz.Adora re-read the messages Catra had sent her, scrambling for some deeper meaning hidden behind the stark black and white characters. But there was nothing she could really hang her hat on;Catra had only really given away that

she wanted to help Raz. She had read that music could help Alzheimer's patients, and she wanted to bring over old CDs of Raz's favourite albums that she'd borrowed years ago and never returned. Adora hadn't wanted to tell Catra that Raz was probably way past music therapy. Despite every ounce of logic in her body, she'd wanted to see her again too much.

Her phone buzzed furiously right as the doorbell rang: time was up. Catra had texted Adora that she was outside the house. Adora rushed to the hallway, smoothing her t-shirt before she opened the front door. As soon as she caught sight of Catra on the doorstep, fidgeting in an oversized shirt and black bike shorts, she could feel that the energy between them was charged. For the first time in weeks, Adora was grateful that Huntara was on her day off. The last thing she needed was an audience.

"Hey," Adora winced at how tense she sounded, cursing herself for being so bad at faking ease, "I got your text."

Catra nodded, dipping her head a little nervously as she moved towards Adora for an awkward greeting hug, like they were nothing more than distant school friends who hadn't seen each other since the last reunion, "Force of habit, I can't always tell if the doorbell's worked, so I…"

"No worries," Adora still wasn't sure how to react when Catra brought up her hearing loss so casually and openly, "It's nice to know it's definitely you and not some random salesperson."

Catra kicked her trainers off and swung her bag from her shoulders as she followed Adora into the kitchen; Adora could sense her every movement in the space even without looking, her mind flooding with memories of younger versions of her ex busying themselves around her, joking with her grandmother and wrapping her arms around Adora's waist from behind. Adora couldn't stop her mind from running away from her even further, imagining what might have taken place in this house if she hadn't made the same mistakes; if she'd clung onto Catra as closely as she always wished. She cleared

her throat as she put the kettle on to boil - there was no way of rewriting history.

No way of stamping out the old thoughts that she wasn't *right* for Catra, or good enough.

No way of taking back the painful emptiness that had swallowed her for years, all because she knew she'd make everything worse for Catra if she stayed.

No way of pressing the call button she'd hovered over a million times, her heart pounding in her chest.

No way to reverse how she'd honed herself into nothing but a weapon in the water - the burn in her muscles straining to supercede the constant ache in her chest - only for everything to come crashing down anyway.

Adora looked back at Catra standing in her kitchen, the living proof that regret had never ceased to be her closest friend and confidante. She could figure out more of what had happened between them after Scorpia's party from the nervous hunch of Catra's shoulders and the way she avoided Adora's eye contact;guilt always had looked the same on her. It gave Adora an odd sense of security, knowing that if something had happened, it wasn't driving Catra away - rather , to the contrary. Yet the worry that it was her who had crossed the line in her unexpected drunkenness was increasing by the second. Was it possible that she could have harmed Catra, or her relationship with Eve without even remembering it? If Adora ever needed a reason to avoid alcohol again she had one - the despair she'd ignored building in her gut burst before her.

What the fuck did I do?

The kettle's lever popped right as the thought came to her and she looked at Catra in horror. Catra stared back at her in confusion, shifting on the balls of her feet with uncertainty.

"You okay?"

"Don't you care?" Catra frowned in response but Adora pressed on, undeterred by the shake of her own voice, "That I told you I regretted it?"

Catra's eyes widened and she stepped forward, pinning her arms to her sides as if she could hardly retrain herself from reaching out.

"Of course!" Her gaze fell, "If things were different, we might have actually"…

Adora's heart jumped when Catra's voice tailed off. She knew her instinct had been right - something *had* happened between them, and this was possibly the only opening she had to find out the truth.

"We might have what?"

"Dora"…

Everything in Catra's tone, combined with her shrinking stance, told Adora to back off. Still, she was too close now to stop.

"Catra, will you just be honest with me? Please, I've been trying to remember that night properly and it's killing me not knowing for sure."

Catra grimaced but Adora knew immediately she'd cave, "We very nearly kissed. But you were too drunk, it wouldn't have been right."

"And Eve."

"Yeah," Catra gulped guiltily, "Eve."

Silence filled the kitchen as Adora turned away from Catra's admission, steeping two tea bags in matching mugs. She waited for guilt to flood her veins, yet all she could feel was the buzz of Catra's proximity flowing through her. Every moment they'd spent together in their former lives seemed to flash in her mind at the same time;

Adora could imagine that they might have still ended up in this same kitchen, drinking the same tea under very different circumstances, if she had made other choices in the past. There were a million questions she wanted to ask and a thousand explanations she had to give. But, just like Catra had said, things were different. The world had moved six years down the line even if she hadn't, and Adora wasn't sure if Catra had given her a window to excavate their history properly.

All she could think to do was gesture towards the kitchen table and set the tea down carefully. She didn't dare reveal how many times she'd nearly called Catra and begged her to take her back in those first awful months in Salineas, ready to throw everything away for a chance at reconciliation. She glanced up at her ex as she sipped her tea, her gut turning. Catra's words repeated in her mind.

"If things were different…"

Was Catra trying to tell her something? Would she still want Adora if it weren't for the realities of the lives they led? Adora could barely keep up with the small talk Catra was making; it was a miracle she lasted so long before blurting out the question dominating her thoughts.

"Why did you come over? Really?"

Catra seemed to startle at Adora's query before she fumbled in her rucksack, clumsily retrieving the CDs she'd mentioned in her texts. She responded warily, her speech paced slowly, "I thought I could pop round a couple of times a week to play these to Raz, it might help."

"There's no helping it, Cat," Adora sighed, bitter that Catra's answer hadn't been what she truly wanted to hear, "She's too far gone."

Adora felt crappy imagining the pity that was sure to be rising in Catra - she knew better than anyone else that Raz was all Adora had left. She loved her friends deeply, yet Adora couldn't pretend

otherwise: without Mara or Raz (dare she say it, *without Catra*), she had no family at all.

"Even so," Catra eventually ventured, coaxing Adora to finally look at her, "She might enjoy it. That's better than nothing, right?"

Adora managed to force a small smile - it was hard to disagree, and she found that she didn't want to push back. Maybe having a safe excuse to rebuild their friendship would start to sate the hole in Adora's heart as well as keeping them both in the clear. Nevertheless, Adora couldn't put her finger on what the real benefit was to her ex.

The last thing she should want to do is this.

"It would be nice, if you're sure," Adora spoke softly after a long pause, "As long as it's not too upsetting for you?"

"Some things are worth a little upset."

It had been more than six weeks and Adora had gotten used to hearing music drift down the stairs from Raz's room when she got home from work. Catra had originally started coming over a couple of evenings a week, but it had soon morphed into nearly every night. Adora had even given her a spare set of keys so she could come and go as she pleased.

It's not like she didn't practically grow up here, anyway. It's basically her home too.

Adora tried not to think about what it would look like from the outside if anyone who knew their past found out Catra was visiting so frequently - she found herself not mentioning their new routine to

Bow or Glimmer, and the only reason she'd given Perfuma for not needing her help anymore was that Huntara gave her enough time to herself. Adora told herself it wasn't exactly a lie;it wasn't like anything was actually happening between her and Catra anyway. That was clear enough whenever Catra cancelled for a date night, or mentioned her plans with Eve at the weekend.

She sighed as she closed the front door gently behind her, listening out for the telltale sound of Etta James or Ben E. King. It had been a long day, starting at six in the morning assisting Mermista at swim team training before a double shift at the bistro. Adora almost looked forward to settling in the armchair in the corner of Raz's room and watching Catra with her grandmother. Finally being able to relax, her heart tingling with the hope that Razmight call her by her real name if she was having a good day, had unexpectedly come to be the favourite part of her day. Sometimes she even let herself temporarily sink into the fantasy that Catra belonged in her home, that they were real partners in managing Raz's illness;Adora knew that she could never admit to anyone that her imagination often went further - that the version of Catra in her head could even play the role of wife, or mother of her children.

Today, though, Adora couldn't hear anything. It put her on alert; usually, Catra would let her know if there was a change in plans, or she would no longer be able to stay with Raz

"Catra?" Adora's voice shook as she climbed the stairs and saw the door to Raz's room closed, her heartbeat throbbing in her throat, "Are you here?"

"Adora!"

She spun on her heels to find Catra sitting in her bedroom instead, perched in front of the old keyboard she'd been stuck with in the months they holed up following Mara's death.

"You look exhausted."

Adora nodded and dropped onto the edge of her bed, turning to face Catra once she'd eased her hair out of its tight ponytail, a sigh unfurling from her lips. She wished she was surprised by Catra's presence in her bedroom - but all she felt was a neutral blankness, her body overtaken by fatigue.

"What are you doing in here, Cat?"

Catra tipped her head towards Raz's room down the corridor, "She's sleeping."

That hadn't answered Adora's question. She raised her eyebrow at Catra, gesturing lazily towards the keyboard. Catra bit her lip, her fingers gripping the edge of the instrument. Adora noticed the sheet music Catra had found too - the compositions she'd left at Raz's place all those years ago, that she'd always refused to share with anyone.

"Do you play again now?" Adora asked, desperate to sidestep any questions coming in her direction.

Catra looked away then, almost like she was ashamed, "No. I kinda thought I would at some point, but I doubt I'd even be good anymore."

"It might take some practice, but I'm sure you would. Talent like yours doesn't just disappear."

Adora wondered if she'd said the wrong thing. They'd avoided conversations like this the entire time Catra had been coming over to visit Raz, and she couldn't shake the feeling that she was wobbling too wildly on a tightrope.

"Maybe," Catra paused before she launched into the one question Adora naively hoped to avoid, "Why do you still have all this?"

Her eyes flitted between Adora, the sheet music and the keyboard. Adora cleared her throat. She hadn't thought they'd ever have this

conversation and she certainly hadn't prepared for it. Adora knew that telling the truth might not help either of them, but she was tired of holding herself at arm's length. She'd waited years to be able to open up to Catra, had presumed she'd never have a chance like this again. Diving in headfirst was all she'd been trained to do, anyway, wasn't it?

"I learned to play your songs. It was the only way I could feel close to you when I was in Salineas. Losing you was too much without it."

"You didn't lose me, Adora," Catra stiffened, her mood shifting, "You left me."

They stared at each other for a long moment before Catra turned away and pressed her thumb to the middle C key, playing a silent scale with her right hand on the unplugged keys. Adora sniffed, shucking her jacket off and unbuttoning her shirt so she was left in her vest and black trousers. She sat next to Catra on the piano bench, forcing her to scooch down.

"What are you doing?"

"If I play it for you, will you sing?"

"What?" Catra looked horrified as she read the sheet music, "This song? I haven't sung it since before Dryl."

"Please. I've wanted to hear you sing for so long, even if it's just one last time."

"Okay," Catra whispered after a pause, "Just once."

Adora's fingers trembled a little bit as she flicked the mains and turned the keyboard on, readying herself to play Catra's song.

"You don't need the sheet music?"

"No, I... I used to play it a lot."

“Oh. Okay .”

Adora began to play, her breath catching as she waited for Catra’s voice to accompany the music.











Adora could feel Catra’s eyes on her as her voice began to grow a little more in confidence, the same crystal tone she’d loved all those years ago ringing out in her bedroom like no time had passed at all.







Catra’s right hand shook a little as she brought it to the keyboard, a second melody adding to the one Adora played.









They didnt make it much further before Adora turned her face towards Catra, finding her ex’s eyes boring right into hers, their faces barely inches apart.

"You're not that bad," Catra spoke lowly, as if her words might shatter the air between them if she was too loud, "Nothing on the old me, obviously, but-"

"You're beautiful," Adora blurted out, "The song, I mean. Your voice is still beautiful."

Before Adora even knew what was happening, Catra had surged forwards, their lips meeting with fervour. She brought her hand to Catra's nape, her body acting on muscle memory and instinct, inhaling deeply enough to take her back in time. They could have been sixteen, twenty or forty-five;to Adora, it seemed like they were suspended in time - all that mattered was the press of Catra's tissue-soft lips on hers and how her fingertips grazed Adora's undercut.

"I never stopped loving you," Adora wasn't sure whether she was showing or telling Catra in the heat of it, "All I've ever wanted is to turn back time."

"God, Dora, I've waited so long for you to-"

A sob caught in Catra's throat suddenly as she cut herself off, freezing in Adora's arms in a split second. Adora's body cooled instantly as Catra scrambled away frantically, her hands flying to her forehead.

"Fuck," Catra could barely look at Adora, "What are we doing?"

Adora stood and attempted to reach out to Catra, her heart sinking in her gut when the brunette stepped away, "I'm sorry, this is all my fault. I shouldn't have agreed to everything with Raz."

"It's *not* all your fault-"

"If I hadn't been stupid enough to go to Salineas, we wouldn't even be in this situation! We could have done so much together, but I-"

“Adora! For fuck’s sake, will you stop making out like you’re in control of everything? I do have some bloody agency, you know. *Im* the one with a girlfriend, and *Im* the one who just fucked up. It has nothing to do with you.”

“Nothing to do with me?” Adora was incredulous.

Catra inhaled deeply, her eyes clamped shut, “Look. We just don’t know how things might have worked out between us and we can’t change anything anyway.” She looked Adora up and down, her expression pained, “I better leave.”

Adora watched as Catra gathered her things and left, her skin stinging with the loss of her. She slumped back on the piano stool, the black and white keys distorting as her vision was overtaken by tears, the first falling from her face the same second the front door slammed behind her ex downstairs.

There was nothing Adora could do but wipe her eyes and get on with the evening; there were too many chores to do before Huntara arrived in the morning, and she had hardly eaten since breakfast. She busied herself for a few hours, trying not to berate herself mentally for how the evening had gone. She’d only just collapsed on the sofa in her pyjamas, her bra flung off and hair scraped sloppily into a ponytail, when the doorbell rang. Adora pushed herself up wearily, wondering what she could do to fob off whoever had come and how she could stop the evening from getting even more laborious.

She wrenched the door open, her arm resting against the pane in tired resignation. Yet as soon as Adora saw who was at the door, she straightened up immediately. Goosebumps rose all over her body when the visitor spoke - Adora could tell this was a moment she’d come to remember.

“We need to talk.”

Chapter End Notes

Is this what you expected from the first chapter back in the current day with older (maybe wiser, maybe not) Catradora? And who do you think is at the door? Let me know what you think :)

Chapter 15

Chapter Notes

Hi friends!Sunday night is the start of Rosh Hashanah / the ewish New Y ear (we're going into the year 5783) so I thought I'd post this ahead of the endless hours of cooking and cleaning I have to start tomorrow!

I hope you enjoy this chapter ... it's more of a mental deep dive but the plot is gonna *t h i c k e n *from here!

Kudos and comments make me happy x

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra wriggled in her seat on the bus home, her left knee jggling incessantly. Her brain whirred at a hundred miles an hour despite every attempt to still her mind and body - it was exhausting trying to keep up with herself. The roar of traffic through the open bus window carved into her too - but Catra was relieved that she could do something about that. She searched her bag for her hearing aid case, pulling the aids out of her ears and snapping them inside. Tension unfurled from her muscles in an instant as the world dimmed to a dull, distant growl.

Peace and quiet, finally .

Still, she should have known that dialling down the volume would only grant her relief temporarily;within minutes, her brain teemed with memories of Adora and how her skin seemed to sing when she'd recklessly kissed her ex less than an hour ago. Guilt washed over her as she thought of Eve. Her girlfriend doted on her, was practically perfect on paper.and yet, maddeningly , the thought of her couldnt compete with her first love at all.

There was no way around it. However much Adora played on her mind and no matter how good it had been to spend time with Raz and her music, Catra knew she now *had* to find a way to keep her distance.

She opened up the blonde's contact on her phone, typing and retyping a million messages about how they'd both benefit for much needed space. But her thumb trembled every time she went to press send and Catra thought she might nearly be sick. She jammed her fingers into the 'stop' button on the pole by her seat and scrambled down the bus stairs as fast as she could, half flying into the streets as soon as the back doors opened. Catra stumbled to the bus stop and stared at the route maps, determined to focus on something - anything - that got her back to normal and away from the clusterfuck of a mental maze she'd tangled herself in. After a few moments of forced calm, she sighed, turning around and slumping onto the shallow plastic seating so she could work out where on the route she'd gotten off.

Fabulous.

The universe was absolutely fucking with her. Where else had she ended up but on the edge of the BMU campus, minutes away from the student union bar where she used to perform (and where Adora had reignited the start of them)?

Too fucking typical.

Catra groaned, her head in her hands. The bus connecting Adora's part of the East End to her Central Bright Moon apartment only came once every forty minutes, and Catra would be damned if she was gonna wait around in this mood. Before she knew it, she'd started wandering around her old haunts, pushing open the door of the SU bar where she once performed weekly. It still smelled the same, wafts of spilled beer over the wooden bar and cheap, greasy plates of chips scattered among huddles of students. Catra climbed onto a stool by the entrance, her black leather jacket squeaking as she bent her elbows to rest them on the hightop in front of her. Right under the

speakers, the set up was perfect: without her hearing aids, she could hear every melody (even if she'd have to fill in the lyrics she knew herself) and there was way less background noise clouding the sound. Catra could let the music fill her up meaninglessly, just existing for the enjoyment of it rather than being a reminder of could-have-beens or lost dreams. After so many years, she was grateful at least for that.

It came as a surprise when a song she hadn't expected to hear began to play over the speakers - really, she should have known the world wasn't done screwing with her - and it took her all the way back.

[illegible]

[illegible]

Catra could see the room in a totally different light for those short moments, remembering how it had felt to hear her own voice ring out throughout the SU bar, knowing how she could entrance everyone with the nakedness of her skill, the entire room in the palm of her hand. *Adora* in the palm of her hand.

[illegible]

[illegible]

What she'd lost suddenly descended on her more heavily than it had in months. She barely ever sang anymore, at least not in front of anyone else, frustrated that she couldn't hear the same crystal clarity in her tone that she missed. It was one of the main reasons Catra had hated going to the few hard of hearing and Deaf events that Scorpia had managed to convince her to attend when Adora first left: Catra hated how little she genuinely believed - unlike others she met there - that living could be just as rich without the full natural brilliance of sound. Her inability to come to terms with it made her feel like an ableist, perfectionist fraud. How was Catra supposed to

build relationships with her peers when deep down, she couldn't even convince *herself* that their lives weren't somehow lesser?

Nothing had made her feel wholly complete since she'd woken in that scratchy Dryl hospital bed. At least, nothing had until she'd seen her own sheet music spread out in Adora's room that afternoon. Catra had always assumed that recovering her old compositions would have the opposite effect, but she hadn't felt the grief she'd anticipated at all. It had almost been like relief flooded her body as her vocal chords opened up, like she'd somehow reconnected to a version of herself that she'd long ignored out of nervousness and fear.

fi

Ti*n*

Catra was desperate not to think about what it meant that she'd finally sung in company for the first time, and that it had been for Adora. Beyond how shocked she was by her own willingness to sing when Adora had asked, it almost made her angry. She had a perfect, happy life with Eve, and all Adora had left her with was fury and pain. Yet strangely, Catra couldn't really feel any of that anymore. Her heart still raced a little when she thought of Adora, but her resentment had twisted into excitement, like none of it had ever happened. Or worse, it was as if the chains shackling them together had strengthened, their wi**z**ened, rusted metal preserving an inexplicable bond. Perhaps it wouldn't make sense to anyone else, but the more time she spent at Adora's house, the more her rage and frustration faded - and even if it was stupid, she wanted to love Adora so much more than she wanted to hate her.

It was no wonder she'd finally crumbled when Adora gave the compliment she'd never expected to hear again: " *Your voice is still beautiful."*

Catra cringed at how fast she'd given into her base desires then, no more composed than a reckless teenager. How had she ever

thought she could really fly this close to the sun without risking the wax dripping from her wings?

fly

Then

Perfuma had tried warning her, even that very day. They'd both been shocked to see each other in Adora's house: Catra, having used her key to visit Adora's grandmother like any other day;Perfuma, already in Raz's bedroom without prior notice, having offered to relieve Huntara of her duties a little early. Catra had bristled at the suspicion Perfuma had cast over her, questioning why she was spending time with Razafter so many years of estrangement and when seeing Adora could trigger such destructive behaviours. It had taken no time at all for Catra to snap in return, cursing Perfuma for suggesting that her past with Adora negated the fact that Razhad practically raised her too. After all, what did Perfuma know about her shitty childhood besides the piecemeal facts she'd gleaned from Scorpia? Wouldn't anyone want to cling onto the rare few dregs of nostalgia that they could reclaim - even in the worst of circumstances?

She still didn't regret telling Perfuma how easy it was for her to be accusative when she had no idea what it was like for her and Adora growing up. Nor did she really care about the pained tightness on Perfuma's face after Catra revealed that she was totally estranged from her own toxic mother, and that helping Adora out had nothing to do with whatever paranoid conspiracies Perfuma had invented in her mind.

"It has nothing to do with Adora," Catra had hardly contained her vitriol in the thick of it, her final words chasing Perfuma out of Raz's bedroom, *"Just because you think so little of me doesn't mean I'd actually cheat."*

Catra laughed, partly out of bitterness and partly in disbelief. She'd made herself a liar and a hypocrite pretty quickly in the end.

Nevertheless, the truth of the matter was that Catra couldnt reconcile the fledgling friendship she and Adora had forged with any notion of destructive, harmful behaviour. She certainly couldnt associate the time shed spent listening to old records at Raż s bedside with anything lewd at all.

Sh

Th

It dawned on Catra that even if the claims of innocence shed made to Perfuma were still true, shed already lied enough to Eve for plausible deniability to be totally thrown out the window. Even without an affair, Catra had fabricated late nights at work and encouraged Eve to hang out with friends or go to gym instead of coming home for dinner. How could Catra think she had the power to redefine the boundaries of betrayal?

It wasnt until Catra finally got back to her and Eve' s flat that she realised the problem: Catra didnt feel that ashamed of herself, at least not as much as she felt she should. Against all rhyme and reason, there was no way to deny it any longer - if it werent for Eve, thered be nothing left to stop her from running headfirst into the arms of her first love.

The realisation was devastating. Catra's chest heaved as she perched on the edge of their bed, her panic swelling until her head pounded with sore over-exhaustion. A familiar deep ache settled behind her brow, underlining Catra's shortcomings all over again. She wanted so badly to cry, and scream, and rage - anything that would make the stupidity of the situation shed found herself in feel a little less bad - but Catra knew any of those things would only make her tension headache worse. The only saving grace was that Eve wasnt home to soothe her;concealing her conundrum would be sickening in this state.

Fck me.

A search of the bathroom, her bedside table and her rucksack didn't proffer any of her migraine meds. Catra spotted Eve's denim jacket on the coat hook - it was worth a look just in case, surely? She dug her hand into Eve's pocket, feeling around for the spare pills that her girlfriend often carried around as a back up. Yet Catra's fingers seized around something entirely different: a small, velvety cube, metal hinges cutting into its thickened seam. Her eyes widened as she brought the box into the light.

She can't… she doesn't possibly think we're ready for this? Can she?

Catra prised it open, her mouth gaping as she stared at the engagement ring secured inside. It was far more decorative than anything she could imagine Eve picking for her, but she'd been wrong enough thinking that marriage wasn't on the cards for them. Who was Catra to say that Eve's taste in romantic jewellery wasn't as expected given her own behaviour was totally removed from what her partner could have ever anticipated of her?

Catra almost retched, running to the bathroom with the ring box still in hand. She set it by the side of the sink, shivering as she clamped her hands on its ceramic edges. She hardly recognised the reflection of herself trembling in the mirror: red rimmed eyes; hair frizzed out around her shoulders; gold necklaces hung around her neck askew.

I can't be here.

It was an out of body experience. Catra tore through the flat to find Melog, scooping him shakily into his carrier bag and throwing lick-e-lick sticks into her handbag with the ring box. She didn't have the patience to figure out clothes. She'd borrow some from whoever she crashed with, or buy new ones if she had to. All Catra knew was that there wasn't enough space to breathe where she was, and processing everything that had happened that day in the flat she shared with Eve would be downright impossible.

She was still acting on autopilot when she ordered the Uber and hurled herself into it with Melog, her fingers inching through the top flap of his carrier bag to stroke the back of his head and ears for comfort. Catra felt like she was in a trance, her paralysis only broken when she found herself back on Adora's street. Yet as soon as she reached out for the car door handle, Catra noticed that someone else had beaten her to Adora's front door. When Adora appeared, she didn't look happy about it at all - it was clear she'd been completely taken aback.

What the hell is Scorpia doing here?

Catra's heart sunk yet again when she realised that there was no way Scorpia's visit didn't have something to do with her. Even though she couldn't see Scorpia's expression - and there was no way she'd hear anything from her distance anyway - she knew Perfuma must have said something.

Of course, she's playing the overprotective mama bear role…

It was fucking typical of Scorpia to bust in, with Perfuma's encouragement or otherwise. Catra could understand it to an extent: Scorpia had had a front row seat to Catra's misery ever since they were teenagers;even after Catra had confessed she didn't reciprocate her friend's crush, Scorpia had never let Catra suffer alone. As she peered down the driveway, Catra was fast realising that even if it weren't for Perfuma's long-held friendship with Eve, there was no way that Scorpia would be fully supportive of Adora's return to Catra's orbit. She had half a mind to storm ahead and scold her friend, demanding that Scorpia butt out of her relationships. But when the driver asked Catra if she was actually planning on getting out, she knew straight away that escaping to Raz and Adora's house was a stupid plan. She wasn't a kid now, and she wasn't seeking refuge from her mother anymore.

Catra played with the ring box in her hand and told the driver to take her home. She knew that if she really did want to blow her entire life up, walking right into whatever collateral damage Scorpia was

currently causing would be the worst start possible. As if he could read her mind, Melog miaowed his assent.

"Running away isn't going to help anything, is it Melog?" Catra murmured under breath, hopeful that the driver couldn't hear her, "We're gonna have to figure this all out another way."

By the time the two of them made it home, Catra had only just let Melog out of his carrier and hurriedly slipped the ring box back into Eve's jacket pocket when her girlfriend slipped through the front door.

"Hey," Catra could barely make eye contact with the blonde as she was pulled into her embrace, a kiss pressed to her forehead, "You have no idea how much I want to collapse on the sofa with you tonight."

"Long day at work?" Catra responded timidly, unsure of how to conduct herself.

"Yeah, it's been so hectic," Eve started, before she noticed the chill on Catra's skin, "Hey, everything alright? You're pretty cold."

"Eh, I walked part of the way home from work. I had a headache and ran out of meds."

Eve frowned, dumping her laptop bag on the sofa.

"What?" Catra asked her, knowing exactly where the disgruntled expression on Eve's face was probably headed, "It's not a big deal-"

"Are they being shitty at work again about your adjustments? I know you hate talking about it, but you've been kind of off for a few weeks now, and the last time you were like this, they had you doing all those external Zoom calls-"

Off for weeks? Catra's pulse jolted with worry. *Have I been that obvious for that long?*

"No, work' s been fine-"

"Because, you know , Catra, it's their responsibility to make sure they're not giving you unnecessary stuf f to do thatll wear you out. You dont want to start getting those weekly migraines again."

"Eve. Listen to me," Catra reached over and squeezed her hand, a silent beg to stop, "W ork's fine. I just lost track of time tonight, okay? I only just got home."

It was a half-lie that had worked plenty of times before, but this time it sank in Catra's stomach a little heavier. She left Eve on the sofa and followed Melog into the bedroom, sinking to the floor to stroke him.

"This is only going to get worse, isnt it?" Catra remembered the feel of the ring box in her palm, whispering to Melog as the cat clambered onto her lap, "What the actual fuck are we going to do now?"

Chapter End Notes

> The mess is gonna proper kick off now... what do you think is going to happen next? And the Scorpia / Adora convo is coming up - do you have predictions for what kinda turn that is gonna take?
>
> Thanks as always for taking the time to read the angsty randomness that pops into my brain ♡

Chapter 16

Chapter Notes

> Hello!I've never celebrated Halloween, but I suppose you can decide whether this chapter is a trick or a treat!
>
> I'm really excited to post this chapter, though it may have been one of the more difficult, transitional ones to write. So grateful to have you all along on this journey with me... We are somehow nearly at the end!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It took Adora all of five seconds to finally open her mouth in response.

"What are you doing here, Scorpia? It's nearly nine, I've got to be at school first thing tomorrow."

"Like I said," Scorpia set her shoulders, her white hair tousled a little in the wind as she moved, "I think we better clear some things up."

Adora sighed. She was already tired, exhausted by the emotional whiplash of the night so far, and she really wanted to dwell on her miseries alone. Yet it was clear that Scorpia's intent was to demand rather than request, so what choice did she have?

If this night is going to get any more difficult, I may as well get it over with.

Adora stepped aside to let Scorpia into the house, and she couldn't help but feel disparate worlds were colliding in front of her. Sure, Perfuma had invited her to Scorpia's birthday party, and the two of them had been civil enough before she left for Salineas. Still, Adora knew that Scorpia had always been fiercely protective of Catra, and

there was a reason they'd never spoken much outside of group settings.

"Perfuma was here today ," Scorpia's statement jarred Adora out of her thoughts. She hadn't needed to ask Perfuma for any help since Huntara had been hired and Catra had started spending so much time with Raz

"She was? I never heard anything from her ."

Scorpia barely acknowledged Adora's response, continuing with an uncharacteristic air of determination, "Catra turned up. Boy , they had quite the argument, apparently - she went full hog on P for asking what she was doing here."

Adora bit her lip. Catra hadn't said anything about Perfuma when she'd gotten home earlier;surely there was nothing much to argue about - at least, Adora was desperate to convince herself that there wasn't.

"She visits Raz," Adora found herself explaining defensively , though she was well within her rights to make decisions on what was best for her grandmother, "I don't know why you'd have a problem with that. It's nothing to do with me, really."

"Hmm." Scorpia mused, her eyes softening a little, "I'm not really sure that's true, Adora."

They stared at each other, the squeak of Scorpia's trainers on the floorboards suddenly thunderous in the silence.

"We've been ignoring it for way too long, but when it comes to Catra, just about everything has to do with you." Scorpia grimaced, and it's only then that Adora noticed that the other woman seemed just as uncomfortable as she felt herself, "And I don't think you really understand how much of a problem that is."

Adora crossed her arms, determined not to let the anxiety bubbling in her chest erupt in front of the other woman. She was not about to let Scorpia, of all people, best her.

"You probably think I'm overstepping-"

"I think overstepping is your middle name," Adora spoke curtly, and she could tell it was shocking - but the old version of her, who always scrambled to keep everyone happy, was languishing in the final throes of death, "And seeing that none of this is any of your business, I'd rather not get into it."

"Well," Scorpia took a deep breath and Adora knew all hell was about to break loose, "It kinda is. I promised Perfuma that I'd give you the benefit of the doubt, make nice and all that. But you don't know what it was like picking up the pieces back then. You broke Catra and then you didn't even stick around to see it."

"I-I know," Adora could feel herself on the edge of tears out of nowhere; every ounce of guilt she'd hoarded for years threatened to swallow her whole, "I-"

"You don't know. She barely ate, couldn't study, she cut almost everyone off. I slept on the sofa of that damn studio for weeks just to make sure she looked after herself," Scorpia's voice broke a little with emotion and it horrified Adora, "And for what? So you could ghost her, pretend she didn't exist? Forget girlfriend, that's not even what a good friend does."

Adora flinched. Scorpia's words glinted like a polished knife poised above her.

"Stop, please. You don't have to tell me how shitty it was. I know it was fucked up, and I was fucked up, and I've never regretted anything more," Adora hung her head, dropping to perch on the carpeted stairs beside them, her voice quietening, "It's not an excuse, but I really thought leaving would be better for her at the time."

"Why would you think that?"

"Because everything that went wrong was my fault!" Adora could sense the surprise in the way Scorpia's shoulders drew tight, and it fuelled her outburst even more, miserable resignation pouring from her throat, "I convinced Catra to come to Dryl, I wasn't there when she got really sick, and I only made it worse after. Nothing could make up for it, and almost everything I did upset her. It's no wonder really - she lost everything because of me."

Scorpia pursed her lips, scratching the back of her neck nervously.

"You really think she lost her hearing because of you?"

"Well-"

"Because that's kind of a God complex you've got going on there."

"What? What do you mean?"

Scorpia sighed, uncrossing her arms and reaching out for the banister next to Adora, "Look. As far as I heard, Catra didn't tell you she was sick. And you know as well as I do that when she wants to keep something on the down low, it sure as hell ain't getting out."

"You don't think it was my fault?"

"It's no one's fault. Whatever the hell's going on right now, though? If you're looking to take the blame for something, that is absolutely it."

"I told you, there's nothing going on!" The lie tripped off Adora's tongue more easily than she expected, "She just wanted to spend time with Razz before..."

Scorpia nodded, not making Adora say it. The silence hummed between them for a minute before it was broken.

"I get that you don't want to hear this, but we all know you and her can't just exist together. You never have and you never will. But

she’s been in a really good place for the last couple of years, and so has Eve.”

“I want Catra to be happy ,”Adora could feel the stone sinking in her gut - she’d been out of her mind to think that opening her home to Catra could help them to heal. Instead, all she’d done was ready herself for heartbreak again, “I’d do anything for her to have that.”

“Good,”Scorpia shrugged, her lips and brow pulled into a pitying frown, “That’ s all I wanted to know.”

Like clockwork, Catra turned up the very next day;Adora’ s breath seized the minute she heard the click of a key turning in the lock of her front door.

“Adora?”

Catra’s voice rang out tinny and timid - no doubt, she was worried after her texts had gone unanswered that day. Adora hadn’t meant to be so quiet;she just had no idea how she could possibly respond. Now she’d been stripped of any ability to deny how damaging their interactions could be, Adora couldn’t figure out where to go next. It wasn’t until she heard a throat clearing in front of her that she finally snapped out of her thoughts.

“Dor-”

“I’m sorry I didn’t reply , I-”

Catra cut her off, her hand raised in the air, “I know Scorpia came here last night.”

Adora startled at Catra’s sudden confession, “She told you?”

"No," Catra worried her lip and severed their eye contact, "I came back to talk to you but she was already at your door."

"You did?" Adora stood from her seat at the kitchen table, her tea sloshing a little over the rim of her mug as she bumped against the tablecloth, "I thought you were upset with me. Im sorry , I know I crossed a line."

Catra shook her head and, impossibly, it made Adora feel even worse, "Can we go back to normal for a second and pretend it didnt happen? The kiss?"

Adora felt like every cell was ripping in half inside her. In her worst moments, she'd been almost grateful to presume that Catra hated her. Yet now she knew for definite that she'd been accurate in her twisted relief. Being forgotten, intentionally or otherwise, was so much worse.

"I dont know if I can do that, Catra."

Adora witnessed the pained expression on Catra's face morph into nothingness as the brunette swallowed her dismay, pushing it deep below her skin. It was absurd to see her ex in her full duality. She was both a perfect stranger and the person who knew Adora more deeply, more truly than any other. Catra's mouth gaped open then shut a few times, like she couldnt settle on how to respond until what she did say floored Adora.

"I found a ring."

"A *ring*"?

Neither of them had to speak aloud for an exchange to take place; Adora got an answer to the question she couldnt bear to ask directly from the quirk of Catra' s irises.

"Congratulations," Adora could tell her voice was devoid of emotion, flat and unfeeling as she forced a smile onto her face, "You must be

happy."

It hardly took seconds for Catra to crumble.

"I should be," Catra stepped forwards towards her , her hands grasping at empty air when Adora instinctively moved back, "I just… I didn't think things would happen like this."

"Don't worry ," Adora could feel her throat tightening as she spoke, but she was used to being governed by necessary evils by now, "I won't ruin it, or complicate things. I made things hard enough for you already."

Catra sniffled, although her eyes narrowed in suspicion, "What exactly did Scorpia say to you?"

"Oh," Adora bristled uncomfortably , not keen on reliving the previous night's conversation, "She told me some things I probably needed to hear."

"Adora..."

Catra stared her down, the warning tone in her voice making it clear that she had no plans to let the conversation move on.

"It was just a bit of a reality check, okay? She doesn't want you to get into a bad place because of me again. I really am so sorry, Catra. About all of it."

"Fucking Perfuma," Catra seethed, completely overlooking Adora's apology, "I should have known she'd make a fuss out of nothing!"

"Don't be angry at them," Adora ignored Catra's sharp scoff in response, "It's a good thing Scorpia came - I don't want to fuck everything up for you even more than I already have."

Catra closed her eyes, leaning back against the kitchen counter, "Don't you get it?"

“What?”

“I freaked out yesterday . I didn't think it would still feel like that if we kissed,"Adora could see the trembling of Catra’ s eyelids fighting back tears even from a short distance, and all she wanted to do was to close the space between them and hold her, "Honestly , I don't know that I care if we *do* fuck everything up - at least, not enough to regret doing it."

Catra turned away from Adora and braced her palms on the edge of the sink, too fearful to look at her after her confession. Adora approached her slowly, stepping into place beside her and resting her hand on top of Catra’s gently. Catra sniffled at her touch, her shoulders melting down and away from her skull as she spoke, "It's crazy , but I can't stop thinking about you.”

“What about the ring?”

“I don't want it.”

Their fingers interlocked and Adora’s heart raced, every beat of blood roaring in her veins, "Eve seems so perfect though. Aren't you happy with her?”

“She *is* perfect. But she isn't you.”

Catra twisted a little and Adora turned towards her. Catra’s trepidation poured from every inch of her, both their nervousness fizzing between them. Slowly , Adora leaned in towards her until their foreheads met. The scent of her was intoxicating, flooding every sense. The rush of her thoughts whirled in Adora’s skull painfully - yet she knew what offer she had to make. However much it hurt to say it, she couldn't live with herself without doing so.

"If you need to forget me, I'll go back to Salineas. Not yet, but once things are settled here." Adora cleared her throat, giving herself a brief moment to think of the only person who was really still tethering

her to Bright Moon besides her ex, "If you want me to walk away , I will."

Catra's reaction wasn't as Adora expected. She jolted away in shock, her hands gripping Adora's tighter in panic. "No! That's not what I meant, when I asked you to forget it earlier," Catra gulped in turn, the bob of her throat quivering, "I want you, Adora, but we can't start like this. I don't want this to be our story ."

Adora nodded, though she couldn't escape the discomfort sinking into her chest. Neither of them really had control over the narrative, anyway. Their real beginnings had started so long ago, and what was spiralling now between them - even if Adora disregarded the years-long weight of destructive guilt on her shoulders - was already set too far in motion.

"We'll figure it out," Adora spoke with more confidence than she felt as she pushed Catra's hair behind her right ear, letting her palm rest on Catra's jaw for a short, sweet second, "Even if we have to take a breather now. I promise."

"Okay . I'll give you your key back," Catra whispered, her lips almost close enough to taste, "Until we do."

Adora let herself sink into worn leather, stretching her limbs out as she waited for Glimmer and Bow to unpack the takeout they'd brought over. She wasn't sure if she'd ever had anything but a Diet Coke (or, God forbid, a Pepsi) from her friends' favourite place, but she'd finally decided to take the Team Etheria coaches' advice and ease up on herself a little.

"I can't believe you actually said yes to this," Glimmer exclaimed excitedly as she set a frosty metal tumbler in front of Adora on

Ra's hodgepodge cof fee table, "I cant remember the last time we got milkshakes and fries."

"Maybe never ," Adora snorted, a grin spreading across her face, "It' s not like I had much of a choice before."

Glimmer and Bow glanced at one another as they took their seats on the sofa opposite her, their worry apparent. Adora grinned back at them enthusiastically, seizing a hot chip between two fingers in a bid to defuse their concern, "Where' s the mayo?"

"No mayo for you," Bow chuckled, "Y ou're gonna dip that in your shake."

"What?" Adora looked at them both ludicrously , but all her friends did was smirk in return, "This is chocolate!"

"Exactly ," Bow picked up a fry and dunked it ceremoniously into Glimmer's strawberry milkshake, gasping in mock outrage when she stole it from him swiftly, "Go on."

"Alright, I guess."

Adora plunged her chip into the thick chocolate shake and bit into it mindlessly, priming herself to demand mayo and ketchup immediately.

"Fuck," her eyes widened at the clash of hot and cold salty sweetness, "This is actually good?"

"I told you!" Glimmer squealed, "See what swimming cost us? I knew I'd never go pro once I discovered it."

Adora smiled, though it didn't quite reach her eyes. Glimmer spluttered for a second, seemingly realising what thoughts she might have triggered. Only Bow and Glimmer had really known the depth of her emotional trauma. They had gotten her through the move to Salineas, and had always listened patiently when Adora admitted

how much she regretted her decision to leave Catra, and reserved their judgment when she told them about how many women she'd slept with in her frenetic pursuit of someone - *anyone* - who could make her feel the way her first love did.

"Shit, sorry . I wasn't thinking."

Adora shook her head, assuaging her friend's concern. Glimmer's comment didn't pierce her the way it might have done in the past - though that wasn't something she could really admit without opening a far grislier can of worms. In the weeks since Catra had made her feelings and intentions clear, Adora had felt like she'd regained a lightness she'd forgotten she once had. The fog of secrecy still clouded them, but no longer needing to manage or suppress her desire around Catra had born Adora anew. They were meticulously careful - only messaging about Raz, never instigating any physical contact beyond a friendly hug - though Adora didn't need to question Catra's feelings for her. They were clear in the way her eye contact would linger when she said goodbye and in the love songs Catra had started to sing acapella when sitting with Raz

"Hey , Adora?" She snapped to attention when Bow spoke, his head dipping towards the living room entrance, "Huntara' s trying to speak to you."

The world slowed to half speed as Adora turned to the doorway. Huntara had always preferred as little interaction in the day as possible, and only spoke in detail to Adora when she had a significant update to share, or to debrief a couple of times a week. Adora tried to suppress the anxious nausea threatening to consume her, though the expression on the burly woman's face did little to alleviate her fears.

"Huntara? Is everything alright?"

It can't be time yet, surely?

She didnt need to listen properly to know what Raz s carer was saying. However suddenly it had come, she was finally facing the moment that had hung over her since she decided to return home. All the conflicting dread and longing she'd been grappling with hit her full force in mere seconds. Her grandmother’s suffering - though Adora had told herself a million times that the person in the bed upstairs wasn't still really Raz- wouldnt last much longer .

"Y ou want me to get your girl here?"

Adora nodded dumbly back at Huntara, oblivious to Glimmer and Bow’s shocked questioning, and climbed the stairs slowly . She moved smoothly;her feet were impervious to the rumble of tears building behind her sternum. Adora hardly noticed the change in scene when she finally reached Raz s bedside. After weeks of precipitous decline in Raz's ability to speak, the drip of the dwindling IV and the old woman's laboured, shallow breaths were now the only noises left between them. Long made a stranger in her grandmother’s mind, Adora had tried to interpret her rough verbalisations as something meaningful, or even purposeful. Yet she knew better deep down. Her only hope for Razz now was relief.

hhale. Exale. ust take it one breath at a time.

"Dont hang on just for me,"Adora murmured under her breath even though it wouldnt be heard or understood, and despite the fact she'd never believed in a god or a heaven, "Go find Mara. T ell Mum I miss her, please?"

You don’t have to stay. Ill be okay , somehow.

Adora studied her grandmother’s shrunken hand, seemingly even smaller within her own palm. She pored over skin wizened by sunspots and purpling veins, and pockmarks from the alternate IV entry points that had burrowed into blossoming bruises. For a while, it was distraction enough for Adora to fixate on the ghosts of pansies and violets splayed against her fairer unblemished skin. That was far easier than accepting the realisation that, despite the friendships she

was so grateful to hold, the solitude she'd forced on herself for so long was about to tip from being one imposed by choice to one dictated by circumstance.

t'll be alright if you let go. Ipromise.

Adora would have dwelled on it for longer were it not for the distant slam of the front door and familiar gait of heavy boots on the staircase. She clutched at the fingers clasping her shoulder as soon as they appeared, cloaking her from the whispers of concern and confusion she could hear vaguely from elsewhere in the room.

Ilove you.

Soon enough, she felt less alone. And then, there was only quiet.

Chapter End Notes

I'm not typically one for death scenes, so I hope this felt like it did our Razjustice a little. I thought a lot about my own grandmother, who died similarly after a quick decline from dementia several years ago, and how shocking it was to see her change so much within a couple of months after little change for a long time.

I'd love to know what you think will happen next - how Bow and Glimmer will respond to the revelation of Catra turning up, and the insinuation that she and Adora have resumed some kind of relationship without them knowing, and how Scorpia's actions might come to impact Catra's perceptions of Scorpia, Perfuma, and maybe even Eve.

The next chapter will be Raz's funeral, and it's one I've been building up to in my head for about ten chapters!

If you are looking for something to read between updates of this fic, I've been spending a lot of time writing my amnesia AU, pancakes for dinner. I would love for you to check it out :)

Thanks again for bearing with me and reading this fic - I always appreciate hearing your thoughts in the comments ♡ Until next time x

Chapter 17

Chapter Notes

> grateful for your patience - though my only excuse is a little touch of the blues and a lot of time spent cuddling with cats. still, when the world only seems to be going backwards, what else is there to do but write?
>
> anyway, writing this has been a little cathartic, and a little escapist. hopefully it gives you pause to breathe too x

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra inhaled deeply before she opened her eyes, counting the seconds as she summoned air through her nostrils and let it out slowly through parted lips. Her head buzzed with a dull ache as it always did, but she knew she'd soon feel the embers of a snore drift over her shoulder and soothe her soul soon enough. Catra had come to rely on this ritual more in recent weeks than she ever had before: for the first part, it grounded her for the day;for the second, it gave her pause to remember whose bed she found herself in.

This was never the plan.

She'd rehearsed the speech so many times in her head, her tongue tripping soundlessly over apologies and platitudes. Yet ultimately, there was no other way to look at it - for all the bitter accusations and outraged retorts she'd hurled Scorpia and Perfuma' s way, she'd done the lowly thing that everyone else had apparently expected of her in the end.

I never imagined this would ever happen, that I'd ever do something like this.

The first time she'd come home to Eve after confessing her desire to Adora, Catra had been shocked by the ease with which lies rolled off

her tongue, and how her body could meld so instinctively into her girlfriend's embrace despite the nausea sinking in her gut. She'd learned, too, to suppress the giddy smiles that threatened to spread across her face when she got a text from Adora, even though her messages were usually about the most mundane of things. Sometimes, Catra felt like she was cheating on both of them, straining to keep Adora at arm's length while she figured out how to get her affairs in order and end her relationship with Eve. She ran miles in her own head, hyper analysing every moment she spent with both women for evidence of how she had hurt them, hunting fastidiously for the straw that was short enough for her to finally justify burning everything to the ground.

She told herself it would have been easier if Eve spent more time in their shared apartment, if there were more opportunities to find the right moment. But the blonde had started spending her early mornings at the gym more often and seemed to book up every evening and weekend with meet-ups and overnight trips that Catra had little hope of distracting her from. Between the endless emails and meetings, Catra had spent her working days trying to figure out if Eve was doing it all on purpose;if her girlfriend' s absence was just a thankless delaying tactic, expertly designed to keep them apart (or together)?for as long as possible. Y et the one time that Catra had eventually managed to get Eve in front of her for the evening, fatal words primed to strike on the flat of her tongue, fate had intervened.

"*What's going on?*" Eve hadn't even looked at her when she spoke, *"Just spit it out, at, my mum' s gonna ring at six*"

Catra wouldn't forget the impatience in Eve' s stance or the weariness with which she'd tapped the cap of f her beer bottle. She hadn't remembered Eve being so flippant about speaking with her mother before;she had always been so careful not to skate across the invisible wounds that Shadow Weaver had left on Catra, which stung just as strong in her enforced absence. Still, Catra had figured she didn't have much of a leg to stand on when it came to

demanding sensitivity. Instead, she'd cleared her throat, willing the confession to pass her lips.

"*I've been trying to figure out the best way to tell you this, but there isn't really one. So…*" Catra's breath had stalled, her mind suddenly blank at the worst moment, "*Fuck, I-*"

Her whole body had jolted as her phone went off, blaring directly into her hearing aids. Eve had looked at her in question when she startled, only nodding in jaded recognition when Catra fumbled to retrieve her phone from her pocket and reject the call.

"*Sorry. Not sure who that was-*"

She had felt the phone buzz in her palm before her ear drums were shaken the second time, interrupting her again. She'd answered then; gut instinct had overruled all else.

"*Catra?*" The voice on the end of the line had been gruff, and it had taken her a second to place the familiar tone before she realised Raz's carer was speaking, "*Mora asked me to call you.*"

"*She did?*" A shiver had rippled through Catra when the unexpected nature of Huntara's call had dawned on her, "*It's too soon, surely…?*"

Huntara had paused purposefully before she responded, her pace revealing her vast experience of having navigated this conversation, "*The sooner you get here, the better.*"

Shellshocked, Catra had hardly voiced her acknowledgment before hanging up, turning away hurriedly from Eve to grab her jacket.

"*Where are you going?*"

"*It's an emergency, I need the car.*"

"*Shit, is everything alright?*" Eve had put her bottle down on the kitchen counter with a clink. The heaviness with which glass hit wood had punctured Catra's disorientation.

“*A family friend, she’s… I’ll explain later.*”

Catra wasn’t sure how long it had taken her to drive to the East End - she’d travelled the route enough times by bike and bus by then to do it on autopilot. Finding Bow and Glimmer in Adora’s living room, the two of them gawking in disbelief at her presence, had jarred her out of her daze. Still, she hadn’t given them a second’s thought once the door slammed shut behind her; Catra had hurried upstairs two steps at a time until she reached Razz’s bedside, her hand reaching out to grip Adora’s shoulder. All Catra had been able to think of was the memory of Mara’s death, her skin crawling with the fear that Adora could spiral to even greater depths in her renewed loneliness. Yet the blonde had behaved so differently to how Catra remembered she did back then; in the weeks after Razz’s death, she hadn’t made any attempt to conceal her anguish. Rather, every stolen moment Catra had spent with Adora in the immediate aftermath of Razz’s passing had exposed more and more of who she’d become - and Catra had felt like it was impossible to resist the intimacy that had built even faster between them. And unlike Adora, Catra had behaved in the exact same way she had the very first time Adora experienced a devastating loss: she pushed absolutely everything else aside.

Could I ever have stayed away after that?

Every time Eve touched her, Catra could feel her own grief compounding in her chest. It was aeons away from the way Adora so frequently curled into the depths of her body, pushing far past the flimsy boundaries they had initially agreed upon. Tear-stained embraces had fast turned into tender kisses as the hours after Razz’s death stretched into days, and then beyond. Trapped on autopilot between two homes, Catra never knew whether she was coming or going anymore. Her only saving grace was Eve’s apparent lack of awareness of her whereabouts - though Catra sometimes felt unsure if this was down to obliviousness or disinterest. Either way, they’d barely spoken in any depth since Catra had returned home on the night of Razz’s death, muttering that the old family friend she’d visited a few times had finally passed away.

In the moments they tiptoed around each other, Catra wondered what it would be like to throw caution to the wind and finally let go. Adora was painstakingly - almost annoyingly - careful not to put pressure on Catra, but she could see how the shine in her blue eyes would dull a little when Catra left her alone in Raż s ageing house. She dwelled for hours on whether the guilt licking at her insides would ever be tamed, or if she was destined to spend her entire life making up for her transgressions. Her only relief came from the scent of her love on the sheets in the early hours of dawn, and the blurred murmurs that danced across Catra's skin before she hauled herself back into the hearing world.

Iwon't let it stay like this for much longer . t isn't fair on any of us.

Catra rolled over, reaching out for golden strands that slipped over her knuckles like a silky waterfall, their ends tickling her fingertips. She wondered how many times she'd done this before, comparing this flaxen hair to her own thick ringlets. She inched closer, burrowing her face into a bare shoulder and weaving her arm around a muscular torso, refusing to let the weight of her infidelity take this comfort from her. Amidst Catra's exhaustion, these fleeting moments were all that could sustain her before her reality split back into two.

Catra had shut the kitchen door before she got stuck into finishing all her preparations, but she should have known better. She'd had no idea that time had flown that qickly , or that the door had burst open behind her back, until a shrill shriek hit the hairs on her nape and her hearing aids whistled from the unexpected noise as she jumped.

"Shi-, so--y ," Catra' s skin cooled as she recognised Glimmer's frenzed speech right next to her , turning hesitantly to lipread, "Adora said you wouldnt still be here!"

"What? What time is it?"

Catra's heart sank as she read the watch thrust in her face and realised Adora's guests would be arriving any moment. It was her own fault, really - she'd insisted on cooking for Raz s life celebration instead of letting Adora fluster over everything herself. In truth, it probably would have been easier for both of them if she'd given way to Adora's suggestion of hiring Lonnie's bistro chef to cater; but Catra had felt like she'd been so compromised in her ability to be there for Adora outside of the hidden dim of her bedroom that anything else felt wrong.

"Fuck. No-one' s here yet, are they?"

Glimmer shut the door behind them hurriedly and spun back to face her, "It' s just me and Adora but everyone'll be here in five!"

Catra grimaced, her eyes sweeping over her efforts on the kitchen counter. She only had garnishes left to do, yet despite the bounty of foods she had prepared, she couldn't help but feel like she'd let Raz down. Their return to sneaking around and Catra's desperate overcompensation wouldn't have been what she wanted for her granddaughter. It certainly wasn't what Catra wanted for herself.

"It wasn't supposed to be like this," she said, half forgetting Glimmer was even there, "It' s not right."

"Don't be such a perfectionist, it looks great," the other woman responded hurriedly, "Look, if you take of f your apron and freshen up a little, people will just think you're here for the wake. Everyone knows you and Adora grew up together, I doubt it'll seem that weird-"

"Not the food. I should be supporting her properly , not hiding in the kitchen. I was stupid to think it'd make up for it."

"Chill, Catra," Glimmer replied wryly , "I get the impression you've been supporting Adora plenty."

Her eyes immediately narrowed.

Of course, Adora must have told Sparkles everything.

"Don't look so miffed about it, it wasn't hard to figure out after…" Glimmer blinked, her nose twitching in lieu of referencing the day Razz had died, "Anyway, you know what Adora's like, getting anything emotional out of her's like beating water out of a stone."

Catra frowned, taking her apron off gingerly and hanging it on the back of the kitchen door.

"She's been doing better recently, despite everything. I can tell," Glimmer had always taken Catra's silence as permission to carry on talking. Years later, Catra supposed that there was no reason for this day to be any different, "I don't know how long all this has been going on, but it's worth it, right? I never thought Adora stopped loving you."

"She didn't," Catra's mouth got ahead of her in the heat of the moment, even though she'd hardly let herself believe these truths, "And it is."

Glimmer nodded, surprising her when she grasped at Catra's hand.

"Bow and I missed you. Even though you were a dick half the time."

"Takes one to know one, Sparkl-"

"I tried to talk her out of it in Salineas, before she stayed on." Catra was taken aback by Glimmer's unexpected candour and the intensity of her eye contact, "You have to understand, she was so broken-"

"I don't need to hear it, Glimmer," Catra spoke softly, as if too harsh a tone could shatter her vocal chords, "Really. I'm a different person now, and I'm banking on the fact that Adora is too."

"So that's it?" Catra could practically feel the concentration of concern in Glimmer's voice bouncing off her skin, "You're really back

together? Properly?"

Catra's throat squeezed tight, the muscles at the edges of her jaw stretched taut, "Yeah. We are."

She didn't explain how hard it was to disentangle herself from Eve, or from Scorpia and Perfuma's pained expectations. Still, there was relief in saying it to someone outside of her and Adora's bubble. Sweeter than she'd imagined.

"Okay. Wow." Glimmer ran her hand through her hair, pausing at a sudden realisation, "Aren't you with Perfuma's?..."

"Yeah."

"But you're definitely?..."

"Yes. Okay? I'm still figuring out how to sort everything. We've got the flat, and a cat, and Eve's out like 24/7-"

"Not to be annoying, but you're kinda veering into excuse territory there..."

"What? No!" Catra couldn't stop the hiss escaping from her, "You tell me, how easy do you think it is to just go and *break someone's heart*?"

"You coul- tal- to me abou- tha-."

Catra whipped round to find Adora standing nervously at the edge of the room, the kitchen door ajar behind her.

"Adora! How long have you been there?"

"Only a second," Adora glanced at Glimmer purposefully, and she started to make her way out the kitchen, "Let me help you with this, Cat. Please."

Catra didn't have a chance to respond. As soon as Glimmer left the room, the door opened temporarily, a shout barrelled down the short hallway from the opposite direction.

"Open Mic?"

Catra would have recognised that voice and nickname anywhere. She looked up sharply at Mermista, her skin tingling at the reminder of the talent she used to hang her identity on, and froze.

"Catra?"

Eve stood behind Mermista at the front door with Perfuma, their arms filled with floral arrangements. Catra gulped, smoothing her hands over her jeans before she plastered a smile onto her face and approached the newcomers.

"Eve! What are you doing here?"

"Scorpia couldn't swap shifts so Perfuma asked for help bringing the flowers," Eve pursed her lips a little, leaning in to speak with Catra as privately as she could, "I thought you had a thing with an old friend?"

"Not technically untrue." Catra could hear the petulant whine in her own voice, "I helped with the food, that's all. I knew the family growing up."

Catra could tell Eve had more questions to ask, but Mermista butted in right on time.

"Hey, you're the one that Open Mic, like, draped herself over at Scorp's party, right? Would've introduced myself but kinda, like, complicated with Adora there…"

Fuck!

Eve's brow furrowed in confusion but this time Catra's saviour came from an unlikely source.

"Eve is Catra' s partner," Perfuma ushered them all into the living room and Catra was desperate to catch a glimpse of Adora, intent on checking she was alright with the unexpected intrusion of her girlfriend, "And a very good school friend of mine!"

"Cute," Mermista eyed Catra slowly , and all she could do was hope she wasn't somehow putting two and two together considering that Catra and Adora had hardly been seen spending time together in public since university, let alone in one another's homes, "Nice to see you again, anyway"…

"Small world, right?"

"Riiiiightttt." Catra smiled a little as Mermista' s drawl petered out. Out of everyone in Adora's old gang, she'd kind of liked the sarcastic captain-turned-coach most.

Catra took some of the flowers from Eve and gestured where she and Perfuma should put the rest, internally cursing herself when she realised she was revealing how familiar she was with the house.

"Just popping to the loo," Catra spoke to no-one in particular , but she needed an out fast, "Be right back."

She didn't hang around to see anyone' s response, but ducked back into the hallway; she caught sight of Adora fussing over how to lay out all the food with Glimmer.

God, at least she' s occupied.

Catra shut herself in the toilet under the stairs, locking it hastily and pulling on the light switch in the cramped space.

"Calm the fuck down," she spoke to herself sternly , pushing curls behind her ears with trembling fingers, "Nothing' s going to happen. And if it does… Maybe that'll be a good thing. Been waiting for a window"…

She could see from the startled irises and flushed cheeks in the mirror that she hadn't convinced herself whatsoever.

"Shit."

Catra teased water from the faucet through her hair sparingly with her fingertips, squeezing the clumps of curls with her hands gently to refresh the product from her last wash day. It wouldn't help anything, but coiling and resetting frazzled strands into place at least made her feel better prepared. More in control.

Here we go.

It was an unexpected relief to return to the living room and find Eve making small talk with Perfuma, Bow and Mermista. Eve had always been so much less awkward than she was; Catra swore she could find a way to propel conversation with a brick wall.

"I was just suggesting that Eve stays," Perfuma told Catra as she reached their huddle, "Seeing as we didn't make proper introductions at Scorpia's birthday. Besides, Razz always loved bringing people together, didn't she?"

Razz didn't give a shit, Catra thought, though she didn't dare do more than nod back, *She always did her own thing.*

"Greyskull better stick around, anyway," Mermista butted in, clearly undeterred from her train of thought from prior to Catra's reappearance, "I know she's, like, meant to be taking a break from Team Etheria, but after Mara, and…" Mermista nudged her head lightly at Catra, and she could feel herself setting aflame with embarrassed discomfort, "When she's going through it, it's like she doesn't exist out of the pool."

"Greyskull?" Catra's heart seized at Eve's question. Her mind raced for a way to interject. Maybe she could steer them back to Perfuma's conversation if she was fast enough…

"Perfu-"

"Adora. So, you, like, must have heard how it was. Sure, she's one of the country's top swimmers, I guess - like, seriously, I taught her well - but honestly, she seems to looove." Thwarted, Catra felt like the blue-haired woman's snail pace of speech was knocking each nail into her coffin tap by perfectly hammered tap, "coaching the kids."

The heat of Eve's gaze concentrated on Catra, a red laser trained on her face.

"Oh, Adora's coaching? Does she do that on top of her job at Thaymore Bistro?"

"Ugh, Glimmer convinced her to stop with the waitressing a while back. She's with us most the week - It's cool, I guess."

Catra didn't even excuse herself before leaving this time, the potency of Eve's curious expression drilling into her. She slipped between the bodies that were now crammed into Adora's home - *who knew she even had this many friends, or any family apart from Adora* - and scarpered into the hallway, scurrying up the stairs towards the quiet. She found herself in Adora's bedroom before even deciding where to go, her hands grasping at the bedding when she perched on the edge of the mattress. Catra tried to stifle the panic she could feel spreading from her palms up to her shoulders and neck. However much she'd scrambled to find the opportunity to be honest with Eve, the truth was that she never imagined it would unfurl so far outside of her control. She'd been naive, or stupidly delusional perhaps, to think that the worlds of present and past wouldn't collide like this - at least, not before she'd dictated the circumstances under which they could.

"It's her," Catra's head darted up at the voice suddenly booming from the doorway, "isn't it?"

"What?" Catra knew she sounded scared and small.

Eve sucked her teeth, running a hand through her blonde hair as she took in all of the swimming memorabilia in Adora's room. She swept a palm over the keyboard, her eyes closing when she reached the sheet music on the stand. Catra held back her breath - she knew her handwriting was recognisable enough on its own, even if her younger self hadn't marked every page of her compositions with her name.

"Adora's the ex, isn't she?" Eve spoke with soft resignation, like she'd known more about Catra's whereabouts than either of them had been willing to admit, "The swimmer you won't talk about?"

"I *did* tell you."

Catra objected with indignation. She'd given Eve the broad strokes. So what if the nitty gritty ins-and-outs weren't wholly revealed? How much good would it have done either of them to rake over those burning coals?

"Come on, Cat, you hardly told me anything. I didn't know her *name*!" Eve's irritation clawed at Catra's skin, "When are you actually going to start being honest with me?"

"Eve, I"…

Her throat closed up before she could respond. Catra fought to swallow, to form her lips around the practised words that had yet to live aloud. But she took too long - her hesitation was clearly too marked for her partner. Eve seemed to suddenly boil over, her charged energy bursting in the air.

"Christ, do you think I'm a total idiot? I can see your shit all over this place!"

Catra shuddered, her eyes fixating on anywhere but Eve's face. She could see it so clearly in her mind's eye now;the way her trinkets were scattered all over Adora's home, and how her sleep clothes hung over the bed post.

"Eve-"

"Believe you me, you're not the first cheater I've had the pleasure of sleeping with, but, God, you're definitely the most stereotypical-"

"Hi," Catra paled when she saw Adora enter the room, her voice shaky and eyes full of tears, "I'm sorry , but everyone can hear you downstairs. A-and I know this is important but can we do it later? Not in the middle of my g-g-grandma's…"

Adora's voice broke and she pinched the bridge or her nose between two fingers. Eve inhaled deeply, frowning at both of them before she spoke to Catra.

"Right. Let' s finish this at home."

"Y ou should leave." Catra stood, her arms crossed over her chest.

"Are you joking me?" Eve's eyes widened, scanning Catra wildly like she'd lost her mind, "Y ou want to stay here?"

"She' s upset."

"*She' s* upset? That' s seriously your read of the situation? Y ou don't think we've got some important shit to sort through right now?"

"Please," Catra trembled, "W e can talk properly when I get home."

"Unbelievable."

Silence descended on the three of them as Eve held her breath, waiting for a retort or change of mind that never came. She stormed past Adora out of the bedroom, and Catra felt sick. She had no idea how she was supposed to drag herself home to Eve, not to mention how to process the fact that their argument had been overheard by everyone downstairs.

"Y ou didn't have to do that," Adora closed the door behind Eve gently and stepped closer to Catra with trepidation, "I'm fine, really ."

"You're not fine, Adora," Catra reached out for her hand, "None of us are."

She watched Adora gulp, the swell of her throat bobbing a little with emotion, "You don't have to stay though. Everyone's here, and you hate it when-"

"Don't worry about me," she cupped Adora's chin in her other hand, willing the softness of the blonde's skin to calm her frazzled nerves, "Let's just focus on Raz, hmm?"

Adora tilted her forehead in agreement, though Catra could tell they had a mutual understanding that went far deeper. For better or worse, the hardest, most fearsome step of reuniting was suddenly in motion. Adora leaned in, pressing her lips to Catra's gently.

"Thank you. For staying."

It was simpler to make the decision than it was to follow through. Catra saw as soon as they made their way downstairs that Perfuma was also missing, and that hardly anyone would meet her eye contact despite the fact that she and Adora were careful to keep their distance. When she finally found herself in front of her own apartment building, her body straining to keep an exhaustion headache at bay, she knew it was all only about to get worse.

"Thanks for gracing us with your presence," Eve sat sullenly on the sofa when Catra crossed the living room threshold, her palm resting on Melog's grey fur, "Half expected you to skip out altogether and leave me with the cat."

"I wouldn't do that, Eve," Catra sat next to them both, her spine stiff, "You know that."

"Do I?" Eve scoffed when Melog moved away from her to crawl into Catra's lap, "I thought you cared about me, but turns out that's a load of shit."

I *do* care about you!"

"Do you fuck," Eve seethed, "Just stop with the lies and tell me the truth."

"Look, I didn't think this could happen, okay? I never thought I'd still have feelings for her, if I ever ran into her again."

Eve stared at her, and Catra could feel herself wilt under the blonde's steely blue gaze.

"How long?"

"Nothing happened physically until-"

"Catra," Eve gritted her teeth, "When did it start?"

Catra paused. She wasn't sure if there was a clear answer. She could say it was when Razz died, or when she started visiting the dying woman regularly, or even that it went all the way back to her and Eve's anniversary at the Bistro.

Had it ever really ended between us?

"Okay," Catra fidgeted on the sofa, a nerve-fuelled shiver rippling through her shoulders, "You remember Adora got really drunk at Scorp's and I drove her home?"

"Scorpia's birthday? That's like, five, six months ago!" Eve finally looked her in the eye, an unprecedented devastation in her pupils, "I thought you were *it*, Cat. Special. But you've been keeping secrets from me all this time."

"You've kept secrets too!" Catra blurted out defensively, too tired for rationality, "Hiding engagement rings! We never had that conversation, and we promised each other we wouldn't do shit like that - not without talking about it properly!"

"Well you didn't think about having a conversation before you jumped into bed with Michael fucking Phelps, did you?" Eve spat back at her before she deflated, stood opposite Catra, "It isn't for you anyway. I was holding onto it for Fuma."

"Perfuma?"

"She's proposing to Scorp."

"Oh. Wow," Catra murmured, her short-lived hubris gone, "I guess that makes more sense."

"Why do you even care?" Eve's voice rose again, her face contorted in anger and misery, "Do you *want* to be with me? Or marry me?"

Catra looked up and studied the planes of Eve's face, her eyes tracing the pleading slope of her brow and the minute dilation of her nostrils as her breath rose and fell.

"I do want to be with you, Eve. You're one the best things that's ever happened to me. But Adora... I don't think I can be without her..."

She could feel Eve watching her, her incredulity building. The air between them seemed to freeze, until Eve raised an ice pick.

"You want her more than you want me?"

Catra nodded slowly, her eyes downcast. She could hardly bear to look at the woman who had given her so much, "I'm sorry. I feel terrible-"

Eve let out a sob, loud enough to make Melog to jump out of Catra's lap.

"Fuck you, Catra," Eve began to shake, hands trembling as she pointed at her, "I gave you everything! And you... you"...

Eve turned away, her words increasingly unintelligible. The volume of her voice rose, and Catra could tell Eve had crossed a point of no

return. She was raging, and Catra knew she deserved every cursed and bitter word - if only she could tell what they were. Catra's desperation grew wildly alongside Eve's anguish;it felt like she was being pushed aside on purpose, her hearing loss weaponised by the person who knew exactly how to hurt her most.

"Eve, please. I can't lipread."

The blonde ignored her, storming away from Catra and tearing down the hallway as she continued her tirade.

"I can't understand you!" Catra yelled after Eve's back, rushing to keep up with her, "Eve!"

The front door slammed in Catra's face, inches from her nose. Catra stared at it, her breath heaving;she raised her palms to the wood just as her tears began to fall, her shock descending into distraught paralysis. She stepped back from the door, her whole body trembling violently. A slow whine creaked out her chest and she sank to her knees, her sobs wrenching her apart.

Pull yourself together.

There was no way she could stay in the flat and wait for Eve to return. Catra packed in a hurry, finally going through the motions she'd imagined so many times over the past weeks since Raz's death. She was methodical despite her hysteria;her hands moved swiftly of their own volition, disconnected from distress pulsing through her brain. Soon enough, she had packed enough for a few days, and she had Melog ready to go. There was more to be discussed, decisions to be made, better apologies to be given. But nothing productive could happen in the immediate.

We need somewhere to stay.

Everything in Catra's soul was telling her to go back to Adora's home. Yet a part of her knew it wasn't right, to run from the arms of

one love into another's and back. Hadnt that been the very worst part of all of it?

Iwant to start this at my best, not my worst.

When she pulled up Scorpia's number, Catra already knew there was a fifty-fifty chance of getting any kind of response, let alone a positive one. Still, being met by the sound of Scorpia's recorded voicemail message felt more significant than perhaps it should. Only minutes later, when Catra was already looking up hotel rates, her phone rang.

"Scorp?"

"Wildcat," Scorpia's voice was soft, but far qieter than usual. Catra's heart sank a little, figuring out that Eve must already be at her and Perfuma's place, "What happened?"

"I..I cant talk about it right now," Catra's throat bulged sorely at the memory of Eve walking away from her, of the helplessness that overtook her when the ability to communicate was withheld, "Is she with you?"

Scorpia paused. Catra could practically see her bouncing on the balls of her feed uneasily.

"Scorp. Please."

She was met with a sharp intake of breath.

"She's here with Fuma."

"I need somewhere to stay," Catra admitted nervously, already anticipating the likely response.

"I'm sorry, Wildcat. You know how Perfuma felt about all this, and you promised me-"

"Just. Dont, okay?" Catra bit back a fresh wave of tears, "I dont need the I told you so'."

"Wildca-"

Catra hung up before Scorpia could say anything else. She'd suspected it, but it was hard to stomach nevertheless: there was no way Scorpia would choose her over Perfuma; there'd be no unconditional, freely-given sympathy left to rely on. Catra had made her bed, and now she had to lie in it.

Her phone rang, lighting up with Scorpia's call ID - this time it was Catra who rejected the call. Only a minute later , it buzzed again.

"Scorpia, just leave it, okay?" Catra couldnt stop the thin reediness bleeding into her voice, nor the sniffle that she failed to suppress, "I get it, you dont have to explain."

"Catra?" Adora' s concern could be felt as well as heard, "Are you okay?"

She inhaled deeply.

"No."

"Oh," Catra loved Adora even more for the readiness she could sense through artificial sound, "Let me come find you."

Let me love you, Catra heard, and her resolve to spend the night alone nearly crumbled. *Let me make up for all the nights Ididn't hold you.*

All Catra wanted was to listen to Adora. But all Catra knew was that if she could do anything to help herself heal, it was to give herself space.

"Find me tomorrow ," she said, blocking Adora' s objections, "I love you."

Tomorrow would be a new start, Catra decided, clear and gold as honey. Beyond the sting of heartbreak, nothing could possibly taste sweeter.

Chapter End Notes

it was so hard to figure out how to balance Eve and Catra's conversations. one of the reasons i wanted to go ahead with writing this fic was to challenge myself in fleshing out the flaws and the problematic behaviours that even the best people aren't immune to. i didn't have a desire to demonise Eve to justify Catra's actions - but i did want to take a heat of the moment action that can be devastating in its thoughtlessness (and can have an impact far greater than most hearing people would probably perceive... but more on that next time...)

please do let me know what you thought about this chapter - whether it all ended in the way you expected, or if anything took you by surprise!and of course, what you think will happen next! i really cherish all the comments i receive from you gorgeous readers, and it's so wonderful to feel a little more seen in world where a lil disabled, jewish lesbian gal rarely gets to be heard x

we have one more chapter left... wish me luck in figuring out how to wrap this all up nicely!

Chapter 18

Chapter Notes

> I've loved writing this fic for what it explores - grief, loss, infidelity, emotional betrayal, and reformed identity - and I'm glad that it's finally come to (what feels like to me, anyway) natural end. I really hope this final chapter gives you a satisfying end and wraps up this little Catradora/Eve vortex well. I'm so grateful for folks being so patient between updates and delving so openly into the snippets of hearing loss experience I've tried to share.
>
> So, thank you SO MUCH for reading - I've absolutely lived for your kudos and wonderful comments!I would be beyond grateful to hear what you think of the ending.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

FR M HS AFTR

Three hours into a six hour flight, Adora was so bored it felt like her eyes might actually roll into the back of her head.

She attempted to cross one leg over the other, cursing when her knee unexpectedly bashed into the seat in front - *of course* , the guy in front of her had chosen that very second to recline his chair. Adora sighed, pressing her shoulders back against the rigid fabric of her own seat and re-angled her screen so that it didnt point into her lap. She thought it was pointless, really. It wasnt like she had the patience to watch anything on an overnight flight. Served her right, anyway. Team Etheria had offered to fly her to Salineas in business class, but Adora hadnt been able to qash her guilt over her prolonged absence enough to accept. Shed taken far longer than the agreed six months off in the end;sure, no one dared to argue

that it hadn't been important to see Raż s final days through but Adora also knew that she'd taken comfort in buying herself an extra year of escape for free.

That thought clouded her mind when she collapsed onto the cool sofa cushions in her abandoned apartment in the early hours of dawn;she could practically see the particles of dust floating in the streaky sunlight when her body forced air around the space for the first time in over a year. Adora grunted as she stretched and knocked her shoes off, letting them tumble under the coffee table. She could hardly remember a time when she hadn't made such a mess of everything. After a million transgressions, she had no choice now but to face up to all of it.

This jurney was step one.

Although her return was supposed to be about breaking old habits, Adora already found herself sinking into past behaviours. She stood up from the couch promptly and bounced on the balls of her feet;she had so much pent up energy from sitting still for so long on the plane despite her exhaustion. There was nothing else for it. She tore her suitcase open and grabbed her go-bag - *thank God for forward thinking* - and shoved her feet into her proper running shoes. Before she knew it, she was out in the coastal breeze, salty air batting at her cheeks as she jogged. The crash of waves pulling back and forth swept over Adora's skin and eased her thoughts. Unlike Bright Moon, there was no need for music for drown out the hubbub of city traffic and ongoing building works. It calmed Adora enough that she hardly took note of her route, her body slipping seamlessly into autopilot mode.

The familiar smell of chlorine wasn't supposed to smell as sweet as it did, but its draw swallowed any and all anxieties Adora had about returning to the Team Etheria pool complex. The few minutes it took her to get past security and into the changing rooms felt like they lasted hours - time slowed beyond recognition stretching across the final seconds that Adora found herself in air rather than water.

The pool swallowed her quickly and surely when they met one another, Adora's body shooting from diving board to lane like a perfect dart. She was blissfully mindless in her haven, every muscle trained on catching a moving target she'd invented for herself; every length of the pool completed revealed a new goal she was desperate to attain.

It shouldn't have been a surprise when she reached its ceramic edge for the fortieth time and found a pair of blue-bagged feet eclipsing her view.

"We weren't expecting to see you until Monday, Grey," her old coach's voice rang loud and clear over the pant of Adora's heaving breath, "Good to have you home."

Catra wished she didn't feel as nervous as she did. Every sip of her cappuccino sloshed inside her writhing stomach, and she hadn't even attempted to pick at her eggs yet.

"So," she said, wiping a drop of coffee off her bottom lip with cautious fingers, "How's it all going?"

Eve tipped her head back as she downed the rest of her champagne, crumpled petals from her poorly-made flower crown falling into her eyes.

"Yeah, fine. Thanks."

"Good to hear."

They nodded at each other awkwardly, waiting for someone (*anyone)* to interrupt and take control of the conversation. They'd no such luck - everyone else at the celebratory engagement brunch was

excitedly chattering away, hardly paying attention to the two of them at all. Even Scorpia was too focused on the mimosa she was handing to Perfuma at the next table to notice she and Eve had gotten stuck together.

This is what I get for trying to be nice, Catra thought, *if I hadn't agreed to swap seats so Perfuma's cousin could sit with her friend then we wouldn't even be in this position!*

It wasn't lost on Catra that she'd only gotten into this situation because she still felt pressured to ingratiate herself to Perfuma. The awkward coffee meet-ups and group dinners Scorpia had included her in since Raz's funeral hadn't improved Perfuma's frosty attitude towards her much, no matter how many grovelling apologies and remorseful explanations Catra offered. And now - after a whole morning of getting her fingers stuck with rose thorns at the flower sculpting activity everyone had dutifully attended - Catra's genuinely generous intentions risked ruining the tiny progress she'd made.

"Sorry," Catra finally attempted to break the ice after begrudgingly accepting that there was no one left to distract them from one another, "I didn't realise you were at this table until I'd already agreed to switch seats."

"Adora isn't here?" Eve spoke at the exact same time, cutting through her explanation; Catra stuttered at the blunt question, her tongue tripping over the end of her sentence.

"No," she replied curtly once she'd recovered her composure, "She's not."

Eve pressed her lips together and nodded slowly, refilling her champagne glass. "Good to hear it was all worth it, then."

Catra bit back a scoff. However much she wanted to push back, this was Perfuma and Scorpia's engagement party, and she wasn't about to start a scene. Eve paused, seemingly waiting for Catra to rise to it, or maybe even second guessing her own words - Catra wasn't sure

if she could read her ex as well as she used to anymore - but she shrunk away quickly , her eyes dropping from Catra to focus on her plate. The silence staled between them, with little left to be said. Having lost what little appetite she had, Catra watched as Eve took a knife to a slice of sourdough toast and attempted to cut off a piece, her whole arm putting in effort as her wrist moved back and forth laboriously. It was almost inevitable that Eve would lose her grip on the toast right as Catra leaned forward towards her own plate, her elbow driving right into Catra's chest as a lump of avocado flew off her plate into the middle of the table.

"Oh, fuck," Eve turned to Catra hurriedly and rubbed her bicep soothingly, "Sorry , love, I didn't-"

They both froze as the instinctive intimacy of Eve's reaction gave way to reality. Eve let go of Catra's arm just as fast she'd taken it and cleared her throat.

"Force of habit," Eve said gruffly, "Don't take it as an opener ."

"An opener?" Catra winced as she rubbed circles into her sore skin. She could tell the other party guests were watching them and listening in now - she could even sense Perfuma and Scorpia staring in horror out of the corner of her eye.

"Doesn't take much to get you into bed, does it?"

"Eve," Catra hissed, her cheeks flushing red, "How much have you had to drink?"

"What do you care?" Eve bristled at the question, shooting daggers at Catra through narrowed, bloodshot eyes, "Am I wrong?"

Catra chuckled under her breath, pushing her seat back, "Yeah, okay. I'm not doing this."

Catra stood abruptly from her seat and rushed out of the restaurant as quickly as possible - she could send Scorpia and Perfuma her

apologies later, but there was no way she could maintain her composure enough to stay. Even if it weren't for the tears threatening to spill from the itchy corners of her eyes, Catra had no desire to hang around and find out just how much everyone else agreed with Eve. She wasn't stupid - she knew how much the stain of infidelity could follow you in Central Bright Moon's insular lesbian community.

"Wait, Wildcat!" Scorpia's voice rang out behind her, "Hold up!"

Catra inhaled shakily, resetting her posture and face before she turned around to face her friend, "I'm sorry, Scorp. But I can't stay, alright? I don't want to ruin your party too."

"Ruin?" Catra finally looked up at her friend once a reassuring hand settled on her shoulder, "You haven't ruined anything. I just want to check if you're okay. Things have been messy but you really didn't deserve that."

"Really?" Catra frowned when Scorpia pulled her into a gentle hug, slow to reciprocate, "It's my fault Eve's upset. And Perfuma's still not happy with me either."

Catra was almost embarrassed by the pitying expression that cloaked Scorpia's features in response, "I know it wasn't easy for you to come today, especially on your own. But I'm really grateful that you did. I couldn't celebrate getting engaged without you!"

"Yeah?"

Catra squirmed with need, her ears straining to gather more assurances and calm her nerves. It's been weeks since she spoke with Scorpia in any depth, their only communication being short telephone calls and quick logistical messages. A part of her had been surprised to get an invite to the engagement party at all.

"Of course, Wildcat. For better or for worse, right?"

"I think that's for marriage, not friendships-"

“*For better or worse*!” Scorpia asserted, squeezing her hand, “I’ll work on P, she’ll come around with time. She knows how important you are to me.”

“Thanks, Scorpia,” Catra couldn’t stop her tears from falling now, smiling with relief as she wiped them away hastily, “Get back in there, yeah? Enjoy it.”

Catra hugged Scorpia tightly, waiting until she’d disappeared back inside the restaurant before finally making her way home. She took comfort in Melog’s companionship for a while, staring mindlessly at the television stroking the purring cat in her lap. Eventually, she couldn’t still her fingers any longer. Catra reached for her mobile, finally giving into the one thing she promised herself she wouldn’t do.

The line rang three times before her call was picked up, and Catra spoke before she could chicken out.

“Hey, Adora.”

Adora had secretly been convinced she’d be the first one to break, but less than twenty-four hours after Catra called her, she was already waiting in the arrivals hall of Salineas’ busy commuter airport, craning on her tiptoes to see past the crowded stream of visitors streaming past the customs gates.

“I thought we promised not to talk this week,” Adora couldn’t help but smile when Catra finally appeared in front of her, failing to suppress a smug grin from spreading across her face, “What happened to that big work project you wanted to focus on?”

“It’s Sunday, dummy.”

Catra was clearly pretending to look annoyed but Adora knew better; she'd learned exactly what the tentative bite of Catra' s incisor on her lower lip meant. And after she'd gotten Catra' s call, along with a miserable explanation of how self-conscious she'd felt at Perfuma and Scorpia's party, Adora wanted more than anything to make her feel good.

"It' s barely been two days, Cat," she said anyway , reaching out to take Catra's rucksack and swinging it over her own shoulder, "Hardly a week."

"W ell." Catra frowned, searching for a retort before she groaned petulantly, "For fuck' s sake, will you just shut up and kiss me?"

Adora couldn't hesitate if she tried - her body flew like a magnet to Catra on command, their lips meeting desperately. She'd never get over this: how their hearts always seemed to beat in sync when they united;the scrape of Catra' s fingertips in the shallows of her undercut;and how the coconut sweet scent of Catra' s shower gel swallowed her whole. If Catra were a biblical whale, Adora was willingly - *gratefully* - her prophet.

"I missed you," she said, her words ghosting Catra' s lips, "Even for two days."

"Who' s the sap now?" Catra replied.

"Me." Adora kissed her again. "Maybe."

"Definitely ."

Adora laughed when Catra pulled away from her and tugged at her hand, stretching them out like a taut elastic band, their hands interlocked over shining Salinean stone.

"Do you even know where you're going? Y ou've never been here before!"

Catra shrugged, tugging Adora further in the same direction and daring her to protest. They stumbled towards the exit, Adora capturing Catra's waist in the bend of her arm and holding her close as they walked. For a moment, she imagined that they could have had a beginning that looked like this years ago, if they hadnt been so wrenched apart by grief.

What would it have been like, Adora thought, *if instead of Catra asking me to stay, Id asked her to come?*

The thought overwhelmed her;it was impossible to imagine the life they could have lived together without sinking into the anguish of guilt and regret. The weight of countless never-lived memories and milestones they might have experienced pressed down on Adora's chest, an anvil over her sternum.

What's going on here?

Adora inhaled deeply, grounding herself in the feeling of the stone under her soles and the rough texture of Catra's denim jeans under her palm.

That's not a helpful thought, she told herself, *there's no way of knowing what could have been.*

Adora tried to silence the train of thought in her mind, but moving wholly past the ghosts of her transgressions was easier said than done. There were no guarantees that Catra would have come with her when she left Bright Moon the first time - if she'd even have wanted to follow Adora given the state of things between them back then - or if their relationship could have even survived if left to ferment between the pained, younger versions of themselves.

Would it have been as selfish then to steer both of us towards my goals, as it would be now?

"What's wrong?" Adora was shaken out of her wandering mind when she felt Catra's thumb stroking along her jaw , a gentle moving press

bringing her back to Earth, "I can tell those cogs are whirring."

"I have to tell you something," Adora's pulse spiked wildly, her heart jumping into her mouth and spilling every reckless word over her tongue in defiance of the meticulous plan she'd crafted to start this conversation, "I already spoke to my coach."

"Oh?" Catra managed to make herself sound neutral, but Adora could tell from the slight quiver of her shoulders that she felt anything but.

"Yeah. I really needed to swim when I landed on Friday and I thought it would be pretty empty at five in the morning, especially now the Commonwealth Games are done with. But he was there and... well, he thought we might as well talk about it then and there instead of waiting until tomorrow. So in the end, he kind of offered me my old spot back if I wanted in on training for the next Olympic qualifiers. Or he said if I wanted to coach, then I could do that instead, just an assistant role, obviously, but..."

Adora's frenized voice trailed off. She searched Catra's face desperately, scouring her features for reassurance that she hadn't made a grave mistake by speaking so spontaneously.

"You love coaching." Catra spoke calmly, almost like she was carefully disconnecting herself from the situation.

Maybe after last time, Adora's inner self suggested, *this is just a form of self-defence.*

"I'm not gonna do it," Adora blurted out hurriedly, squeezing Catra's elbow, "I only came back to Salineas to get my flat on the market and wrap everything else up. I want to be in Bright Moon."

Catra stepped away from Adora, her palm drifting down from her jaw to lie flat on Adora's sternum.

"You sure about that? It's not your dream anymore to try for the Olympics or, like, coach at that level?"

"I want you," Adora gulped, willing Catra to believe it as much as she did herself.

"Then ask me. Don't make the decision for me."

Don't let history repeat itself, Adora knew what Catra really meant, *not after we've come this far.*

"Would you come with me if I said yes?" Adora wasn't sure if she'd felt this nervous in years, "You don't have to, I'll turn it down if you're happy back home. I just don't want to fuck us up again, Cat, really, I can't lose us-"

"Hey, Adora," Catra squeezed Adora's hand and cut off her ramble, "Give me a chance to answer, will you?"

"Yeah," Adora practically choked on the air in her throat as she raced to stem her words, "Sorry."

Catra smiled, quirking her lip like Adora was an idiot for imagining she'd have any other response, "Don't sell the flat. Melog's gonna need somewhere to put his tree."

"Yeah?"

"Yeah."

"Yeah! Really?" Adora swept Catra off the ground, spinning her around; their shrieks of laughter attracted plenty of looks but Adora couldn't give less of a shit if she tried.

"Yes. Like I'm ever letting you go again."

SIX MONTHS AFTER

"I'm telling you, Dor , I'm going to shit myself."

Catra paced back and forth, her hands tearing clumped curls apart as they raked through her hair.

"It'll be fine," Adora tried to reassure her , "They'd be mad not to-"

"Fuck, fuck!" Catra fumbled with her phone as her ringtone blew up in her hearing aids. "They're calling."

Adora stood and moved in front of her, holding Catra's hips steady in her palms, "You've got this. I know it."

Catra nodded and exhaled with a tremble before picking up the call. The next few seconds could turn her life upside down - not that the past few months of living in Salineas hadn't already done that. Yet Catra wouldn't have imagined the little ditties Adora encouraged her to post on TikTok while she looked for a new marketing job on the coast would have brought her to this point. She'd only recorded herself singing the first song after a couple too many beers, buoyed by excitement during their first weekend living together in Adora's flat. She'd taken such pleasure - gluttonous, almost - in opening up their newly purchased piano and running her fingers over the keys, her voice pouring out of her throat unashamedly. Singing for Adora had helped her let go of her long-held inhibitions since her life with Eve had blown up; when she'd realised quite how much attention the videos she'd posted out of boredom were getting, Catra had started to wonder if she could apply the social media strategies she wrote for clients to her own account.

"Kitten," DT drawled over the phone, "I hope you've not been waiting for me to call."

"Nah, you just caught me between things," Catra let the lie roll off her tongue - she'd never really trusted DT enough to be vulnerable with them, "You got an update or what?"

"Well, there's good news and bad news." DT trailed off and Catra could envision how much fun they were having on the other side of the line, "Which do you want first?"

"Either." Catra listened out for DT's response but it didn't come. She tripped into filling the silence, temporarily losing her cool facade, "I don't know, just tell me! Bad first, I guess."

"Alright, kitten. Well, they don't want you ghostwriting for me."

Catra felt her whole body deflating in disappointment. She'd been silly, maybe, to think that after all these years out of the music industry, she could just fall into a paid gig that easily. DT was a bonafide star now, and it should have been satisfying enough that they'd unexpectedly reached out to Catra with an offer to get her on their songwriting team. But it had been so exciting, even briefly, to think she could still make music the way she used to. That the pace of her pulse could accelerate like it did when she landed on a new combination of chords and placements;and that she could finally embrace the long-lost brilliance of her music through the richness of its vibrations and not only its sound.

"What's the good news?"

"I slipped them your old demo and they want to workshop it with you instead. If they like it, they'll look at signing you."

"What? That demo's from, like, seven years ago. And I don't sing anymore."

"Don't be ridiculous, darling. You sing plenty in your little videos. Viral, aren't they?"

"That's a bit different, DT-"

Hardly. Besides, a queer deaf singer's gonna market well among the kids these days. You know that."

"That's not a good enough reason-"

DT hung up on Catra mid-sentence without a hint of goodbye. Suddenly, Adora's hands on her hips were all Catra could focus on, her mind swimming with disbelief.

"Cat? What'd they say?" Adora looked at her with anticipation and prised her mobile out of her clamped hand; Catra thought she could swim in the blue that bore into her, "Sounded kinda confusing from the outside."

"They want me to work on my own stuff."

"What?" Adora practically shouted with glee, "Catra, that's incredible!"

"But I haven't performed since before." Catra cocked her head to the side with worry, "What if I can't do it like I used to? Like if I can't hear the instrumentals properly or figure out how to follow the beat… Or if someone heckles me but I can't tell what they're saying. I'll get thrown off, or-"

"*If* there's any problems, we'll figure out what will help. But Cat, they want your voice. You. Because you're amazing, and everyone's gonna agree when they hear you."

Laughter bubbled from Catra's throat as Adora's words sunk in, giggles pouring from her uncontrollably, "Well, it's only a tiny indie label, it's not like I'm gonna be the next Taylor Swift or anything."

"A - we don't need to fight with T-Swift, there's room for more than one goddess in the charts, alright?" Adora was still laughably predictable, even after all these years.

"Okay, Swiftie, you sleeping with her or me?"

"And B," Adora continued, slapping Catra's arm playfully, "you are fucking incredible and I'm not going to let you talk this down."

"No?" Catra quirked an eyebrow at her girlfriend, leaning in close enough for Adora to feel Catra's breath on he lips before she drew away towards the bedroom, "I suppose you'll just have to convince me how *fucking incredible* I am."

"Oh," Catra loved to see Adora when she looked this flustered, irises engulfed by seas of black above the pink flush of her cheeks, "That's not hard. I c-can do that."

"Better show me then."

Catra knew what Adora was thinking long before she found herself pinned atop the bedcovers, muscular forearms planted either side of her shoulders: *challenge duly accepted* .

[illegible]R AFTER

Being back in Bright Moon was odd, especially since they couldn't even stay in Raz's house now it had been rented out.

Less strange was the softness of the grey silk blazer under Adora's hands, her palms skimming the jacket hem by Catra's hips.

"I've gotta go, Dor , I can't be late."

"Hey ," Adora leaned into the crook of Catra's neck and pressed her lips to the bergamot-perfumed skin there, "I'm invited too."

"I have no idea what you just said but it probably wasn't helpful."

Adora chuckled, kissing the seam where Catra's ear met the plane of her neck and leaning back to settle her dislodged hearing aid back into place.

"Sorry . It's just impossible to let go when you look like that."

"Pf ft. Says the blonde Adonis," Catra scof fed, before she looked up at Adora tenderly and slipped away, smacking her ass on her way out the room, "I really love you in that suit."

Adora's whole body bristled with pleasure. There was something about the way Catra's eyelids would flutter - the most imperceptible of movements - when Adora wore something that gave her true euphoria. She'd helped her find compressive sports bras that looked good under crisp button-up shirts, and loose jeans that sat just right at her hips and tucked perfectly into her Doc Martens.

"I always hoped you'd like me this way ," Adora had confessed once shyly as Catra ran buzzing clippers over her nape, "I know I don't look the way I used to."

"It' s right on you," Catra had replied instantly , her fingers mussing the golden hair scraped carefully into a bun, "So that means it' s right for me, too."

It was hard for Adora not to fantasise about all the states of undress Catra had shown to her in their Salineas home while she watched her from across the room. Sure, she'd complimented the brides profusely, gushing over the detailed embroidery on Perfuma's sleeves and the striking asymmetry of Scorpia's neckline, but she could hardly see past Catra's beauty.

"Earth to Adora," Glimmer 's voice bore into Adora's skull, but it hardly shook her from her laser focus on Catra at all, "Jesus, you're even more whipped than I thought."

Adora shrugged, tipping her glass towards Bow's as the last of the wedding toasts finally came to an end. It had been a relief, really,

that they'd been welcomed home so warmly;so far , they'd managed to avoid any conversations with Eve, and the table plans had mercifully set their places far away from any old school friends of Perfuma that Catra had been nervous to bump into. More surprising, however, was the reqest Scorpia had made to her best woman.

As familiar instrumentals seeped into the air from the wedding band, Adora's skin prickled all over with goosebumps. It always did in the seconds before Catra sang, her biceps pebbling in anticipation. And then it came, smooth and velvet and luxe, pouring over Adora's senses and taking her back in time.

Adora was her student self again, crammed in the campus bar between her teammates and desperate to qell the desire coiling in her chest.

"Oh, shit," Mermista' s qip drifted over the table, "Greyskull' s got that look in her eyes again."

"When does she not?" Glimmer jpked, and Adora let a lazy smile spread on her lips as she kept her focus on the singer;she was grateful for the ease with which she could love Catra so openly now, freed from the shackles of fear or social estrangement.

Adora loved the life they'd crafted together: slow , early morning kisses before she left to train at the gym;afternoons coaching by the poolside and confronting herself in therapy;weekends whittled away on the beach as blue skies gave way to orange and pink before dappled moonlight;evenings spent amidst smoky lights and bass-heavy amps, Catra's songs wrapping around her ears.

Now she'd reunited with her friends and former teammates, Adora realised that she'd genuinely never felt quite this content. She didn't even feel guilty for looking past Perfuma and Scorpia's first dance in favour of the stage, and she didn't care who noticed how brazenly distracted she was.



Her breath caught as Catra reached the song's chorus, her closed eyes fluttering open to land directly - miraculously - on Adora.

"I'm so proud of you," she said when the whole wedding party gathered outside to watch the fireworks and they stood close enough for Catra to hear Adora's voice above the crowd, "That song always takes me back to the start of us."

"That song?" Catra questioned her with a tease, "W as Cyndi Lauper your gay awakening?"

"Y ou know full well who my gay awakening was."

"Hmmm." Catra inched up on her tiptoes and met Adora at eye level, "That song' s not when we started, anyway. That one went a little like this..."



Catra's voice was husky in the secret cocoon they'd made for themselves, her volume tailored precisely for Adora's ears only. She was drowned out quickly by the snaps and crackles overhead and rippling gasps erupting among their fellow guests. Yet again, Adora was transported to the past;this time to furtive glances and Smirnoff Ices, and clumsy fumbles in the dark.

"Maybe it was when we were kids. Remember those new year fireworks?"she asked.

"You know I never remembered that properly. It's not fair for it to be that."

Catra turned around and pressed her back to Adora's chest, pulling Adora's arms to wrap around the waist of her suit. They were each finally where they belonged, dynamite sparking in their chests the same as it had in their teens.

"Hey , Adora,"Catra said after a while, her tone more serious than before, "I dont think I actually care about where it started anymore."

"No?"

Adora mulled over all the options as she reflected on Catra's admission. Fireworks, open mics, chocolate fondants and worn piano keys. Maybe life was too complicated to carve into moments and milestones so simply.

"I think you're right,"she said finally , pressing a kiss to the side of Catra's temple and leaning closer to her hearing aid, "The only thing that really matters is that we finally know where we're going."

Chapter End Notes

I guess that's actually it!A little open-ended, but hopefully not too much, as I honestly couldn't decide on the millions of ideas i

had in my head. I also tried very hard to deliver on some fluff, because I know these two deserved it after all that mess!Either way, I really hope you enjoyed it :)

Please do leave a comment/feedback if you're tempted as I would so appreciate hearing your thoughts on this fic now it's complete. Thank you so much for reading :)

If you'd like to read more of my fics, I'm planning on publishing the final chapter of my amnesia AU, pancakes for dinner, shortly.

Thank you again for reading this fic and spending time with me and my angsty brain ❤

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!